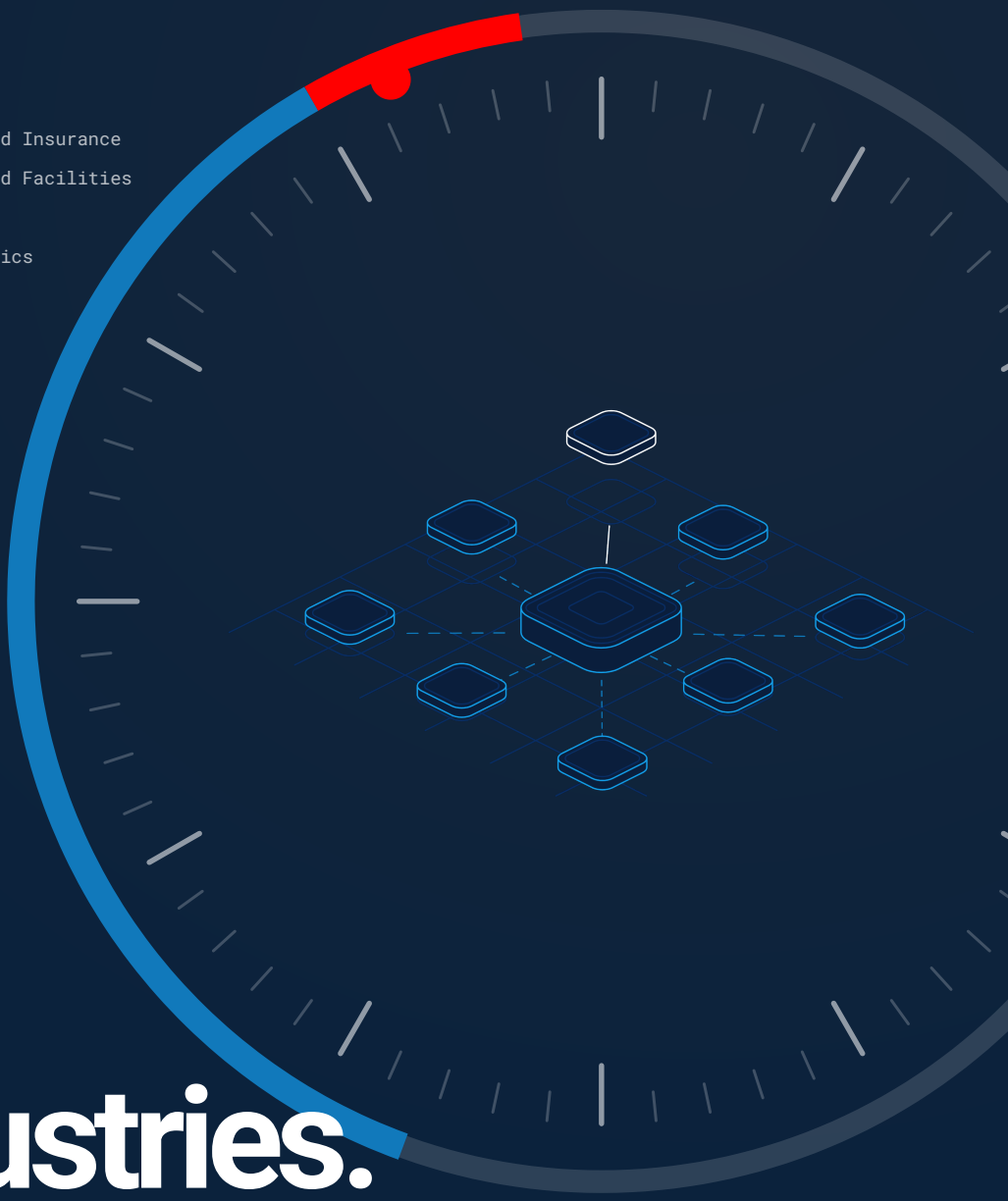
INDUSTRY SERIES · SIX WEEKS

9 NOVEMBER TO 14 DECEMBER 2026

- 9 November Financial Services and Insurance
- 16 November Property, Housing and Facilities
- 23 November Retail
- 30 November Transport and Logistics
- 7 December Hospitality
- 14 December Healthcare



6 PLAYBOOKS · 6 REPORTS

Six industries. One plan.

A crisis playbook and an intelligence report for each focus industry, one week at a time.

9 Nov · 16 Nov · 23 Nov · 30 Nov · 7 Dec · 14 Dec

THE SCHEDULE

One industry a week.

Each week pairs a practical crisis playbook with an evidence-based intelligence report. Page numbers refer to this combined edition.

WEEK 1
9 November

Financial Services and Insurance

PLAYBOOK Within tolerance p. 003
REPORT Resilience, regulated p. 032

WEEK 2
16 November

Property, Housing and Facilities

PLAYBOOK Every resident reached p. 059
REPORT Safe homes, clear duties p. 088

WEEK 3
23 November

Retail

PLAYBOOK Keep the shutters up p. 116
REPORT When the tills go dark p. 145

WEEK 4
30 November

Transport and Logistics

PLAYBOOK Keep it moving p. 173
REPORT The Heathrow lesson p. 202

WEEK 5
7 December

Hospitality

PLAYBOOK Ready for Martyn's Law p. 228
REPORT The protect duty p. 257

WEEK 6
14 December

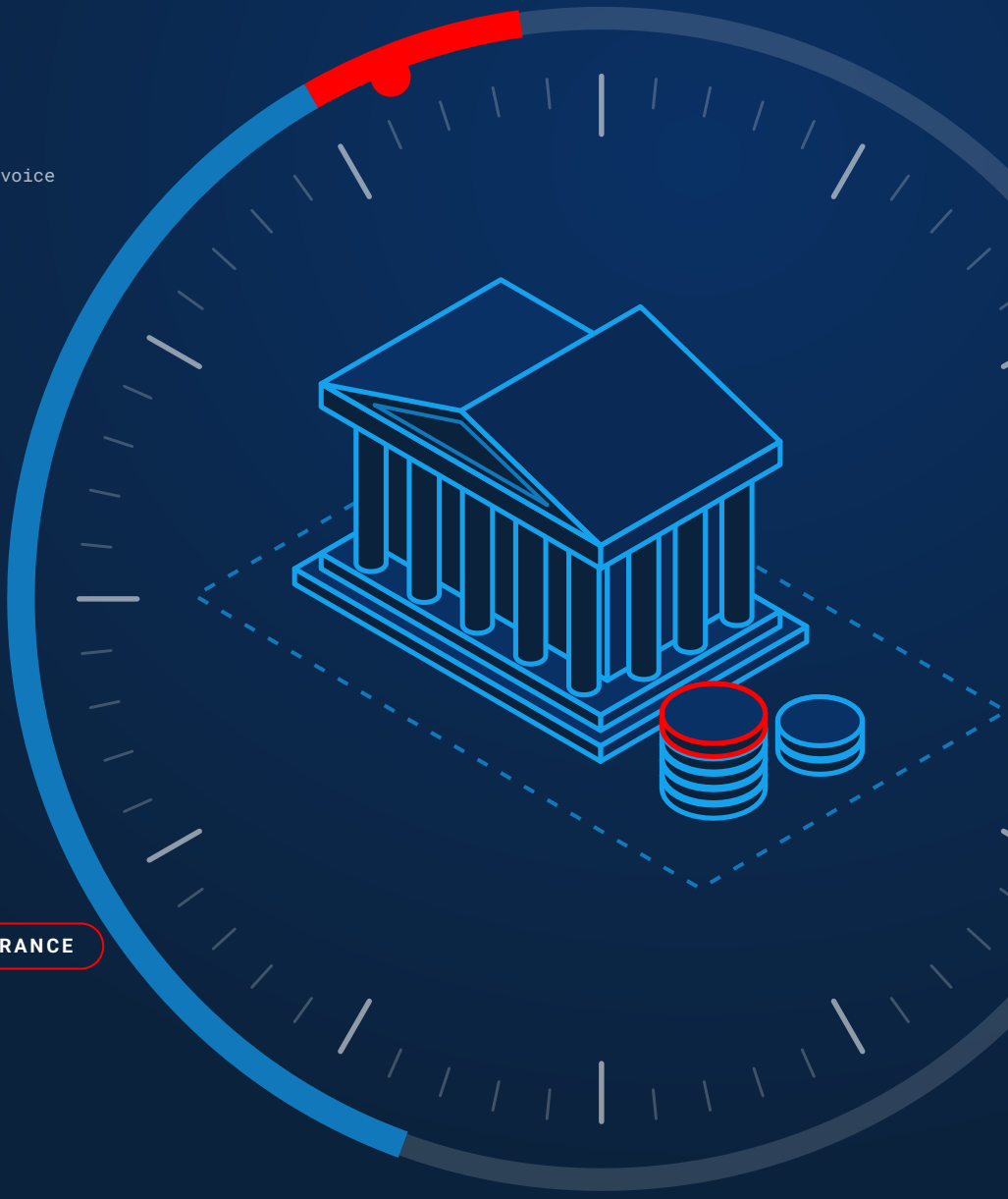
Healthcare

PLAYBOOK Major incident, minute one p. 283
REPORT When the lab went dark p. 312

CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 01

WEEK OF 9 NOVEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



FINANCIAL SERVICES AND INSURANCE

Within tolerance.

A crisis playbook for banks, insurers, payment and investment firms. What to do in the first hour of a severe disruption, how to communicate when email and chat are down, and how to prove you can stay within your impact tolerances.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

Contents

A practical crisis playbook for banks, insurers, payment and investment firms: how to keep important business services within tolerance on the worst day, run the first hour, talk to customers and regulators when normal channels fail, and gather the evidence a board and a supervisor will ask for.

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FOREWORD

Resilience on paper met a real morning on 20 October 2026.

At 06:53 BST on Tuesday 20 October 2026, the utility feed to a data centre hosting europe-west2-b, one of Google Cloud's London zones, failed. A second feed was switched out for repairs, and a control system fault stopped the backup generators from starting. When the batteries ran out at 07:00, servers in the zone lost power. Google's incident report puts the main impact across the London region at six hours and eight minutes.[1]

Customers of Lloyds, HSBC and Revolut reported problems with apps, payments and cash withdrawals that morning.[2,3] The FCA said it was engaging with Google, and the Treasury Committee wrote to the Bank of England and the FCA for details.[2] Google Cloud had been designated a critical third party to the UK financial sector just fourteen weeks earlier.[4]

Since 31 March 2025, UK banks, insurers, payment firms and many investment firms have been expected to show they can remain within impact tolerances for each important business service.[5] This playbook is about the practical side of that duty: the first hour, the messages, the suppliers and the evidence. Our companion intelligence report sets out the regulation and the record in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three questions decide how your worst day goes.

Regulators do not expect firms to prevent every disruption. They expect firms to know which services matter most, how much disruption customers and markets can bear, and how they will stay inside that limit when something fails.

Do we know what matters?

Important business services named, impact tolerances set and approved by the board, and every service mapped to the people, systems and suppliers it relies on.

Can we act in minutes?

A severity ladder everyone uses, a first-hour plan with named owners, and a way to reach the response team that does not depend on the systems that have failed.

Can we prove it?

Severe but plausible scenarios tested, communications included, and the timings, decisions and lessons recorded so the self-assessment stands up to challenge.

Resilience is measured on the customer's clock, not the supplier's.

A cloud provider can restore its service on its own timetable. Your impact tolerance keeps running from the moment your customers cannot pay, be paid or claim.

PART 01

Know your limits.

Before a crisis, decide which services matter most and how much disruption is too much.

01 Services, tolerances and mapping

02 Important business services by firm type

03 A severity ladder for financial services

KNOW YOUR LIMITS

Important business services and impact tolerances, in plain terms

> **A tolerance is the point at which harm becomes intolerable. Recovery targets should sit well inside it.**

The UK operational resilience rules, set out by the FCA in PS21/3 and by the PRA in SS1/21, ask a firm to look at itself from the outside in. An important business service is one that, if disrupted, could cause intolerable harm to customers or risk to market integrity, or for the PRA threaten the firm's safety and soundness or financial stability.[5,6]

For each one, the firm sets an impact tolerance: the maximum tolerable level of disruption. The PRA requires every tolerance to include a time metric, says it applies at peak times as well as normal ones, and expects firms to stay within it in severe but plausible scenarios, whether or not a third party delivers part of the service.[6]

The deadline mattered. Rules came into force on 31 March 2022, and by 31 March 2025 firms had to have done the mapping and testing to remain within tolerance, and made the investments to operate consistently within it.[5]

In March 2026, reviewing annual self-assessments, the FCA saw progress: clearer methods, annual reviews and some non-time metrics such as transaction volumes. It also found firms not setting distinct tolerances for consumer harm and market integrity, and mapping that focused mainly on technology.[7]

A tolerance is not a recovery time objective. It is the point at which harm becomes intolerable, so recovery targets usually sit well inside it. If your recovery plan only just fits within the tolerance, the plan is the risk.

The practical test is simple. Pick any important business service and ask three people to name its tolerance, its top three dependencies and who declares an incident. If the answers differ, start there.

ILLUSTRATIVE SERVICES

What an important business service looks like

Examples only. Each firm must identify its own services and justify its own tolerances.

FIRM TYPE	EXAMPLE SERVICE	TOLERANCE METRICS TO CONSIDER	HIDDEN DEPENDENCY
Retail bank	Making a payment from a current account	Hours of disruption at peak, number of customers and value of payments affected	Card processor, cloud region, fraud engine
Insurer	Making and paying a motor or home claim	Days to first contact and payment, with extra weight in a storm or flood	Claims platform supplier, contact centre telephony
Payments and e-money	Card authorisation and access to funds	Minutes of failed authorisations, share of transactions declined	Scheme connection, issuer processor, single hosting zone
Investment firm	Placing and settling client orders	Orders missed or delayed in market hours, settlement fails	Order management SaaS, market data, custodian links
Building society	Mortgage completion on the agreed day	Completions missed, with tolerance tightest at month end	Payment scheme access, conveyancer portal

SEVERITY

A severity ladder for financial services

Agree the triggers in advance so nobody debates the level while customers wait. If in doubt, declare higher and step down.

SEV 1

Critical

TRIGGERS

An important business service is down or badly degraded and its impact tolerance is at risk. Customers cannot pay, be paid, reach cash or make a claim. Data integrity in doubt, or a suspected cyber attack on core systems.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Crisis team, executive on call, regulatory lead and communications lead. Board chair informed.

`Push, SMS, voice call · escalate after 5 minutes`

SEV 2

Major

TRIGGERS

An important business service is degraded but a tested workaround is holding. One channel is down, such as the app but not cards. A material supplier declares an incident.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Incident team, service owners, supplier manager. Communications lead on standby.

`Push and SMS · bridge opened`

SEV 3

Moderate

TRIGGERS

Internal system failure with little or no customer impact. Failover worked as designed. Elevated error rates under investigation.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Technology on call and the service owner.

`Push and email`

SEV 4

Watch

TRIGGERS

Supplier advisory, risky change window, severe weather warning or a peak day such as payday or month end ahead.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager logs it and briefs the next shift.

`Email and incident log`

PART 02

The first hour.

What happens in the first sixty minutes decides whether you stay within tolerance.

01 A T+ timeline for a cloud outage

02 When email and chat are down too

03 Messages for customers, staff and regulators

FIRST HOUR

Cloud outage at 07:00

A bank or payment firm whose app and cards depend on one cloud region. Owners are roles.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Alarms and complaints arrive together** Monitoring shows failed card authorisations and app logins as the contact centre and social channels light up.	DUTY INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:05	**Declare and page out of band** Declare SEV1 provisionally. Page the team by SMS and voice, not email or chat, which may share the failed dependency.	DUTY INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:10	**Open the bridge, start the clock** Assign leads and a scribe. Record which important business services are hit, and when.	INCIDENT LEAD
T+00:15	**Call the provider, do not wait for it** Raise a priority case. On 20 October the first public update came about two and a half hours after impact began.[1]	SUPPLIER LEAD
T+00:30	**First word to customers** Holding message on the website, app and social channels. Contact centre script live. Flag customers who need urgent help.	COMMUNICATIONS LEAD
T+00:45	**Decide on failover** Invoke the tested move to another zone or region, or manual workarounds. Protect data integrity above speed.	TECHNOLOGY LEAD
T+01:00	**Tell the supervisor** Early call to FCA and PRA supervisors. Payment firms must report a major incident within 4 hours of detecting it.[8]	REGULATORY LEAD

OUT OF BAND

When email and chat go down with everything else

> **Out-of-band means a route that shares no critical dependency with the systems that have failed.**

The FCA's March 2026 review found firms often had not considered in detail the alternatives or workarounds when their usual communication channels are unavailable, and little evidence that communications strategies are tested in scenario exercises.[7]

In a cloud or identity outage, the tools a firm uses to coordinate may be the first casualties. If email, chat, the intranet and the incident ticketing system all sign in through the same identity provider or sit in the same cloud region, the response team cannot reach each other at the moment they most need to.

Out-of-band means a route that shares no critical dependency with the systems that have failed. In practice that is a combination: a mass notification service hosted separately from your estate, SMS and voice to personal and work mobiles, a fixed conference bridge with numbers printed in the plan, and an offline copy of contact lists and runbooks.

Test it the way it would fail. Run an exercise in which email and chat are declared unavailable for the first two hours. Measure how long it takes to reach the full response team, how many acknowledge, and who you could not reach at all.

The same thinking applies to customers. If the app is the channel that is down, the app banner cannot carry the message. Agree in advance which channels carry customer updates when the main one fails: the website status page, social accounts, SMS, branch staff, and the contact centre's recorded message.

Finally, keep the regulator's contact details outside your normal systems. A supervisor's mobile number in a locked mailbox helps nobody.

TEMPLATES

Six messages ready to send

Fill the brackets with confirmed facts only. Agree sign-off rules in advance so messages are not held up.

SMS · RESPONSE TEAM

142 chars

> SEV1 declared 07:05. Cards and app down. Join bridge now: [number] PIN [pin]. Do not use email or Teams. Reply 1 to confirm, 2 if unavailable.

No reply in 5 minutes: call the deputy.

SMS · BRANCH AND CONTACT CENTRE

132 chars

> Cards and app disrupted. Use script v3. Don't speculate on cause. Log customers who need urgent cash or payments. Next brief [time].

APP BANNER AND WEB · CUSTOMERS

> Some customers can't use our app or cards right now. We're working to fix this and will update you here by [time]. Sorry for the disruption.

Say money is safe only once confirmed.

EMAIL · CRITICAL SUPPLIER

> SEV1 affecting [service] since [time]. Within 15 minutes please confirm scope, your reference, a named engineer, an ETA and any workaround.

Copy the contract owner.

EMAIL AND PHONE · FCA AND PRA SUPERVISORS

> Since [time] an operational incident has affected [service]. Likely cause: third-party cloud disruption. Customers affected: about [n]. Tolerance [x] hours, [y] elapsed. Next update [time]. Contact: [name, mobile].

Formal reports follow the rules that apply.

STATEMENT · MEDIA HOLDING LINE

> We're aware some customers are having difficulty using our app and cards. We're working to restore services as quickly as possible and will update our website. We apologise to those affected.

No supplier or cause until confirmed.

CUSTOMERS AND REGULATORS

Telling customers and regulators: what good looks like

Most criticism after an outage is about silence and confusion, not the fault itself.

MOMENT	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
First 30 minutes	Silence while engineers diagnose the problem.	A holding message on every channel you still control, within 30 minutes.
Supervisors	First call made only once the cause is known.	An early heads-up, then formal reports to the clock. From 18 March 2027 most firms report within 24 hours of determining that a threshold is met.[8]
Vulnerable customers	One generic message for everyone.	Priority help for those who cannot reach cash, pay rent or complete a purchase that day.
Cause	Early speculation, or blaming a supplier.	Say what you know and what customers should do. Name the cause only when confirmed.
Updates	Irregular, and only when there is news.	A fixed cadence, such as every 60 minutes, even when nothing has changed.
Afterwards	Close quietly and move on.	Explain what happened, put right any financial loss and share the lessons.

PART 03

Prove it.

Map what you depend on, test the severe days and keep the evidence a board can rely on.

01 Where concentration hides

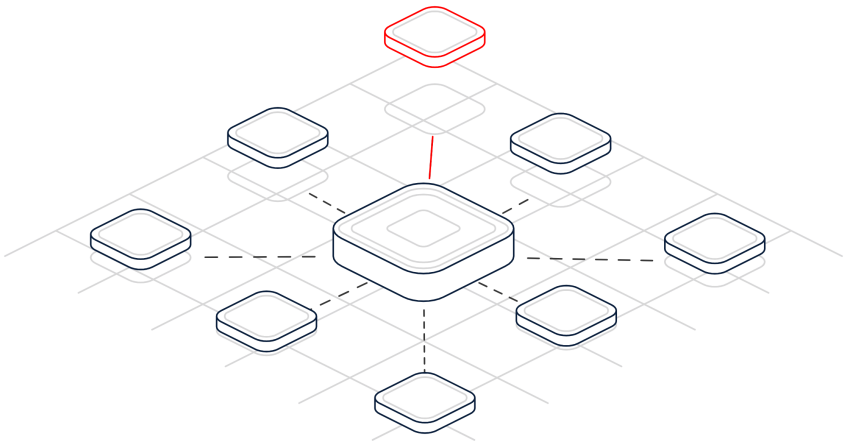
02 Three scenarios to test

03 Evidence and your 90-day plan

CONCENTRATION

Four places concentration hides

The UK designated four cloud providers as critical third parties in July 2026. Regulated firms remain responsible for managing their own third-party arrangements.[4,9]



01 One region, one zone

Services described as resilient may still run in a single zone, or rely on regional control systems that a zone failure can disrupt.

02 Shared tooling

Email, chat, identity and incident tooling often sit with the same provider as production. One outage removes both the service and the means to coordinate.

03 Your suppliers' suppliers

A claims platform or core banking SaaS may run in the same cloud region you chose to avoid.

04 Payments chains and people

Processors, scheme connections and fraud engines need tested alternatives. So do key teams working from a single site.

SCENARIOS

Three severe days to rehearse

RETAIL BANK

A cloud zone fails at 07:00 on payday

THE DISRUPTION

App, card payments and online transfers degrade across the region, not just the failed zone.

THE FIRST HOUR

SEV1 by SMS and voice, bridge open, customer holding message by T+00:30, supervisor called by T+01:00.

THE TEST

Fail over to another region in a live-like environment and time it against the tolerance.

WATCH OUT

Corporate email and chat run in the same region. Run the exercise without them.

PAYMENTS AND E-MONEY FIRM

Card processor outage on Black Friday

THE DISRUPTION

Authorisations fail for 40 minutes at peak, leaving customers stuck at tills.

THE FIRST HOUR

Switch to the standby route, push in-app guidance, report within 4 hours.

THE TEST

Prove the standby route carries peak volume, not just a test transaction.

WATCH OUT

Fraud rules may block legitimate payments once traffic moves.

GENERAL INSURER

Claims supplier hit by ransomware during a storm

THE DISRUPTION

The claims platform is offline as storm claims peak.

THE FIRST HOUR

Manual intake script, longer contact centre hours, brokers and supervisor told.

THE TEST

Run a week of claims by hand in a tabletop and count what breaks.

WATCH OUT

A data breach brings separate notification duties.

TESTING AND EVIDENCE

Test the severe days, then write it down

What the FCA's review of 2025 self-assessments rewards, turned into six steps.

01 Choose scenarios that could break you

Vary the nature, severity and duration. The FCA questions self-assessments that claim no scenario could defeat the firm without severe testing to show it.[7]

02 Include communications in every test

Declare email and chat unavailable. Time how long it takes to reach the team, the customer channels and the supervisor.

03 Run the tolerance clock

Record the start, each decision and the point of recovery against the tolerance for every affected service.

04 Plan for a breach

Where a scenario would breach a tolerance, document the longer-term remediation plan, with owners and dates.[7]

05 Make the self-assessment decision-ready

Add confidence ratings, second and third line input, and a clear ask of the board, which must review and approve it.[6,7]

06 Learn from real incidents

Use 20 October as a case study. Map which of your services would have been hit, and how you would have known.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Check that the response team can be reached without corporate email or chat. Print the bridge number and supervisor contacts into the plan.	Head of resilience
This week	List every important business service that depends on a single cloud region or zone, including through suppliers.	CIO or CTO
This month	Agree the severity ladder and first-hour roles. Load the six message templates and their sign-off rules.	Head of resilience, communications lead
This month	Ask material suppliers how they notify you, how fast, and where their own dependencies sit.	Third-party risk lead
This quarter	Run a severe scenario with communications channels unavailable. Time it against tolerance and record the evidence.	Head of resilience
This quarter	Map incident reporting to the FCA and PRA rules that apply from 18 March 2027, and to DORA for EU entities.	Chief risk officer, compliance

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your executive committee

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

READINESS

- ? If our cloud region failed at 07:00 tomorrow, which important business services would breach tolerance first?
- ? Could we reach the whole response team in ten minutes without email or chat?
- ? Who is authorised to send the first customer message, and how fast?

EVIDENCE

- ? Which scenario in our last test came closest to breaching a tolerance, and what are we doing about it?
- ? Did our last test include communications, suppliers and the supervisor call?
- ? Would our self-assessment convince a sceptical board member?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready to stay within tolerance?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Important business services and tolerances approved by the board**
  Reviewed in the last twelve months or after material change.

- [ ] **Every service mapped to people, systems and suppliers**
  Including the cloud region and zone, and key fourth parties.

- [ ] **Severity ladder agreed and out-of-band alerting tested**
  The team reachable without corporate email, chat or single sign-on.

- [ ] **Message templates loaded**
  For customers, staff, supervisors, suppliers and the media, with sign-off rules.

- [ ] **Regulatory reporting clocks known**
  Current rules, PSP four-hour reports, the 2027 regime and DORA where relevant.

- [ ] **Severe scenario tested this year**
  With communications included and timings recorded against tolerance.

- [ ] **Self-assessment evidence ready**
  Confidence ratings, remediation owners and second line challenge.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Important business service
A service provided to an external user which, if disrupted, could cause intolerable harm or risk to the firm or the wider system.

Impact tolerance
The maximum tolerable level of disruption to an important business service, always including a time metric.

Mapping
Identifying the people, processes, technology, facilities and information that support each important business service.

Severe but plausible scenario
A demanding but realistic disruption used to test whether a firm can stay within tolerance.

Self-assessment
The written record of a firm's compliance with the resilience rules, reviewed and approved by the board.

Critical third party
A provider designated by HM Treasury whose services, if disrupted, could threaten UK financial stability or confidence.

Availability zone
An isolated location within a cloud region, with its own power and networking.

Out-of-band
A communication route that does not rely on the systems affected by the incident.

DORA
The EU Digital Operational Resilience Act, applying to EU financial entities from 17 January 2025.

Material third party arrangement
A supplier arrangement whose disruption could seriously affect a firm, which must be notified and registered under the 2027 regime.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When a cloud region fails at 07:00, sending the alert is the easy part. Staying within impact tolerance depends on who acknowledged, which workarounds started, what customers and supervisors were told, and whether you can prove it all afterwards.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits

Seven steps in this playbook, and the modules that support them. Crises Control supports your plan; it does not replace it.

Page the response team by SMS, voice and push when email and chat are down, and escalate to deputies when nobody acknowledges.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Run one workspace per incident, with the bridge, decision log and approved message templates in one place.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
Turn failover and manual workaround runbooks into tasks with owners, deadlines and escalation.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
Watch tasks, communications and escalations live against the tolerance clock for each affected service.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Keep timestamped timelines as evidence for supervisors, the post-incident review and the self-assessment.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.
Let branch and frontline staff raise an urgent issue with their location in one touch.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Draft role-specific updates for customers, staff and supervisors, then review before sending.	**CRAiG** AI assistant (beta) that drafts role-specific messages, translates and summarises.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your financial services organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Incident team, executives and key suppliers reached by push, SMS and voice when email is down.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement tracked against each important business service; no response escalates in minutes.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation tied to impact tolerance thresholds, not to individual memory.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by IT, operations, communications and compliance.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Workaround and recovery steps for each important business service run as owned tasks.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of services, tasks and teams that the executive can read without a briefing.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that supports self-assessment and regulator questions, produced on request.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Severe but plausible scenarios rehearsed end to end, including the loss of usual channels.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own financial services scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A cloud or payments outage that pushes an important business service towards its impact tolerance.

02 A cyber incident that takes out email and chat, so you need out-of-band coordination.

03 A critical supplier failure that you must manage, report and evidence.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

+44 (0) 20 8584 1385

contactus@crises-control.com

www.crises-control.com

Request a demo

SOURCES

Sources and notes

Sources were accessed in November 2026. Scenarios, templates and timings in this playbook are illustrative and should be adapted to your firm.

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Stay within tolerance on the worst day.

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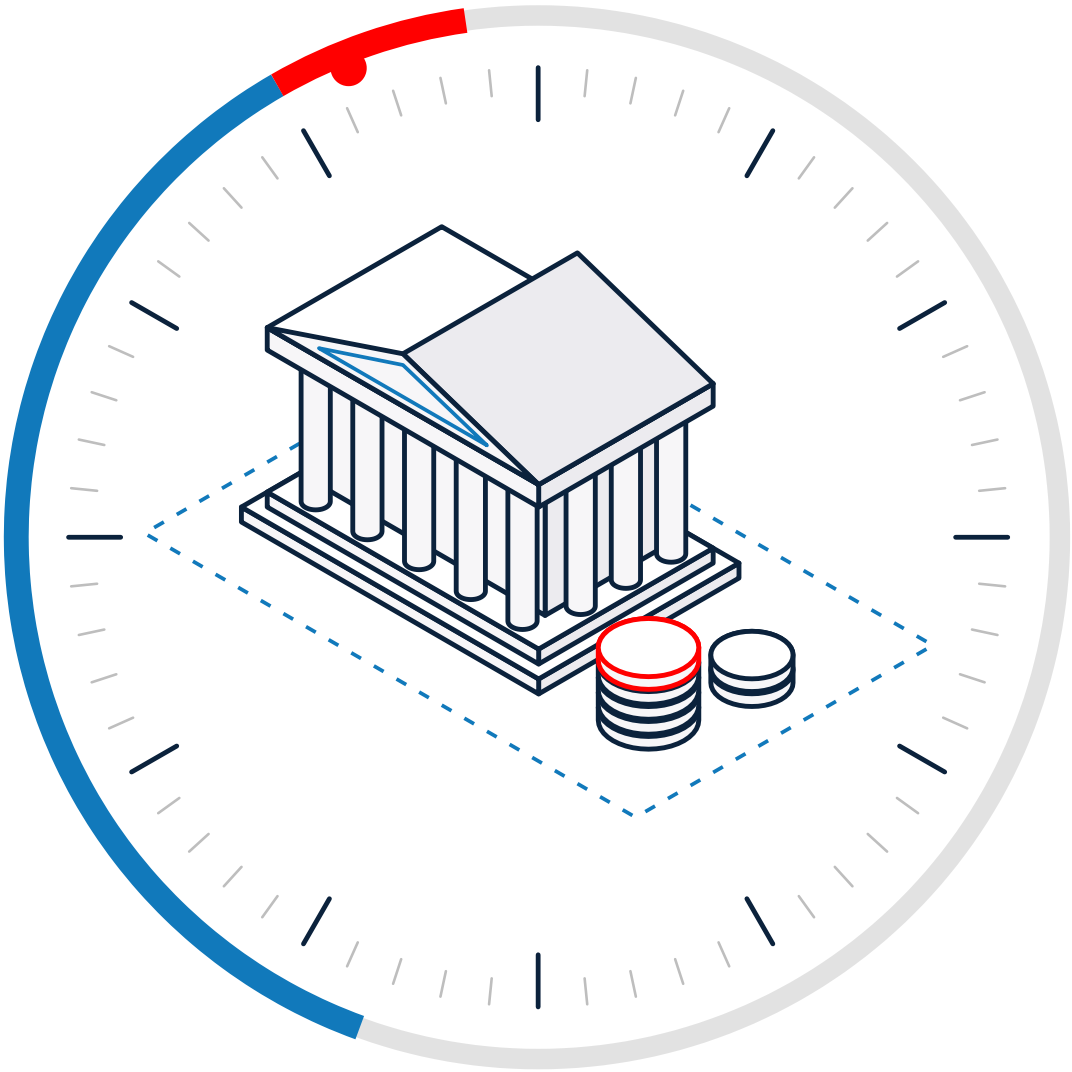
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Intelligence report No. 01 · Resilience, regulated



FINANCIAL SERVICES AND INSURANCE · OPERATIONAL RESILIENCE

Resilience, regulated.

The impact tolerance deadline has passed, four cloud providers are now overseen as critical third parties, and a six-hour outage in London tested both. What the evidence shows, and what UK financial firms should do now.

INSIDE

Contents

An evidence-based look at UK operational resilience regulation for banks, insurers, payment and investment firms: what the rules require, what the 20 October 2026 Google Cloud outage revealed, and what boards should do next.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The rules now assume disruption will happen. The question is whether firms can prove they stay within tolerance.

On 20 October 2026 a power failure at a data centre hosting europe-west2-b, one of Google Cloud's London zones, disrupted services across the region for six hours and eight minutes, according to Google's final incident report.[1] Customers of Lloyds, HSBC and Revolut reported problems with apps, payments and cash withdrawals.[2,3]

The outage landed in a regulatory regime that had just matured. Since 31 March 2025 UK banks, insurers, payment firms and other in-scope firms have been expected to remain within impact tolerances for each important business service.[4] In July 2026 HM Treasury designated Google Cloud EMEA, Amazon Web Services EMEA, Microsoft Ireland Operations and Oracle Corporation UK as critical third parties.[5] From 18 March 2027 new FCA and PRA incident and third-party reporting rules apply.[6,7]

The FCA's review of 2025 self-assessments found progress, but also communications strategies rarely tested in exercises and few workarounds for losing usual channels.[8] Its own data shows retail banks reported 446 major operational incidents in 2025.[9]

This report sets out what the rules require, what the October outage shows about concentration and redundancy, and what boards in financial services and insurance should ask for now.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Oversight of cloud providers does not move responsibility. Each firm must still show, with evidence, that its important business services stay within tolerance when a critical supplier fails, and that it can reach staff, customers and supervisors when its usual channels are down.

KEY FINDINGS

Seven things the evidence tells us

01 The deadline has passed. Supervisors now want evidence.

Firms had until 31 March 2025 to be able to remain within tolerance. The FCA is now reviewing annual self-assessments and questioning claims not backed by severe testing.[4,8]

02 Communications are a weak link.

The FCA found limited evidence that communications strategies are tested in scenario exercises, and little detail on workarounds when usual channels are unavailable.[8]

03 A zone failure became a regional problem.

Google reports that demand surges on neighbouring zones and control plane dependencies spread impact beyond europe-west2-b.[1]

04 Redundancy failed in combination.

One utility feed was out for repairs, the other failed, and a control system fault stopped generators starting before batteries ran out.[1]

05 Concentration is now overseen, but responsibility is not transferred.

Regulators say firms remain responsible for managing their own third-party arrangements under the critical third parties regime.[10]

06 Reporting is getting faster and more uniform.

From March 2027 most FCA firms report within 24 hours of meeting a threshold; payment firms keep a 4-hour clock; DORA sets 4 and 24 hours.[6,11]

07 IT failures are routine, not rare.

Retail banks reported 446 major operational incidents to the FCA in 2025, led by change management and third-party failure.[9]

AT A GLANCE

Operational resilience in six figures

Each figure is sourced. Where sources measure different things, we say so in the analysis that follows.

6h 08m

Duration of the main impact across Google Cloud's London region on 20 October 2026.[1]

38

Google Cloud products listed as affected on the incident's status page.[1]

446

Major operational incidents reported to the FCA by retail banks in 2025.[9]

803 hours

Unplanned outages at nine major banks and building societies, January 2023 to February 2025.[12]

Over 40%

Share of cyber incidents reported to the FCA in 2025 that involved a third party.[13]

4

Cloud providers designated as critical third parties by HM Treasury, effective 13 July 2026.[5,14]

TIMELINE

From policy to a real test

Key dates in UK and EU operational resilience regulation, and the October 2026 outage.

29 March 2021 — **UK rules published**
The FCA publishes PS21/3 and the PRA SS1/21. Rules apply from 31 March 2022.[4,15]

1 January 2025 — **CTP regime in force**
Rules for critical third parties take effect, ready for any designation by HM Treasury.[10]

17 January 2025 — **DORA applies**
EU financial entities must report major ICT-related incidents under DORA.[16]

31 January 2025 — **Barclays outage**
Some customers lose access to services for up to three days, prompting Treasury Committee letters to banks.[12]

31 March 2025 — **Transition ends**
Firms must be able to remain within impact tolerances for each important business service.[4]

18 November 2025 — **EU names critical providers**
The European Supervisory Authorities designate critical ICT providers, including Google Cloud EMEA.[17]

18 March 2026 — **Reporting rules final**
FCA PS26/2 and PRA PS7/26 set incident and third-party reporting rules, applying from 18 March 2027.[6,7]

13 July 2026 — **First UK designations**
AWS, Google Cloud, Microsoft and Oracle come under direct oversight.[5,14]

20 October 2026 — **London cloud outage**
A power failure in europe-west2-b disrupts services across the region; banks report customer impact.[1,2]

PART 01

The rules.

Four overlapping regimes now shape how financial firms prepare for, report and recover from disruption.

01 The UK regime four years on

02 Who must do what

03 Two reporting clocks

THE RULES

The UK regime, four years on

> **Some self-assessments claimed no scenario could defeat the firm, without severe testing to prove it.**

The UK approach, set out by the FCA in PS21/3 and the PRA in SS1/21, applies to banks, building societies, PRA-designated investment firms, insurers, recognised investment exchanges, enhanced scope SM&CR firms and payment and e-money firms.[4] It asks each firm to identify its important business services, set an impact tolerance for each, map what supports them and test against severe but plausible scenarios.[4,15]

The PRA is specific about tolerances. Each must include a time metric, applies at peak times as well as normal ones, and must hold whether or not a third party delivers part of the service. The board approves the services, the tolerances and the written self-assessment.[15]

By 31 March 2025 firms had to have performed mapping and testing so they could remain within tolerance, and made the investments needed to operate consistently within it.[4]

In March 2026 the FCA published what it found in firms' self-assessments. Good practice included annual reviews, non-time metrics such as transaction volumes and testing that covers cyber attacks and third-party failures. Weaknesses included tolerances that did not separate consumer harm from market integrity, mapping focused mainly on technology, and more work to do on third-party vulnerabilities.[8]

On communications, the FCA restated that firms must maintain an internal and external strategy that delivers clear, timely and relevant messaging. It found limited evidence of that strategy being tested, and firms not considering in detail what to do when usual channels are unavailable.[8]

It also challenged confidence. Some self-assessments stated there was no scenario the firm could not recover from, without evidence from sufficiently severe testing.[8]

AT A GLANCE

Who must do what

A simplified summary. Read the rules themselves for scope and detail.

REGIME	WHAT IT REQUIRES	STATUS
Operational resilience (FCA PS21/3, PRA SS1/21)	Important business services, impact tolerances, mapping, scenario testing, communications strategy, board-approved self-assessment.[4,15]	In force since 31 March 2022; tolerance deadline 31 March 2025.
Critical third parties	Designated providers are overseen on the critical services they provide to the sector. Firms remain responsible for their own arrangements.[10]	Rules from 1 January 2025; first designations from 13 July 2026.
Incident and third-party reporting (FCA PS26/2, PRA PS7/26)	One incident definition, thresholds, staged reports, notification of material third-party arrangements and an annual register.[6,7]	Published 18 March 2026; applies from 18 March 2027.
Current incident notification	Firms report incidents under SUP 15.3 and Principle 11. Payment service providers report major operational or security incidents within 4 hours of detection.[6,9]	In force now. New regime from 18 March 2027; the 4-hour PSP clock continues.
EU DORA	ICT risk management, crisis communication plans, major incident reporting, register of information on ICT providers.[11,18]	Applies from 17 January 2025 to EU financial entities, including UK groups' EU subsidiaries.

REPORTING CLOCKS

Two reporting clocks to plan for

Firms with EU entities may need to run both. Times are maximums; regulators expect reports as soon as practicable.

STAGE	UK FCA, FROM 18 MARCH 2027	EU DORA, NOW
Trigger	The incident meets one or more thresholds: intolerable consumer harm, market integrity, or safety and soundness.[6]	The ICT-related incident is classified as major.[11]
Initial report	As soon as practicable and at most within 24 hours of determining a threshold is met. Payment service providers: within 4 hours of first detecting.[6]	Within 4 hours of classification as major, and no later than 24 hours from becoming aware.[11]
Updates	Enhanced reporting firms give material updates as the incident develops.[6]	Intermediate report within 72 hours of the initial notification.[11]
Final report	Enhanced firms: within 30 working days of resolution, 60 at the latest.[6]	No later than one month after the latest intermediate report.[11]
Third parties	Notify new or significantly changed material arrangements; submit a register annually.[6]	Maintain a register of information on all ICT service arrangements.[17]

PART 02

The outage.

On 20 October 2026 one London data centre lost power. What happened next is a case study in concentration and redundancy.

01 What Google's report says

02 How one zone became a region

03 A pattern, not a one-off

THE OUTAGE

What happened on 20 October

> **The control system read live voltage on a disconnected feed and decided mains power was healthy.**

Google's final incident report, published on 4 November 2026, is unusually detailed. The facility hosting europe-west2-b had two utility feeds. Feed B had been switched out for repairs after problems found in a generator load test on 14 October, so feed A carried the whole load.[1]

At 06:53 BST an underground cable fault outside the site cut feed A. The control system that should have started the backup generators read live voltage on the isolated feed B and concluded mains power was healthy, so it never sent the start signal. Batteries carried the load for their roughly five minutes of runtime, and at 07:00 servers, storage and network equipment in the zone lost power.[1]

Engineers restored power from a standby utility source by 08:20, but storage that had shut down uncleanly needed lengthy recovery. Platform services were fully available at 12:11 and most customer workloads at 13:08, six hours and eight minutes after impact began.[1]

The impact did not stay in one zone. Google says demand surges on the other two London zones and control plane dependencies across zone boundaries caused unexpected impact for customers running in unaffected zones or across the region.[1]

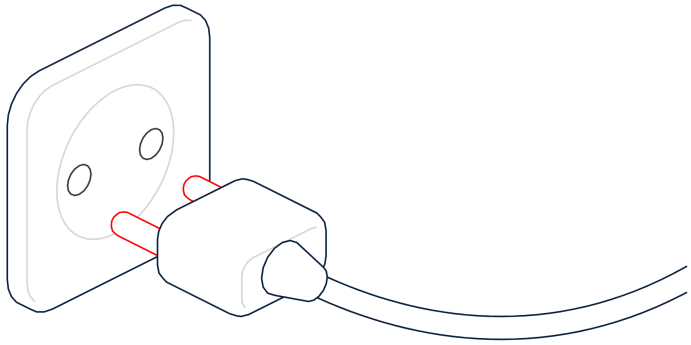
Customers of Revolut reported problems with card payments, transfers and cash withdrawals; Lloyds and HSBC said some customers had difficulties. Revolut said customers' money and data were safe.[2,3] The FCA said it was engaging with Google, the European Banking Authority sought information, and the Treasury Committee wrote to the Bank of England and the FCA.[3]

Google's own action list includes a communications item: to bolster notification speed with an automated alert-to-communication mechanism. The earliest update in its published incident history is timestamped 09:35 BST, about two and a half hours after impact began.[1]

HOW IT SPREAD

From one feed to a whole region

The sequence as Google's incident report describes it. Times are BST on 20 October 2026.



01 **Two feeds become one**

Feed B is out for repairs, so feed A alone supplies the site. At 06:53 a cable fault cuts it.[1]

02 **Generators never start**

Sensors read voltage on the isolated feed, so no start signal is sent. Batteries run out and the zone goes dark at 07:00.[1]

03 **Failover overloads neighbours**

Workloads shift to the other London zones, saturating capacity and producing errors across the region.[1]

04 **Recovery takes hours, not minutes**

Power returns by 08:20, but storage recovery and controlled re-admission run until 13:08.[1]

LESSONS

What failed, and the lesson for financial firms

Each failure point in Google's report has a parallel in a firm's own resilience plan.

FAILURE POINT	WHAT GOOGLE REPORTS	LESSON FOR FIRMS
Planned maintenance	A temporary single-feed posture while repairs were made.[1]	Treat maintenance windows at critical suppliers as periods of higher risk, and ask to be told about them.
Untested automation	A control system misconfiguration stopped generators starting.[1]	Test failover end to end, including the parts you assume will work automatically.
Zone versus region	Demand surges and control plane dependencies spread impact beyond the failed zone.[1]	Do not assume multi-zone means resilient. Map regional dependencies and test a full regional loss.
Recovery time	Storage recovery meant hours between power returning and service.[1]	Set recovery assumptions from real incidents, not from supplier marketing.
Notification speed	Google lists faster automated customer notification as an action.[1]	Detect impact with your own monitoring. Do not wait for a status page.

THE PATTERN

A pattern, not a one-off

> **Rare combinations happen. Every firm relying on one region needs to know what its customers experience when they do.**

October was not the first time technology failure has stopped customers paying or being paid. In early 2025 Barclays customers lost access to some services for up to three days from 31 January, the self-assessment tax deadline. Barclays told the Treasury Committee that 56% of online payments failed during the incident, and expected to pay between £5 million and £7.5 million in compensation.[12]

The Committee's letters to nine banks and building societies found at least 158 IT failure incidents and at least 803 hours of unplanned outages between January 2023 and February 2025, more than 33 days. Firms cited third-party suppliers, system changes and internal software faults.[12]

FCA data points the same way. Retail banks reported 446 major operational incidents in 2025. The top drivers were change management at 24.22% and third-party failure at 20.85%.[9] Across all firms, the FCA says over 40% of cyber incidents reported to it in 2025 involved a third party.[13]

Consumer groups are watching. In September 2026 Which? analysed FCA data on 21 banks and building societies and found Santander and its Cahoot brand reported the most incidents between April 2025 and March 2026, at 38.[19]

Concentration is now a policy issue in its own right. The EU designated Google Cloud EMEA and others as critical ICT providers in November 2025; the UK followed in July 2026.[5,17] The October outage was the first major test of a newly designated UK critical third party.

The lesson is not that cloud is unsafe. Google's report shows layers of redundancy that usually work. It is that rare combinations happen, and every firm relying on one region needs to know what its customers experience when they do.

PART 03

What to do now.

What the evidence means for UK financial firms, and the steps that turn compliance into readiness.

01 What it means for the UK

02 Recommendations

03 Questions for the board

UK RELEVANCE

What it means for UK organisations in Financial Services and Insurance

> **Take the 20 October timeline, overlay your own services, and ask whether you would have stayed within tolerance.**

First, the critical third parties regime is a backstop, not a shield. The Bank of England, PRA and FCA describe it as complementing existing outsourcing and operational resilience rules, with regulated firms remaining responsible for managing their own third-party arrangements.[10] The PRA's expectation that firms stay within tolerance whether or not they use third parties still applies.[15]

Second, the 18 March 2027 reporting rules will expose weak incident processes. Firms must decide quickly whether an incident meets a threshold and report within 24 hours of that decision; payment firms keep a 4-hour clock from detection. Material third-party arrangements must be notified and registered.[6,7] That needs a severity model, named decision makers and data captured as the incident runs.

Third, communications deserve the same rigour as technology. The FCA's March 2026 findings point to untested strategies and no plan for losing usual channels.[8] DORA goes further for EU entities, requiring crisis communication plans for responsible disclosure of major incidents to clients, counterparts and, where appropriate, the public.[18]

Fourth, groups with EU subsidiaries must run two sets of clocks. DORA has applied since 17 January 2025, with initial notification within 4 hours of classifying a major incident and no later than 24 hours from awareness.[11,16]

Insurers should note that important business services include claims, which peak in exactly the events, such as storms and floods, that also stress suppliers and staff.

The practical test for any board: take the 20 October timeline, overlay your own services, and ask when you would have known, who you would have told, and whether you would have stayed within tolerance.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Six steps for financial firms

In priority order.

01 Map cloud concentration to important business services

Record region and zone dependencies for each service, including through suppliers, and test a regional loss. [1,8]

02 Build out-of-band communications

Reach the response team, customers and supervisors without corporate email, chat or single sign-on. [8]

03 Test communications in every scenario

Include customer, staff, supplier and supervisor messages, timed against tolerance. [8]

04 Prepare for the 2027 rules, and DORA

Agree thresholds, decision owners and data for a 24-hour initial report and a third-party register, in one model that also meets DORA clocks. [6,7,11]

05 Make supplier notification a contractual test

Ask critical suppliers how fast and how they will tell you, including about maintenance windows.

06 Strengthen the self-assessment

Severe scenarios, confidence ratings, remediation owners and real incidents as evidence. [8]

FOR THE BOARD

Questions boards should ask this quarter

Answers should be specific, dated and owned.

EXPOSURE

- ? Which important business services depend on a single cloud region, directly or through a supplier?
- ? If our main region failed for six hours on payday, which tolerances would we breach?
- ? Which suppliers would tell us first, and how?

READINESS

- ? Can we reach staff, customers and supervisors without email and chat?
- ? Are we ready to report within 24 hours of meeting a threshold from March 2027?
- ? Does our self-assessment show severe testing, or only confidence?

GLOSSARY

Terms used in this report

Important business service
A service to an external user which, if disrupted, could cause intolerable harm or risk to the firm or the wider system.

Impact tolerance
The maximum tolerable level of disruption to an important business service, including a time metric.

Self-assessment
A firm's written record of compliance with the resilience rules, approved by its board.

Critical third party (CTP)
A provider designated by HM Treasury and overseen by the Bank of England, PRA and FCA.

CTPP
Critical ICT third-party service provider, designated by the European Supervisory Authorities under DORA.

DORA
The EU Digital Operational Resilience Act, Regulation (EU) 2022/2554, applying from 17 January 2025.

Availability zone
An isolated location within a cloud region with its own power, cooling and networking.

Control plane
The systems that manage and route cloud workloads, as distinct from the workloads themselves.

PLC
Programmable logic controller: an industrial computer controlling equipment such as generators.

Material third party arrangement
A supplier arrangement that must be notified and registered under the 2027 UK reporting rules.

Mapping
Identifying the people, processes, technology, facilities and information behind each important business service.

Severe but plausible scenario
A demanding but realistic disruption used to test whether a firm can stay within tolerance.

Change management
The controls around updates to systems, the leading driver of major incidents at retail banks in 2025.

Register of information
The DORA record of all contractual arrangements a financial entity has with ICT providers.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When a cloud region fails at 07:00, sending the alert is the easy part. Staying within impact tolerance depends on who acknowledged, which workarounds started, what customers and supervisors were told, and whether you can prove it all afterwards.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your financial services organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Incident team, executives and key suppliers reached by push, SMS and voice when email is down.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement tracked against each important business service; no response escalates in minutes.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation tied to impact tolerance thresholds, not to individual memory.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by IT, operations, communications and compliance.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Workaround and recovery steps for each important business service run as owned tasks.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of services, tasks and teams that the executive can read without a briefing.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that supports self-assessment and regulator questions, produced on request.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Severe but plausible scenarios rehearsed end to end, including the loss of usual channels.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own financial services scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A cloud or payments outage that pushes an important business service towards its impact tolerance.

02 A cyber incident that takes out email and chat, so you need out-of-band coordination.

03 A critical supplier failure that you must manage, report and evidence.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

+44 (0) 20 8584 1385

contactus@crises-control.com

www.crises-control.com

Request a demo

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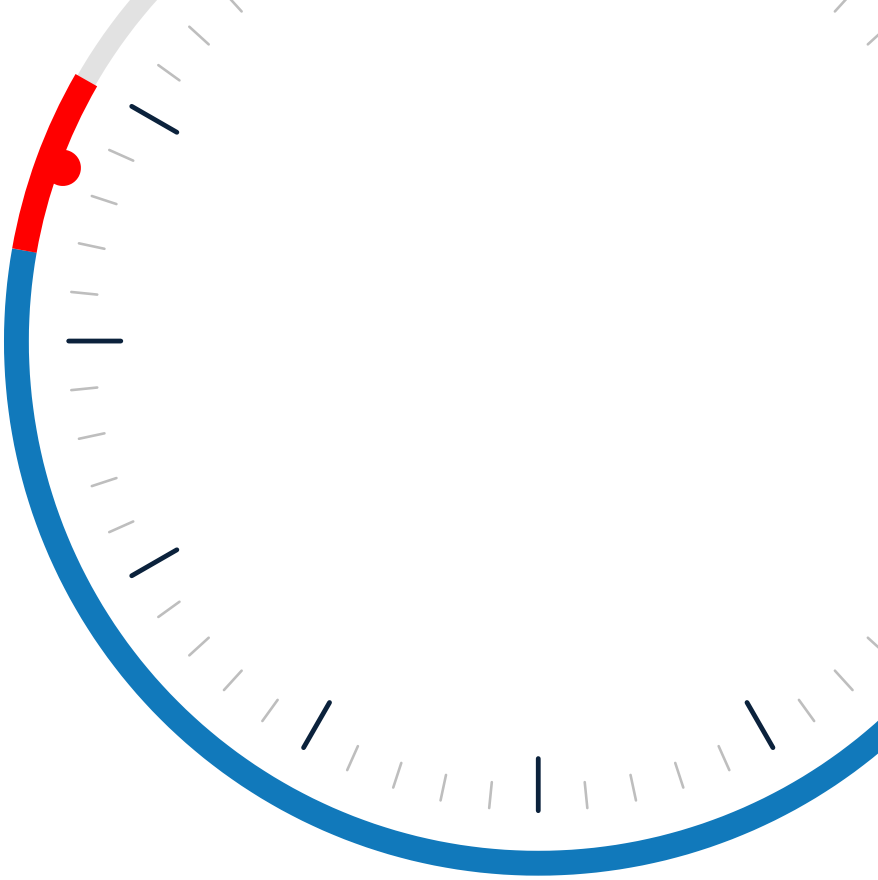
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Ready for the next six hours?

Crises Control helps banks, insurers, payment and investment firms alert the right people in minutes, coordinate the response from one place and keep the evidence supervisors ask for.

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PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Crisis playbook No. 01 · Within tolerance

CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 02

WEEK OF 16 NOVEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



PROPERTY, HOUSING AND FACILITIES

Every resident reached.

Fire, flood, gas, a dead lift or a building system that stops obeying. A playbook for reaching every resident, occupier and member of staff in the first hour, including the people who cannot leave on their own.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

Contents

A practical playbook for landlords, managing agents and facilities teams: how to keep residents, occupiers and staff safe and informed when a building emergency starts, and how to prove afterwards that you did.

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FOREWORD

In a building emergency, the message is part of the safety system.

When something goes wrong in a block of flats, an office or a care setting, the physical response gets the attention: the fire service, the engineer, the shut-off valve. Yet the Grenfell Tower Inquiry found that the people affected were also failed by information. The landlord's records of residents who might need help to escape were incomplete on the night, and in the days after the fire the council had no effective system for communicating with the public.[1,2]

The law has moved since. Responsible persons in multi-occupied residential buildings must give residents fire safety instructions and report lift faults to the fire service. From April 2026, taller buildings and those that have switched to simultaneous evacuation need evacuation plans for residents who cannot get out unaided. Social landlords now have 24 hours to investigate and make safe emergency hazards.[3,4,5]

There is a newer risk too. In October and November 2026, attackers reached refrigeration controllers across Europe that had been left exposed to the internet, and the UK's National Cyber Security Centre warned that other building and heating controls could be at risk if left unprotected.[6,7] A building management system that is switched off, or quietly changed, is now a credible way for an emergency to begin.

This playbook is for the people who own that first hour: housing and property managers, facilities and building safety leads, and the out-of-hours teams who pick up the phone at 3am. It is practical and vendor-neutral. Our companion intelligence report sets out the evidence and the legal detail.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things decide whether everyone is reached.

Most failures in building emergencies are not about knowing what to do. They are about who knows, how fast they hear, and whether anyone can show later what was decided and why.

Know who is in the building

A current, consented record of residents and occupiers who may need help, with how each prefers to be contacted and who can act for them.

Reach them in minutes, not hours

Pre-approved messages for each kind of emergency, sent on more than one channel, with a way to see who has not acknowledged.

Log every decision

A single, timestamped record of what was known, what was decided, who was told and when. It protects residents first and your organisation second.

A plan that cannot reach the person on the ninth floor is not a plan.

Evacuation strategies, contractor rotas and BMS alarms all depend on one thing working: getting the right instruction to the right person, and knowing that it arrived.

PART 01

Know your building.

Before the alarm sounds: the emergencies you will face, how serious each one is, and who lives and works inside.

01 Why building emergencies are communication emergencies

02 Six emergencies, six first messages

03 A severity ladder for buildings

04 Knowing who needs help

KNOW YOUR BUILDING

Why building emergencies are communication emergencies

> **The physical emergency is only half of it. Who knows, how fast, and what they do next usually decides the harm.**

Every building emergency has two parts. One is physical: a fire, a burst main, a gas escape, a stuck lift, a power cut. The other is informational: who needs to know, what they should do, and whether they have understood.

The Grenfell Tower Inquiry's findings are blunt on this. The landlord's emergency plan was out of date and incomplete, missing fire action notices were a prominent subject of residents' complaints, and its information on vulnerable residents was incomplete on the night.[1] Afterwards, the council had no arrangements for identifying those forced from their homes or for communicating with them.[1]

Residents also notice when communication fails in ordinary times. In its review of complaints determined in 2025-26, the Housing Ombudsman found poor communication and inadequate record keeping running through its most serious repairs cases.[8]

The building itself is changing too. Heating, ventilation, lifts, access and pumps are increasingly run from a building management system (BMS) that a contractor can reach remotely. In October 2026 France's CERT-FR reported numerous compromises of internet-exposed refrigeration controllers.[6] US agencies warned such attacks could alter settings and create fire hazards.[9]

No UK building management system compromise was confirmed in that wave, but the NCSC has warned that exposed controls of other kinds are at risk.[7] For elderly residents, heating switched off on a January night is a welfare emergency, whatever caused it.

So the planning question is not only how to fight a fire or fix a pipe. It is how quickly you can tell everyone what to do, and how you will know who has not heard.

SIX EMERGENCIES

Six emergencies, and what the first message must say

The first message sets the tone for everything after it. Agree the wording now, not on the night.

EMERGENCY	FIRST MESSAGE MUST SAY	WATCH FOR
Fire	Where it is, the current strategy and how to report a fire, matching the instructions residents already hold.[3]	A change of strategy. The second message matters more than the first.
Flood or escape of water	Which floors are affected, whether to isolate electrics, where to go if homes are unsafe.	Water reaching risers, lift pits and electrical intakes.
Gas	No switches or flames, open windows, leave if told to, call 0800 111 999.[10]	Residents who cannot leave quickly.
Lift failure	Which lifts are out, expected return, help for those who cannot use stairs.	In high-rise blocks, report firefighting lift faults not fixed in 24 hours to the fire service.[3]
Power failure	Scope, expected duration, what still works, welfare checks for powered medical equipment.	Door entry and warden call that depend on mains power.
BMS fault or tampering	What people will notice (heat, ventilation, access), what to report, and that the cause is being checked.	Settings that change back after a reset.

SEVERITY

A severity ladder for buildings

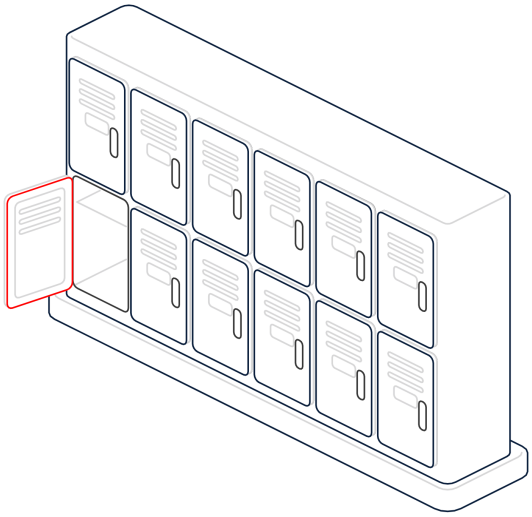
Agree the levels in advance so the person on call does not have to decide alone. Each level names who is alerted and how.

SEV 1 **Life at risk**	TRIGGERS Fire with smoke spreading, change from stay put to evacuation, gas escape inside the building, people trapped, structural movement, or, for social landlords, an emergency hazard under Awaab's Law.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Duty manager, building safety lead, senior leadership, every affected resident, contractors and the fire and rescue service liaison. `Voice + SMS + push, repeat until acknowledged`
SEV 2 **Safety at risk**	TRIGGERS Firefighting or evacuation lift out with no fix in 24 hours, loss of heating in cold weather, flood affecting electrics, unexplained BMS changes.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Duty manager, building safety lead, contractor, residents of affected floors, welfare team for vulnerable residents. `SMS + push + email, voice for vulnerable residents`
SEV 3 **Service disruption**	TRIGGERS Single lift out with another working, planned shutdown overrun, door entry fault, local leak contained.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Duty manager, contractor, affected residents or occupiers. `SMS or push + email`
SEV 4 **Monitor**	TRIGGERS BMS alarm cleared, minor fault logged, advance notice of works.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Building team and contractor; residents only if they will notice. `Email or app notice`

WHO LIVES HERE

Four things to know about every resident who may need help

The law requires this in blocks of 18 metres or seven storeys, and over 11 metres with simultaneous evacuation. It helps everywhere.[4]



01 **Who and where**

Residents whose ability to evacuate is compromised by an impairment or condition, with flat and floor.[4]

02 **What help they need**

Offer a person-centred fire risk assessment; agree the approach in an emergency evacuation statement.[4]

03 **How to reach them**

Preferred channel and language, and whether a carer should also be told.

04 **Consent and review**

Share with the fire service only with explicit consent. Review every 12 months.[4]

PART 02

The first hour.

When the alarm sounds: who does what, what residents hear, and how to change course safely.

01 A worst-day timeline

02 Ready-to-send messages

03 Changing the evacuation strategy

04 Three scenarios

WORST DAY

Fire in a high-rise block, 02:10 on a winter night

Illustrative: a 20-storey block with a stay-put strategy and residents who need help to leave. Adapt the roles to your structure.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Fire reported, 999 called** A resident calls 999 and the out-of-hours line. The incident is opened; duty manager and building safety lead alerted automatically.	OUT-OF-HOURS
T+00:08	**First message to residents** Approved message to every resident: location, current strategy, how to report smoke. SMS, push and voice.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:12	**Information for the fire service** Plans and secure information box confirmed. Consented list of residents who need help ready for the incident commander.	BUILDING SAFETY LEAD
T+00:20	**Strategy change** If the fire service decides to evacuate, one message goes to all residents at once. Non-acknowledgements are chased.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:30	**Vulnerable residents** Each resident on the list is reached, or reported to the incident commander as not reached.	WELFARE LEAD
T+00:45	**Contractors, holding line, log** Lift, alarm and BMS contractors called; no remote changes without approval. Holding statement issued. Log checked.	FACILITIES AND COMMS

TEMPLATES

Six messages to approve before you need them

Short, specific and written for the person reading at 2am. Keep SMS under 160 characters and send the same instruction on every channel.

SMS · RESIDENTS — 133 chars

> FIRE at Lowry House, floor 9. Stay in your flat unless fire or smoke affects it. If it does, get out and call 999. Updates to follow.

Only while the strategy is stay put.

SMS · OCCUPIERS AND STAFF — 130 chars

> Gas escape reported at Quay Building. Do not use switches or flames. Leave now by the nearest exit and meet at the front car park.

Fire wardens confirm floors are clear.

SMS · RESIDENTS — 132 chars

> Lowry House: LEAVE THE BUILDING NOW by the stairs. Do not use lifts. If you cannot get out, call 999 and tell them your flat number.

Strategy change. Voice call anyone who has not acknowledged.

EMAIL · CONTRACTORS

> Incident at Lowry House from 02:10. Make no remote changes to BMS, lift or alarm settings until the duty manager confirms. If on call, attend and report to the incident lead.

Stops resets that destroy evidence.

VOICE · VULNERABLE RESIDENTS

> This is Northgate Housing. There is a fire at Lowry House. The fire service know you may need help. Keep your front door shut and press 1 to confirm you heard this.

Only say the fire service know if they do.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA AND FAMILIES

> We are working with the fire service at Lowry House. Residents' safety is our priority. We will update this statement at 04:00.

No speculation on cause or casualties.

STRATEGY CHANGE

Changing from stay put to evacuation

The decision belongs to the fire and rescue service. Your job is to make it reach every resident within minutes. The Grenfell Tower Inquiry criticised the absence of contingency plans for a full evacuation.[1]

Hear it once, clearly

Agree in advance how the incident commander's decision reaches your duty manager, and who is allowed to trigger the evacuation message.

Send to everyone, on every channel

One pre-approved instruction, by SMS, push and voice, to every resident and visitor on record. Building alarm systems where fitted.

Watch who has not responded

Non-acknowledgements are not silence. Pass the list of flats not reached to the incident commander, floor by floor.

Prioritise those who need help

Residents with evacuation statements are contacted individually and their status reported, using the information already shared with consent.

Log the change

Time of decision, time of message, numbers reached and not reached. This is the record an inquiry, regulator or court will ask for.

Test the strategy-change message at least once a year, with the fire safety instructions you give residents every 12 months.

IN PRACTICE

Three buildings, three bad nights

SUPPORTED HOUSING, 40 FLATS

Burst tank floods the plant room at 23:00

THE RISK

Power, lift and warden call fail. Some residents use powered medical equipment.

THE PROOF

Log shows every resident reached within 40 minutes.

THE RESPONSE

SEV 2. Voice calls to all, welfare checks, contractor and network operator called.

WATCH OUT

Know what fails when the power goes.

OFFICE CAMPUS, 1,200 STAFF

Heating and ventilation settings change overnight

THE RISK

BMS setpoints altered remotely; laboratory ventilation switched off.

THE PROOF

Log and contractor access records shared with security and the insurer.

THE RESPONSE

Treated as tampering. Remote access cut, settings recorded before reset, staff told.

WATCH OUT

A reset alone is not enough if the device stays exposed.[6]

GENERAL NEEDS TOWER, 18 STOREYS

Both lifts fail on a Friday evening

THE RISK

Residents with limited mobility stranded. One is the firefighting lift.

THE PROOF

Monthly lift check records available to residents.

THE RESPONSE

Fire service told when the fault ran past 24 hours, and when fixed.[3]

WATCH OUT

By day two a lift outage is a welfare issue.

PART 03

Prove it.

After the first hour: contractors and nights, a record you can stand behind, and the plan for the next 90 days.

01 Who answers at 3am

02 A decision log you can defend

03 Week, month, quarter

OUT OF HOURS

Who answers at 3am: five arrangements to settle now

Most building emergencies start outside office hours. The weakest link is usually the hand-off between your on-call team and a contractor's.

01 One number, one owner

A single out-of-hours route, a named duty manager and a deputy called automatically if the first does not respond.

02 Contractor contacts that work

Named 24/7 contacts for alarm, lift, BMS, gas, electrical and water contractors, tested quarterly.

03 Remote access rules

No remote changes during an incident without approval. Remote access only through secured connections.[6,9]

04 Information to hand

Floor plans and the consented list of residents who need help, available away from the office.[3,4]

05 Who reports to whom

Who tells the fire service, council and insurers, and who decides if a safety occurrence goes to the Building Safety Regulator.[11]

DECISION LOG

A decision log you can defend

Social landlords must now give tenants a written summary of investigation findings and keep them informed of progress.[5] A good log makes that easy.

AREA	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Timing	Times reconstructed from memory and phone records days later.	Every alert, call and decision timestamped automatically as it happens.
Who was told	"We messaged the residents" with no list.	Recipients, channel, delivery and acknowledgement for every message.
Decisions	Actions recorded, reasons lost.	What was known, what was decided, by whom and why, in one place.
Vulnerable residents	A spreadsheet checked if someone remembers.	Each person's status recorded: reached, visited, passed to the fire service.
Contractors	Calls on personal phones, not recorded.	Who was called, when they arrived, what they changed.
Afterwards	A report written from scattered emails.	A timeline ready for the debrief, the Ombudsman or the regulator.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure and building portfolio.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Check every out-of-hours contact and escalation route. Confirm contractors' 24/7 numbers. Find any BMS, lift or plant controller reachable from the internet.	Duty manager rota lead
This week	Draft and approve the six message templates. Confirm who may send an evacuation message.	Head of housing or facilities
This month	Audit records of residents who may need help: consent, contact preference, flat and floor. Confirm what the fire service holds.	Building safety lead
This month	Remove internet exposure of building controls, change default passwords and agree remote access rules with contractors.	Facilities and IT
This quarter	Run a night-time exercise including a strategy change and a BMS fault. Measure time to reach every resident.	Building safety lead
This quarter	Review Awaab's Law response times, the decision log and, for higher-risk buildings, the residents' engagement strategy.[12] Report to the board.	Director of property

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

REACH

- ? If we had to evacuate our tallest block tonight, how long would it take to reach every resident, and how would we know who we had missed?
- ? Do we know, for every building, which residents need help to leave, and does the fire service have that information with their consent?
- ? Who decides, at 3am, that an incident is SEV 1?

CONTROL AND PROOF

- ? Which of our building systems can be reached from the internet, and who can change them?
- ? Could we produce a timed record of every message and decision from our last incident within a day?
- ? Are we meeting the 24-hour emergency hazard timescale today, and how do we know?

CHECKLIST

Can you reach every resident?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **One out-of-hours route with automatic escalation**
  Tested in the last three months.

- [ ] **Six approved message templates**
  Including a stay put to evacuation change and a holding line.

- [ ] **Consented records of residents who need help**
  With flat, floor, contact preference and review date.

- [ ] **Fire safety instructions issued to every resident**
  To new residents promptly and to everyone every 12 months.[3]

- [ ] **Contractor 24/7 contacts and remote access rules**
  No exposed controllers, no default passwords.

- [ ] **24-hour emergency hazard process**
  Investigation and safety work within 24 hours of becoming aware.[5,13]

- [ ] **Decision log in use**
  Every incident, timestamped, with recipients and acknowledgements.

- [ ] **Night-time exercise in the last year**
  Including vulnerable residents and a strategy change.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Responsible person
The person with duties under the Fire Safety Order for the common parts of a building, usually the landlord or managing agent.[14]

Accountable person
Under the Building Safety Act, a person who holds a legal estate in, or has a repairing obligation for, any part of the common parts of a higher-risk building.

Higher-risk building
In occupation, a building at least 18 metres or seven storeys tall with at least two residential units.

Stay put
A strategy in which residents not affected by fire or smoke remain in their flats, relying on compartmentation.

Simultaneous evacuation
Everyone leaves at once when the alarm sounds or when told to.

Residential PEEP
A personal emergency evacuation plan for a resident who cannot evacuate unaided, recorded as an emergency evacuation statement.

Secure information box
A box on site holding plans and contact details for the fire and rescue service.

Emergency hazard
Under Awaab's Law, a hazard posing an imminent and significant risk of harm that a reasonable landlord would make safe within 24 hours.

BMS
Building management system: the controls that run heating, ventilation, lighting, pumps and sometimes access and lifts.

Safety occurrence
An incident or situation relating to fire spread or structural integrity in a higher-risk building that must be reported to the regulator.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When a fire alarm sounds in a high-rise at 02:10, a text to residents is minute one. Keeping everyone safe depends on which residents need help, which contractor is on the way, who changed the evacuation strategy, and a record you can stand behind later.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits

The steps in this playbook, mapped to the Crises Control modules that support them.

Send the evacuation or stay-put message to every resident on SMS, voice and push, and chase anyone who has not acknowledged.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Open one workspace per incident, with approved templates and a single communication log for the duty manager and partners.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
Turn the out-of-hours procedure into assigned tasks for the welfare lead, facilities and contractors, with deadlines and escalation.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
See which floors and residents have been reached, which tasks are open and what has escalated, in one live view.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Keep a timestamped record of every message, decision and acknowledgement, ready for the debrief or the regulator.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.
Let concierge, wardens and caretakers raise an alarm with their location in one touch.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Draft resident updates quickly and translate them into the languages your residents use.	**CRAiG** AI assistant (beta) that drafts role-specific messages, translates and summarises.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your property and housing organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Residents, staff and contractors reached on several channels, including people without smartphones.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement tracked by block and by flat; vulnerable residents followed up first.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Out-of-hours escalation to the duty manager and contractor is automatic.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One log for the incident, shared by housing, repairs, the fire service liaison and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Awaab's Law and fire safety actions run as tasks with owners and deadlines.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of buildings, residents contacted and jobs outstanding.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A defensible, timestamped record of every decision and message.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Night-time scenarios rehearsed, including a change from stay put to evacuation.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own property and housing scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A night-time fire in a high-rise block where the evacuation strategy changes.

02 A flood, gas leak or power failure that affects vulnerable residents.

03 A building management system fault or tampering incident that needs contractors at 3am.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

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www.crises-control.com

Request a demo

SOURCES

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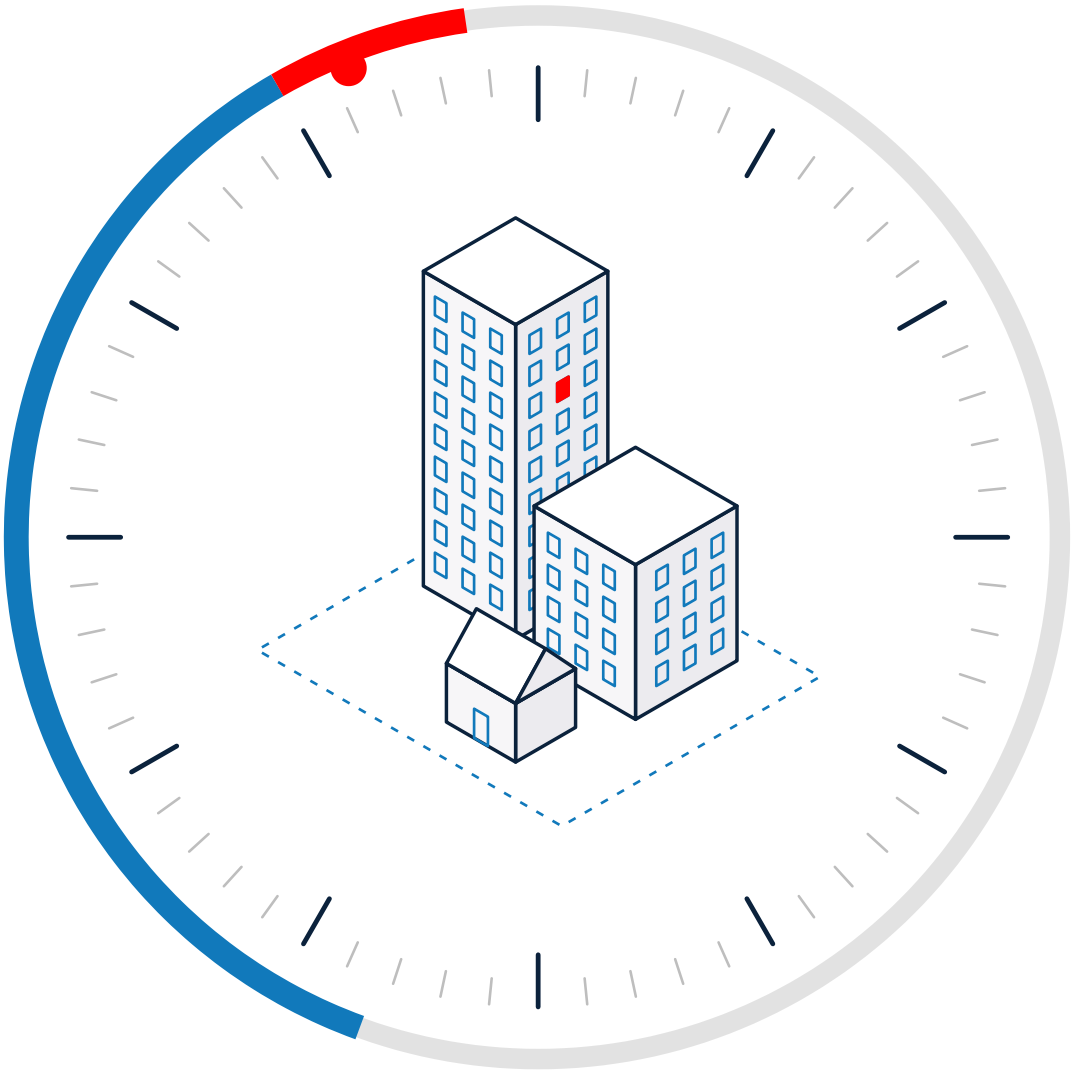
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Intelligence report No. 02 · Safe homes, clear duties



PROPERTY, HOUSING AND FACILITIES · INTELLIGENCE REPORT

Safe homes, clear duties.

Awaab's Law, the Building Safety Act, new evacuation duties and attacks on building controls. What the evidence says about keeping residents safe and informed, and what UK landlords and building managers should do now.

INSIDE

Contents

An evidence-based look at the duties that now govern how landlords and building managers keep residents safe and informed in an emergency, the lessons of the Grenfell Tower Inquiry, and the new risk to building controls.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Telling residents what is happening, and proving you did, is now a legal duty as much as a courtesy.

Since October 2025 social landlords in England have had 24 hours to investigate and make safe emergency hazards in tenants' homes.[1] From 30 November 2026 the same regime extends to further hazards including fire, electrical hazards and excess cold.[2,3] Responsible persons for multi-occupied residential buildings must already give residents fire safety instructions, and from April 2026 taller blocks need evacuation plans for residents who cannot get out unaided.[4,5]

These duties follow the Grenfell Tower Inquiry. Its Phase 2 report found that the landlord's information about vulnerable residents was incomplete on the night of the fire, that the fire brigade's control room was not prepared for a flood of calls, and that the council had no effective system for communicating with those affected.[6]

A new risk has joined the old ones. In October and November 2026, attackers reached internet-exposed refrigeration controllers across Europe, including at a few UK businesses.[7,8] The UK's National Cyber Security Centre warned that heating and other building controls could also be at risk if left unprotected.[9]

This report sets out the duties, the evidence behind them and the emerging threat, and ends with practical recommendations for UK landlords, managing agents and facilities leaders.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Treat resident communication as part of the safety system: know who is in each building and who needs help, reach them in minutes on more than one channel, keep building controls off the internet, and keep a timestamped record of every decision.

KEY FINDINGS

Seven things the evidence tells us

01 **Response times are now law for social landlords.**

Emergency hazards must be investigated and made safe within 24 hours of the landlord becoming aware of them.[1,2]

02 **The scope widens on 30 November 2026.**

Phase 2 of Awaab's Law adds fire, electrical, excess cold and heat, falls, structural collapse and domestic hygiene hazards.[2]

03 **Residents must be told how to stay safe, every year.**

Fire safety instructions go to new residents promptly and to all residents every 12 months.[4]

04 **Vulnerable residents now have specific rights.**

In scope buildings, residents who cannot evacuate unaided must be offered an assessment and an evacuation plan.[5]

05 **Grenfell's communication failures were systemic.**

Incomplete records of vulnerable residents, an overwhelmed control room and no way to reach displaced people all contributed.[6,10]

06 **Communication is where landlords most often fail residents.**

The Housing Ombudsman found poor communication and record keeping running through its most serious repairs cases in 2025-26.[11]

07 **Exposed building controls are a live target.**

Attacks on refrigeration controllers in 2026 used internet-exposed interfaces and, in some cases, published default passwords.[7,8]

AT A GLANCE

Building safety and communication, in six figures

Each figure is sourced. Legal duties are summarised; the regulations set out the detail.

24 hours

To investigate and make safe an emergency hazard in social housing under Awaab's Law.[1]

30 Nov

2026: the date Phase 2 of Awaab's Law is due to apply, after approval by both Houses in October.[2,3]

58

Grenfell Phase 2 recommendations. The government accepted all of them, 49 in full and 9 in principle.[12]

12 months

How often residents of multi-occupied buildings must be given fire safety instructions.[4]

62%

Share of Housing Ombudsman findings in 2025-26 that were maladministration.[11]

53%

Fall in internet-exposed refrigeration controllers Censys observed between 9 October and 5 November 2026.[13]

TIMELINE

From Grenfell to Awaab's Law

Key dates for residential and building safety communication.

14 June 2017 — **Grenfell Tower fire**
Fire sweeps through the tower in a few hours. A public inquiry follows.[6]

23 January 2023 — **Fire Safety (England) Regulations**
Duties on resident information, fire doors, lifts and secure information boxes take effect.[4]

4 September 2024 — **Grenfell Phase 2 report**
Fifty-eight recommendations, including on emergency planning and vulnerable residents.[10]

26 February 2025 — **Government response**
All 58 recommendations accepted, 49 in full and 9 in principle.[12]

27 October 2025 — **Awaab's Law Phase 1**
24-hour duty for emergency hazards, and damp and mould timescales, in social housing.[1]

27 January 2026 — **Building Safety Regulator stands alone**
The regulator leaves the HSE to become an arm's length body of MHCLG.[14]

6 April 2026 — **Residential evacuation plans**
Person-centred fire risk assessments and evacuation plans in scope buildings.[5]

12 October to 5 November 2026 — **Attacks on refrigeration controllers**
CERT-FR alert, a second European wave, NCSC alerts to UK firms and a US fact sheet.[7,8,13,15]

30 November 2026 — **Awaab's Law Phase 2**
Fire, electrical, excess cold and other hazards brought into the timescales.[2]

PART 01

The new duties.

What the law now requires landlords and building managers to do, and to tell residents.

01 Awaab's Law and the 24-hour clock

02 The duties at a glance

03 Fire safety, evacuation and the regulator

AWAAB'S LAW

Awaab's Law and the 24-hour clock

> **The clock starts when the landlord becomes aware, often through an out-of-hours call.**

The Hazards in Social Housing (Prescribed Requirements) (England) Regulations 2025, known as Awaab's Law, came into force on 27 October 2025.[1] They apply to social landlords in England.

An emergency hazard is defined as one that poses an imminent and significant risk of harm to the health or safety of an occupier, which a reasonable landlord would act on to make safe within 24 hours.[1] The landlord must investigate and complete any safety work as soon as reasonably practicable, and within 24 hours of the duty applying.[1] Government guidance puts it plainly: both must be completed within 24 hours of becoming aware of the hazard.[2]

The regulations also govern communication. After an investigation, the landlord must give the tenant a written document setting out its findings within three working days, and keep the tenant informed about the timing and progress of work.[1] Where a home cannot be made safe in time, the landlord must secure suitable alternative accommodation at no cost to the household.[1]

Phase 1 covered emergency hazards and significant damp and mould. Amending regulations, approved by the House of Lords on 14 October and the House of Commons on 20 October 2026, are due to extend the regime from 30 November 2026.[3] Phase 2 adds excess cold and heat, falls, structural collapse, fire and explosions, electrical hazards and domestic hygiene where they present a significant risk of harm.[2]

There is one carve-out that matters for building managers. Guidance states that Awaab's Law does not apply to fire hazards in communal areas already covered by the Regulatory Reform (Fire Safety) Order 2005, such as damaged fire doors or blocked escape routes, which remain for the responsible person.[2,16] Fire hazards inside homes, such as broken smoke alarms, are in scope.[2]

The practical effect is a clock that starts when a landlord becomes aware, often through an out-of-hours call. Meeting it depends on reports reaching the right person quickly and on a reliable record of when each step happened.

AT A GLANCE

The duties that shape emergency communication

England only. Summaries; the regulations and guidance contain conditions and exceptions.

LAW	APPLIES TO	WHAT IT REQUIRES ON COMMUNICATION
Awaab's Law	Social landlords[1]	Emergency hazards investigated and made safe within 24 hours; written findings to tenants; progress updates.
Fire Safety (England) Regulations 2022	Responsible persons for multi-occupied residential buildings[4]	Fire safety instructions and fire door information to residents; lift faults over 24 hours reported to the fire service in high-rise blocks.
Residential Evacuation Plans Regulations 2025	Blocks of 18m or seven storeys, or over 11m with simultaneous evacuation[5]	Identify residents who need help, offer assessment and plans, share basic details with the fire service with consent.
Building Safety Act 2022, s91	Principal accountable persons for occupied higher-risk buildings[17]	A residents' engagement strategy covering information, consultation and how views are taken into account.
Building Safety Act 2022, s87	Accountable persons for occupied higher-risk buildings[18]	Prescribed safety occurrences reported to the Building Safety Regulator.

FIRE AND EVACUATION

Fire safety, evacuation and the regulator

> **Basic details go to the fire service only with the resident's explicit consent.**

The Fire Safety (England) Regulations 2022 came into force on 23 January 2023.[4] In any building with two or more homes and common parts used for evacuation, the responsible person must display fire safety instructions covering the evacuation strategy and how to report a fire, give them to new residents promptly and to all residents every 12 months, and tell residents about fire doors.[4]

Buildings of at least 18 metres or seven storeys carry more. They need a secure information box, floor and building plans for the fire service, wayfinding signs that can be read in low light, and monthly checks of firefighting and evacuation lifts. A lift fault that cannot be fixed within 24 hours must be reported to the fire and rescue service, and so must the fix.[4]

From 6 April 2026, the Fire Safety (Residential Evacuation Plans) (England) Regulations 2025 apply to blocks of at least 18 metres or seven storeys, and to those over 11 metres with a simultaneous evacuation strategy.[5] The responsible person must use reasonable endeavours to identify residents who cannot evacuate unaided, offer a person-centred fire risk assessment, agree an emergency evacuation statement, and prepare a building emergency evacuation plan for the fire service. Basic details go to the fire service only with the resident's explicit consent.[5]

For higher-risk buildings, the Building Safety Act 2022 adds a residents' engagement strategy, setting out what information residents will receive about building safety decisions and what they will be consulted on, and a duty to report prescribed safety occurrences to the regulator.[17,18]

The Building Safety Regulator became a standalone body sponsored by MHCLG on 27 January 2026, a step towards the single construction regulator the Grenfell Tower Inquiry recommended.[14] The government's response to the inquiry also notes that statutory guidance now requires evacuation alert systems in new blocks of flats over 18 metres.[12]

PART 02

The lessons.

What the Grenfell Tower Inquiry and the Housing Ombudsman say about communication when it matters most.

01 What Grenfell revealed

02 Four failures of information

03 The everyday test

GRENFELL PHASE 2

What the Grenfell Tower Inquiry found about communication

> **None of these failures needed new technology to avoid. They needed current records and rehearsed plans.**

The Phase 2 report, published on 4 September 2024, set out how a concrete tower became a death trap through the failings of many institutions over many years.[6]

Before the fire, the landlord's emergency plan for the tower was out of date and incomplete, and the absence of fire action notices was a prominent subject of complaints by residents.[6] Its data systems on vulnerable residents were not co-ordinated, and the spreadsheet available on the night was incomplete: a basic neglect of its fire safety obligations, the inquiry said.[6]

During the fire, the London Fire Brigade had not prepared for a large number of calls from people needing rescue. Staff were forced to improvise ways of handling the information, and it had not produced contingency plans for a full evacuation.[6]

After the fire, the response of government and the council in the first week was described as muddled, slow, indecisive and piecemeal.[6] The council had no arrangements for identifying people forced from their homes or for communicating with them, and arrangements for obtaining and sharing reliable information were lacking.[6]

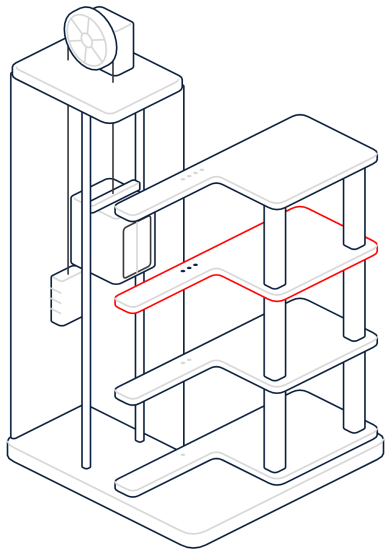
The inquiry's recommendations follow from this. Local authorities should practise recording information about displaced people and communicate continuously with those who need help, in suitable languages. Responsible persons should collect enough information about vulnerable occupants to assist their escape.[10]

None of these failures needed new technology to avoid. They needed current records, rehearsed plans and someone accountable for telling people what was happening.

FOUR FAILURES

Four failures of information the inquiry identified

Each has a direct counterpart in today's duties.



01 **Records of who needs help**

Incomplete information on vulnerable residents on the night. Now addressed by residential evacuation plans in scope buildings.[5,6]

02 **Instructions residents can follow**

An out-of-date emergency plan and missing fire action notices. Now addressed by annual fire safety instructions.[4,6]

03 **Handling a surge of calls**

No preparation for many simultaneous calls for rescue, and improvised information handling.[6]

04 **Reaching people afterwards**

No system to identify or communicate with displaced residents, and no reliable records.[6,10]

THE EVERYDAY TEST

The everyday test: what the Ombudsman sees

> **A resident who has waited weeks for a reply about a leak will not trust an instruction to stay put at 2am.**

Emergencies test communication that is already in place. The Housing Ombudsman's Annual Complaints Review for 2025-26 shows how often that everyday communication falls short. Of its findings, 62% were maladministration and a further 2% severe maladministration.[11]

Responsive repairs featured in 80% of cases and accounted for most severe findings. Across those severe cases, the Ombudsman identified poor communication and inadequate record keeping as recurring failures.[11] Damp, mould and leaks made up a large share of repairs complaints, the same territory Awaab's Law now governs.[11]

The Ombudsman reports that Awaab's Law cases are beginning to reach it, and that early insights suggest landlords are struggling to identify them and respond within the timescales.[11]

Records matter as much as messages. A landlord that cannot show when it was told about a problem, what it did and what it told the resident will find the same gap exposed when an emergency hazard and its 24-hour clock are disputed.

The lesson for landlords is uncomfortable but useful. A resident who has waited weeks for a reply about a leak will not trust an instruction to stay put at 2am. Trust built in ordinary times is what makes emergency messages work.

PART 03

The new threat.

Building controls connected to the internet, and what the 2026 attacks mean for landlords and facilities teams.

01 When building controls are attacked

02 What good control looks like

03 What it means for UK organisations

BUILDING CONTROLS

When building controls are attacked

> **Exposed controllers were reached with weaknesses that had been known for a long time.**

On 12 October 2026 France's national CERT issued an alert after numerous compromises of remote controllers for refrigeration installations, naming Danfoss AK-SM and AK-SC, Copeland XWEB and Dixell XWEB products.[7] It said attack campaigns were probably still under way and that exposing these management interfaces to the internet was contrary to good practice.[7]

Censys reported that the night of 11 October attacks switched units at hundreds of French supermarkets into defrost. Overnight on 2 November, grocers in Belgium, Estonia, Ireland, Luxembourg, the Netherlands and Sweden reported similar attacks.[13] In the UK, three members of the Association of Independent Meat Suppliers and a fruit and vegetable wholesaler were affected; no stock was reported lost.[8]

The NCSC's director of operations said the attacks used vulnerabilities that had been out there for a long time and were not sophisticated. Its chief executive called them the foothills of a wider threat.[8] In remarks reported by PA Media, he named heating and refrigeration controls among systems often under-secured.[9]

US agencies described the risk in terms any building manager will recognise. Attackers could change temperatures, creating fire hazards and equipment damage, and cause a loss of visibility of current conditions. Their advice: remove internet exposure, separate operational technology from business networks, change default passwords, patch or replace end-of-life devices, log activity and set safe limits with alerts.[15]

No compromise of a UK building management system was confirmed in this wave, and we found no public evidence that residential buildings were targeted. But the controllers that run heating, ventilation, lifts, pumps and smoke control are often managed remotely by contractors in the same way. CERT-FR warns that resetting an end-of-life device that stays exposed leaves it open to reinfection.[7] The NCSC publishes guidance on secure connectivity for operational technology.[19]

BUILDING CONTROLS

What most organisations get wrong

Building controls are usually owned by facilities, maintained by contractors and invisible to IT. That gap is where the risk sits.

AREA	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Inventory	Nobody holds a list of BMS, lift, plant and refrigeration controllers.	A list of every controller, its location, owner, contractor and how it is reached.
Remote access	A web page left open so a contractor can log in from anywhere.	Access only through a secured connection, with internet exposure removed.[7,15]
Passwords	Factory defaults, sometimes printed in public manuals.	Defaults changed, accounts named, stronger authentication where feasible.[8,15]
Lifecycle	Controllers run for years past vendor support.	End-of-life devices identified, isolated and replaced.[15]
Monitoring	Changes noticed only when residents complain.	Safe setpoint limits with alerts, and logs reviewed.[15]
In an incident	A contractor resets the device remotely.	Settings recorded first, access cut, residents told what to expect.

UK RELEVANCE

What it means for UK organisations in Property, Housing and Facilities

> **Out-of-hours reporting, contractor response and the record of awareness will be tested more often.**

For social landlords, the immediate priority is the Awaab's Law clock. From 30 November 2026 more hazards fall within it, including electrical faults and excess cold.[2] Out-of-hours reporting routes, contractor response and the record of when the landlord became aware will be tested more often.

For anyone responsible for a block of flats, fire safety communication is a standing duty, not a one-off. Annual instructions, fire door information and, in taller buildings, lift fault reporting are already required.[4] In scope buildings, residents who need help to evacuate must be identified and offered plans, with consent to share basic details.[5]

For higher-risk buildings, the residents' engagement strategy and mandatory occurrence reporting create a clear expectation of what residents are told, and what the regulator hears about.[17,18] A standalone regulator focused on building safety is likely to ask for evidence.[14]

For facilities teams in offices, campuses and mixed-use buildings, the 2026 attacks are a prompt to find every building controller that can be reached from the internet. Loss of heating, ventilation or access is an operational emergency, and in residential settings a welfare one.[9,15]

Across all of these, the Grenfell findings point to the same capabilities: current records of who is in the building and who needs help, rehearsed ways of reaching people quickly, and reliable records of what was done.[6,10]

RECOMMENDATIONS

Seven steps for landlords and building managers

01 Map the clock

Trace how an out-of-hours hazard report reaches a decision-maker, and how awareness is timed.[1,2]

02 Know who needs help

Current, consented records of residents who may need help to evacuate.[5,10]

03 Take building controls off the internet

Inventory BMS and plant controllers, remove exposure and change default passwords.[7,15]

04 Approve messages in advance

Templates for each emergency, consistent with residents' fire safety instructions.[4]

05 Reach people on more than one channel

Use suitable technology and languages, and track who has not acknowledged.[10]

06 Log every decision

Timestamp each alert, decision and acknowledgement.

07 Exercise at night

Rehearse a night incident with a strategy change, at least annually.

FOR THE BOARD

Questions boards should ask this quarter

Answers should be specific, dated and owned.

DUTIES

- ? Are we meeting the 24-hour emergency hazard timescale, and are we ready for the hazards added on 30 November?
- ? In which of our buildings do residential evacuation plan duties apply, and how many residents have been offered an assessment?
- ? When did every resident last receive fire safety instructions?

READINESS

- ? How long would it take to reach every resident of our largest building at 3am, and how would we know who we had missed?
- ? Which of our building controllers can be reached from the internet, and who can change them?
- ? Could we produce a timed record of every decision from our last serious incident?

GLOSSARY

Terms used in this report

Awaab's Law
The common name for the Hazards in Social Housing (Prescribed Requirements) (England) Regulations 2025.

Emergency hazard
A hazard posing an imminent and significant risk of harm that a reasonable landlord would make safe within 24 hours.

Responsible person
The person with duties under the Fire Safety Order for the common parts of a building.

Higher-risk building
In occupation, a building at least 18 metres or seven storeys tall with at least two residential units.

Accountable person
A person who holds a legal estate in, or has a repairing obligation for, the common parts of a higher-risk building.

Residential PEEP
A personal emergency evacuation plan for a resident who cannot evacuate unaided.

Simultaneous evacuation
A strategy in which everyone leaves at once, used where stay put is not appropriate.

Safety occurrence
An incident or situation relating to fire spread or structural integrity that must be reported to the regulator.

BMS
Building management system: controls for heating, ventilation, lighting, pumps and sometimes lifts and access.

Operational technology
Systems that monitor and control physical equipment, as opposed to business IT.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When a fire alarm sounds in a high-rise at 02:10, a text to residents is minute one. Keeping everyone safe depends on which residents need help, which contractor is on the way, who changed the evacuation strategy, and a record you can stand behind later.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your property and housing organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Residents, staff and contractors reached on several channels, including people without smartphones.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement tracked by block and by flat; vulnerable residents followed up first.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Out-of-hours escalation to the duty manager and contractor is automatic.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One log for the incident, shared by housing, repairs, the fire service liaison and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Awaab's Law and fire safety actions run as tasks with owners and deadlines.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of buildings, residents contacted and jobs outstanding.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A defensible, timestamped record of every decision and message.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Night-time scenarios rehearsed, including a change from stay put to evacuation.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own property and housing scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A night-time fire in a high-rise block where the evacuation strategy changes.

02 A flood, gas leak or power failure that affects vulnerable residents.

03 A building management system fault or tampering incident that needs contractors at 3am.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

+44 (0) 20 8584 1385

contactus@crises-control.com

www.crises-control.com

Request a demo

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Is every resident reached?

Crises Control helps landlords, managing agents and facilities teams alert residents, occupiers, staff and contractors in seconds, track who has responded and keep a complete, timestamped record of every decision.

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PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Crisis playbook No. 02 · Every resident reached

CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 03

WEEK OF 23 NOVEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



RETAIL

Keep the shutters up.

Payment outages, cyber attacks, abuse on the shop floor, lockdowns and warm freezers. How to keep stores trading and colleagues safe when it goes wrong at peak.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

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A practical playbook for retail resilience leaders: how stores and head office work as one when tills, systems, fridges or people are under threat, with a peak trading plan for Black Friday and Christmas.

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FOREWORD

Retail crises rarely start at head office. They start at a till, a freezer or a shop door.

In April 2025 a cyber attack forced Marks and Spencer to pause online orders for 46 days, and the retailer estimated the hit to operating profit at around £300m before mitigation.[1,2] The Co-op shut down systems to contain a parallel attack, lost an estimated £206m of sales in six months and later confirmed that data on all 6.5 million members had been taken.[3,4] In October 2026 an incident at Ahold Delhaize took online grocery services offline in the Benelux and the US; the group now expects fourth-quarter sales to be €200m to €250m lower.[5]

The same month, attackers switched supermarket refrigeration into defrost from the internet. France's CERT-FR reported numerous compromised controllers, and on 2 November a second wave reached stores in Ireland, Belgium and Sweden and food suppliers in the UK.[6,7] Meanwhile, the BRC counts more than 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff every day.[8]

This playbook is for the people who have to hold it all together: resilience, security, store operations, IT and communications leaders. It sets out how a store and head office should work as one team on the worst day of the year, what to have ready before Black Friday, and the messages to send in the first hour. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things keep a store trading on a bad day.

Retail incidents move fast and land on the shop floor first. The retailers that cope best are not the ones with the thickest manuals. They are the ones where stores and head office already know who decides, how they talk and what each store does without being asked.

One incident, one team

A store manager and the head office incident lead share the same severity scale, the same facts and the same clock. Nobody waits for a meeting to start.

Fast, two-way messages

Head office can reach every store, and every store can reach head office, in minutes, with a record of who has read what and who has not.

People before stock

Every procedure starts with colleague and customer safety, from a queue that turns hostile to a lockdown call or a freezer that cannot be trusted.

A store that cannot take payment is not trading. It just has the lights on.

The hardest retail incidents are the ones that turn an IT problem into a shop floor problem within minutes: long queues, angry customers and colleagues left to explain something nobody has told them.

PART 01

Ready for peak.

Decide now how stores and head office will work together, how you will grade an incident and what must be true before Black Friday.

01 Store and head office as one team

02 Six threats, first actions

03 A retail severity ladder

04 Peak readiness in six steps

READY FOR PEAK

One incident, two worlds: the store and head office

> **Every head office decision has a store consequence, and someone must own telling stores about it.**

A retail incident is lived in two places at once. At head office, it is a dashboard turning red, a bridge call and a decision about which systems to switch off. In the store, it is a queue that will not move, a customer who wants to know why and a manager who has heard nothing.

The 2025 attacks showed how quickly the two worlds connect. M&S first disclosed a cyber incident after problems with contactless payments and click and collect over the Easter weekend, and stopped taking online orders three days later.[2] The Co-op said it kept trading while it contained its attack, but had to deal with payment problems and empty shelves along the way.[3]

The decisions that protect the business at head office are often the ones that hurt stores most. Taking systems offline can stop an attacker. It can also stop stock files, price updates, loyalty scanners and delivery slots. When Ahold Delhaize took systems offline as a precaution in October 2026, stores stayed open but some shelf labels showed out-of-date promotional prices and loyalty scanners failed.[9]

So the first rule of retail incident management is that every head office decision has a store consequence, and someone must own telling stores about it. The second is that information must flow upwards as well as down. Store managers see the effects first: the first declined card, the first fridge alarm, the first group of shoplifters who turn aggressive. They need a fast, simple way to raise it and to know it has landed.

That means one severity scale that stores and head office both use, one place where the facts live, scheduled updates even when there is nothing new, and acknowledgement from every store so you know who has not heard. It also means trusting store managers with clear authority to act on safety without waiting for permission: to close a door, stop a queue or take stock off sale.

None of this needs to be built during an incident. It needs to be agreed, written down and rehearsed before the busiest weeks of the year.

SIX THREATS

Six retail threats and the first moves that matter

What each side does in the first five minutes, without waiting to be told.

THREAT	FIRST STORE ACTION	FIRST HEAD OFFICE ACTION
Till or payment outage	Switch to the cash and offline procedure. Stop restarting terminals. Tell customers what works.	Confirm scope. Send one instruction to all stores with the next update time.
Cyber attack on core systems	Trade on what still works. Report anything odd. Do not reset devices unless told.	Contain, keep evidence, decide what to switch off and tell stores what each shutdown means.[2,9]
Violence or abuse	Make safe, call 999 if anyone is in danger, do not pursue. Colleague first.	Check it is logged and reported, support the manager, make the next shifts safe.
Fire, threat or attack nearby	Evacuate, invacuate or lock down as briefed. Account for colleagues.	Alert nearby stores, convene the incident group, own customer and media lines.
Cold-chain failure	Probe food by hand, take unsafe stock off sale, do not just reset the controller.[6,10]	Call the contractor, find other sites with the same controllers, take them offline.
Rogue message to customers	Expect questions. Use the approved line and do not guess.	Lock the channel used, then tell customers plainly what to ignore.[11]

SEVERITY

A retail severity ladder that stores and head office share

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later.

SEV 1 **Critical**	TRIGGERS Payments, tills or core systems down across many stores or online. A weapon, terror or life-safety incident at any store. Controller tampering at several sites.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Crisis team, all affected store and area managers, IT and security leads, communications and legal. Voice · SMS · push · bridge in 15 min
SEV 2 **Major**	TRIGGERS Outage in one region or one channel. Serious assault on a colleague. Fridge or freezer failure with stock at risk. A credible threat to a store.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Incident manager, area and regional managers, IT or facilities on call, communications on standby. SMS · push · escalate after 10 min
SEV 3 **Moderate**	TRIGGERS Problem at a single store: tills failing, a violent incident without injury, one fridge alarm, an evacuation for a false alarm.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Store manager, area manager, service desk or facilities helpdesk. Push · email
SEV 4 **Minor**	TRIGGERS Verbal abuse logged, a single device fault, a near miss or a suspicious approach to staff.	WHO IS ALERTED, HOW Store manager, recorded for trend reporting and weekly review. App · email

BEFORE BLACK FRIDAY

Peak readiness in six steps

Black Friday falls on 27 November this year. Finish these before then, and repeat the checks before the last trading weekend before Christmas.

01 Freeze change and name the on-call team

No non-essential changes to payments, tills, e-commerce or networks over peak. Publish who is on call for every day, including weekends.

02 Test the offline and cash procedure

Confirm what each till and terminal can do offline, how much cash float stores hold and who decides to go cash only.

03 Rehearse one outage and one lockdown

A 30-minute exercise with store and area managers: a payment failure at 10am on a Saturday, then a lockdown call.

04 Check every contact list

Store, area and regional managers, key suppliers, payment providers and contractors, each with a tested out-of-hours number.

05 Close the doors you forgot

List fridge controllers, building systems and supplier remote access that face the internet, and take them off it.[6,12]

06 Brief colleagues on safety

De-escalation, how to raise an alarm, when not to intervene and who to call. Staff the hotspots, not just the tills.

PART 02

When it happens.

The first hour on the worst day, and the procedures for violence, lockdown and a cold chain you cannot trust.

01 The first hour of a peak outage

02 After an assault on a colleague

03 Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

04 A cold-chain incident

05 Messages ready to send

THE FIRST HOUR

Black Friday, 07:40: card payments fail

An illustrative timeline. The cause is not yet known. Act on what you can see.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**First reports reach the service desk** Dozens of stores report card terminals declining. Online checkout errors climb.	SERVICE DESK
T+00:05	**Incident declared at SEV 1** Several regions and online are hit. The bridge opens and the log starts.	INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:10	**First instruction to every store** Go to the cash and offline procedure, stop restarting terminals, acknowledge. Next update 08:30.	RETAIL OPERATIONS
T+00:15	**Find the cause, keep the evidence** Check provider status and internal systems for intrusion. Nothing is switched off without a decision.	SECURITY LEAD
T+00:20	**Protect people, tell customers** Managers may pause entry if queues become unsafe. Banner, social posts and store announcement: open, cash accepted, next update time.	SECURITY · COMMS
T+00:45	**Decide on containment** If attack is suspected: isolate, call the response provider and insurer, assess whether personal data is involved.	SECURITY LEAD · LEGAL
T+01:00	**First update to the crisis team** Stores affected, cash position, customer impact, likely duration, decisions needed, next update.	INCIDENT MANAGER

VIOLENCE AND ABUSE

After an assault on a colleague: six steps that matter

The BRC estimates over 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff a day, 118 of them physically violent.[8]

01 Make safe and get help

Call 999 if anyone is hurt or in danger. Do not detain or follow the offender.

02 Look after the colleague

First aid, a quiet room, someone with them, a safe way home. Not back on the till.

03 Keep the evidence

Secure CCTV and body-worn video, note witnesses, write it up within the shift.

04 Report it, every time

Report to police and keep the reference. The new offence of assaulting a retail worker is enacted but not yet in force.[13]

05 Tell head office within the hour

One message, one channel: area manager, security and HR hear the same facts.

06 Follow up and learn

Call the colleague next day, review staffing and layout, share intelligence locally.

MARTYN'S LAW PROCEDURES

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 will require shops where 200 or more people can be expected at once to have these four procedures, so far as is reasonably practicable. The duties are not yet in force.[14]

Evacuation

Getting people away from danger by moving them out of the premises. Know your exits, assembly points and who sweeps each area.[14]

Invacuation

Moving people to a safer place inside, such as a stockroom or back corridor away from glass and entrances.[14]

Lockdown

Securing the premises to stop people entering or leaving. Know which doors lock, who locks them and how fast.[14]

Communication

Getting information to everyone on site: colleagues, customers and contractors, with a way to reach staff who are off the shop floor.[14]

The implementation period is at least 24 months from Royal Assent on 3 April 2025. Premises expecting 800 or more people fall into the enhanced tier, with wider duties.[14]

COLD CHAIN

When you cannot trust the fridge

Refrigeration controllers have been tampered with remotely across Europe this autumn. Treat an unexplained defrost as a possible attack until you know otherwise.

Spot it

An alarm, a case warming for no reason or a defrost cycle outside its schedule.

Check the food, not the display

Probe product temperatures by hand. In England, Wales and Northern Ireland chilled food must legally be kept at 8°C or below.[10]

Take it off sale

Remove anything you cannot show stayed at a safe temperature. Record what, where and when for the insurer and food safety team.

Cut the remote link

With the contractor, take controllers off the internet and allow access only through a secure VPN. CERT-FR warns a factory reset alone is not enough for end-of-life kit.[6]

Restore and check every site

Reconfigure, check defrost schedules, then look for the same controllers at every other store and depot.[6,12]

Check your insurance conditions before cutting data links to the refrigeration contractor, as CERT-FR advises.[6]

MESSAGES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and honest. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause, and always give the time of the next update.

SMS · STORE MANAGERS

146 chars

> SEV1: Card payments down in many stores. Switch to cash and offline procedure now. Do not restart terminals. Reply 1 when done. Next update 08:30.

Keep it under 160 characters so it arrives as one message.

PUSH · ALL STORE COLLEAGUES

> Some payment systems are down. Your safety comes first. Stay calm, use the till script, call security if anyone becomes aggressive. Please do not post about this online.

WEB BANNER · CUSTOMERS

> We're sorry: some card payments aren't working in our stores right now. Stores are open and accepting [cash]. We're working to fix it and will update here at [10:00].

Only say what you know is true. Add what still works.

EMAIL · SUPPLIERS AND HAULIERS

> We are managing an IT incident affecting [systems]. Deliveries continue as booked unless we call you. Do not act on any request to change bank details or give access. Verify on [known number].

Attackers often follow up with fake supplier requests.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of an issue affecting payments in some of our stores and are working to resolve it as quickly as possible. Our stores remain open. We will share more information as soon as we can.

SMS · STORE MANAGER, COLD CHAIN

153 chars

> SEV2: Fridge controller alarm at your store. Probe food temps now. Do not reset the controller. Take unsafe stock off sale. Reply 1, then call [FM line].

PART 03

Recover and rehearse.

Three scenarios to test your plan, a dated plan with owners and the questions to put to your leadership team.

01 Three scenarios

02 This week, this month, this quarter

03 Questions and checklist

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse before peak

GROCER, 400 STORES

Card terminals fail on the last Saturday before Christmas

THE TRIGGER

A provider outage hits two regions at 10am. Queues build and answers vary.

WHAT HURTS

Waiting for certainty before saying anything.

WHAT HELPS

One acknowledged instruction to every store within ten minutes.

REHEARSE

Run one store on cash only for 30 minutes.

CONVENIENCE CHAIN, FRANCHISE AND COMPANY STORES

Freezers defrost overnight in a dozen stores

THE TRIGGER

Opening staff find warm freezers in defrost. The common link is remote access.

WHAT HURTS

Restocking before anyone has cut remote access.

WHAT HELPS

A probe-and-quarantine routine and a list of controllers by site.

REHEARSE

Ask area managers to name their controller models.

FASHION RETAILER, FLAGSHIP STORE

An aggressive group, then a call to lock down

THE TRIGGER

A group threatens colleagues, then police advise of an incident nearby.

WHAT HURTS

A tannoy nobody hears upstairs, no list of who is on shift.

WHAT HELPS

Colleagues who know the safe room and which doors lock.

REHEARSE

A ten-minute lockdown walk-through each quarter.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Publish the peak on-call rota and change freeze. Send the severity ladder and the six message templates to every store.	Head of resilience
This week	Test the cash and offline procedure in one store per region. Confirm payment provider escalation contacts.	Retail operations director
This month	Take fridge controllers and other building systems off the internet. Review supplier remote access.	Facilities and IT security
This month	Brief every store on violence response and reporting. Check alarms, body-worn video and radios work.	Head of security
This quarter	Map stores likely to be in scope of Martyn's Law and draft the four procedures for each format.	Head of security, with legal
This quarter	Run a joint store and head office exercise on a cyber outage. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Chief operating officer

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

TRADING

- ? If every card terminal failed at 10am on a Saturday, how long until every store had one clear instruction?
- ? Which head office shutdown decisions would stop stores trading, and who tells them?
- ? Do we know which store systems and fridge controllers face the internet today?

PEOPLE

- ? Is every assault on a colleague reported, followed up and visible to the board?
- ? Could each large store evacuate, invacuate or lock down today, and has it practised?
- ? How would we reach colleagues who are off shift or off the shop floor?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready for peak?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **One severity ladder used by stores and head office**
  With named owners for each level.
- [ ] **Peak on-call rota and change freeze published**
  Covering every trading day to the new year.
- [ ] **Cash and offline procedure tested this month**
  In at least one store per region.
- [ ] **Message templates approved and loaded**
  Store managers, colleagues, customers, suppliers and media.
- [ ] **Fridge controllers and building systems off the internet**
  Remote access only through a secure route.
- [ ] **Every assault reported and followed up**
  With aftercare for the colleague and a store risk review.
- [ ] **Evacuation, invacuation and lockdown briefed**
  And walked through in large stores.
- [ ] **Every store acknowledges alerts**
  And non-responders are chased automatically.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Severity level
A shared grade (SEV 1 to SEV 4) that sets who is alerted, how fast and how often.

Offline payment mode
A terminal setting that stores some card transactions for later authorisation when the network is down.

Change freeze
A period, usually over peak, when only essential changes to systems are allowed.

Invacuation
Moving people to a safer place inside a building, away from danger outside.

Lockdown
Securing a building so people cannot enter or leave until it is safe.

Martyn's Law
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, which sets duties for larger public premises.

Cold chain
Keeping chilled and frozen food at safe temperatures from supplier to shelf.

Refrigeration controller
A device that runs fridges and freezers and can often be managed remotely.

Defrost cycle
A scheduled warm-up that clears ice. Stretched or repeated, it spoils stock.

Acknowledgement
A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Incident manager
The person who runs the response, keeps the log and sets the rhythm of updates.

Holding line
A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

Body-worn video
A camera worn by colleagues or security staff that records incidents as evidence.

Responsible person
Under Martyn's Law, the person or organisation in control of qualifying premises.

Remote access
A route for suppliers or engineers to manage systems from outside the store.

End of life
When a manufacturer stops issuing security fixes for a product.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When card payments fail on Black Friday, a message to stores is minute one. Trading through it depends on which stores acknowledged, who switched to the fallback, what customers were told, and an accurate picture for head office.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits in a retail incident

How the steps in this playbook map to Crises Control modules.

Send the first instruction to every store manager and see who has acknowledged, with automatic escalation to area managers.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Run the incident from one workspace with one log, shared by stores, head office and suppliers.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
Turn the cash procedure, cold-chain checks and lockdown steps into tasks with owners and deadlines.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
See which stores are affected, what has been done and where escalations are waiting.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Give colleagues a one-touch way to raise an alarm with their location.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Keep a timestamped record of every message and decision for the post-incident review and insurer.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your retail organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Every store manager and on-call colleague reached in minutes, on more than one channel.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Store-by-store acknowledgement, with escalation when a store stays silent.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation from store to region to head office runs by rule.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by IT, store operations, loss prevention and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Fallback, lockdown and cold-chain procedures run as owned tasks in every store.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Head office sees which stores are trading, closed or at risk, live.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline for insurers, the ICO or a post-incident review, ready the next day.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Peak-trading scenarios rehearsed with stores, not only at head office.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own retail scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A card payment or till outage on your busiest trading day.

02 A violent incident or lockdown in a store, with colleagues to protect.

03 A refrigeration or cold-chain failure across several sites.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

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www.crises-control.com

Request a demo

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Keep every store in the loop.

Crises Control helps retailers alert every store in seconds, see who has acknowledged, run incidents from one place and keep colleagues safe on the shop floor.

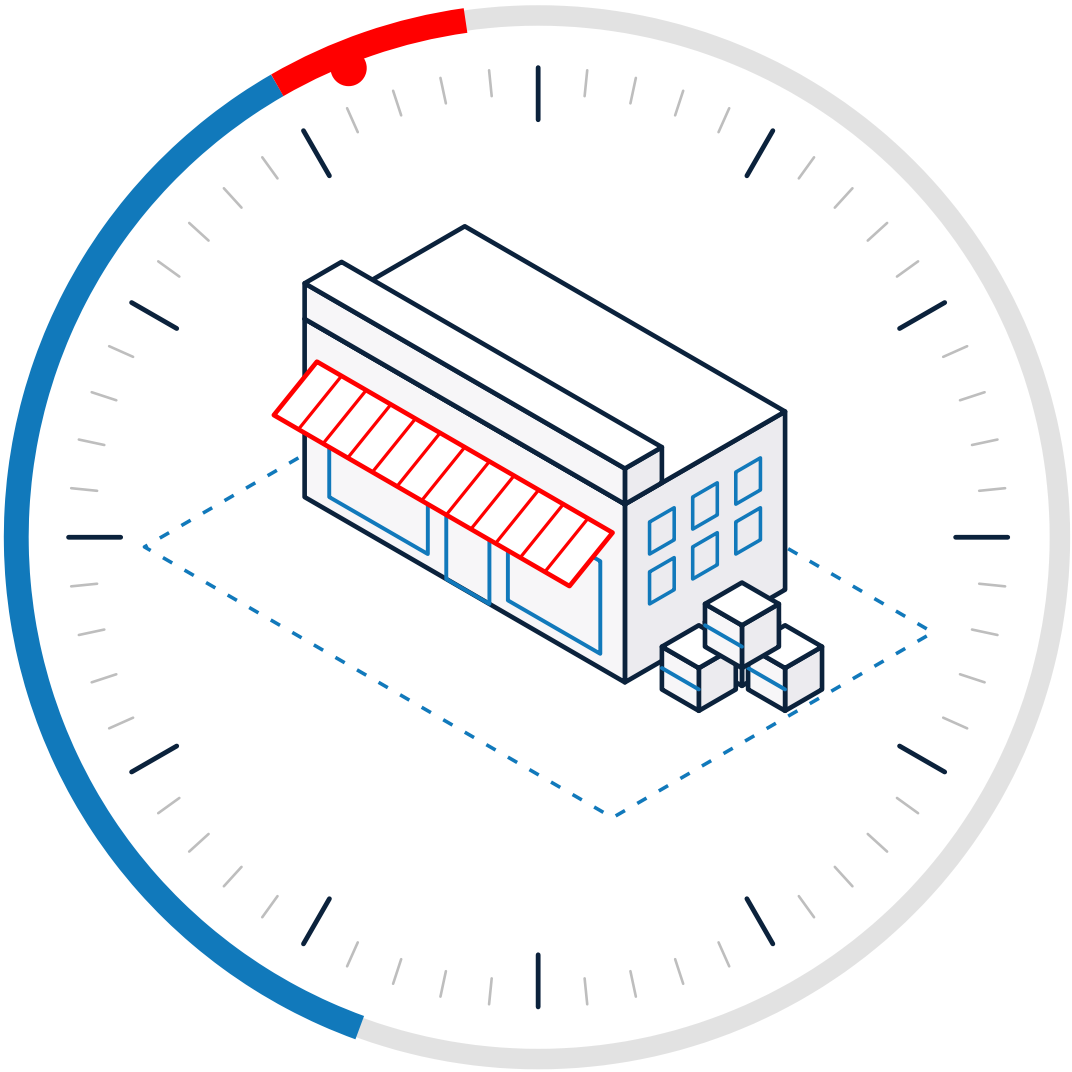
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Intelligence report No. 03 · When the tills go dark



RETAIL · INTELLIGENCE REPORT

When the tills go dark.

M&S, Co-op, Ahold Delhaize, ASOS and the supermarket fridge attacks. What the evidence shows about retail disruption, colleague safety and the laws coming into force, as peak trading begins.

INSIDE

Contents

An evidence-based look at the incidents that have tested UK and European retailers since 2025: cyber attacks that stopped online trading, a rogue message to app users, refrigeration controllers switched off from the internet, violence against shop workers and the new laws that follow.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Retail disruption now starts in systems most shoppers never see, and ends on the shop floor.

In April 2025 a cyber attack forced Marks and Spencer to pause online orders for 46 days; it estimated the hit to operating profit at around £300m before mitigation and later booked £131.3m of incident costs against £100m of insurance proceeds.[1,2,3] The Co-op lost an estimated £206m of sales in six months and confirmed that data on all 6.5 million members had been taken.[4,5]

Autumn 2026 brought new patterns. Ahold Delhaize took systems offline in October and expects fourth-quarter sales to be €200m to €250m lower.[6] ASOS app users received an unauthorised push notification after an employee's credentials were obtained by impersonation.[7] And attackers switched supermarket refrigeration into defrost: around 700 French supermarkets were affected in October, and a second wave on 2 November reached Ireland, Belgium, Sweden and UK food suppliers.[8,9,10]

On the shop floor, the BRC estimates over 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff a day.[11] A specific offence of assaulting a retail worker is now in the Crime and Policing Act 2026 but is not yet in force, and Martyn's Law will require larger shops to plan for evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.[12,13]

This report sets out what happened, separates disclosed figures from claims, and ends with practical steps for UK retail leaders before and during peak.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Treat payment, store systems, refrigeration controllers and colleague safety as one resilience problem, owned at board level, with a single way to alert and coordinate every store and a plan rehearsed before peak.

KEY FINDINGS

Seven things the evidence tells us

01 **Shutting systems down is often the right call, and it is expensive.**

M&S, the Co-op and Ahold Delhaize all took systems offline to contain attacks; each then faced weeks of disrupted online trading, availability or supply.[4,6,14]

02 **Stores kept trading, but not normally.**

Shops stayed open in every case, yet colleagues dealt with payment problems, empty shelves, wrong shelf prices and failed loyalty scanners.[2,4,15]

03 **People, not code, opened the door.**

M&S says attackers tricked staff at a third-party contractor; ASOS says an attacker impersonated a trusted contact to obtain an employee's credentials.[2,7]

04 **Recovery takes months, not days.**

M&S restored its online offer in August 2025 and recorded £131.3m of incident costs for the year; its fashion recovery took longer than expected.[3,14]

05 **Operational technology is now a retail attack surface.**

CERT-FR reported numerous compromised refrigeration controllers. Danfoss said most affected units were end of life and no longer patched.[8,16]

06 **Violence remains high even as it falls.**

Incidents fell to 1,617 a day from over 2,000, but remain far above the 455 a day recorded in 2019 to 2020.[11]

07 **New legal duties are coming, but not yet live.**

The retail worker assault offence and Martyn's Law duties are both enacted but awaiting commencement.[12,13]

AT A GLANCE

Retail disruption, in six figures

Each figure is sourced. Some are company estimates that may change as results are finalised.

46 days

How long M&S stopped taking online clothing and home orders in 2025.[2]

£206m

Sales the Co-op estimates it lost to its 2025 cyber attack in the first half alone.[4]

€250m

Upper end of Ahold Delhaize's expected fourth-quarter 2026 sales hit, estimated at €200m to €250m.[6]

About 700

French supermarkets affected by the October 2026 refrigeration attacks, according to the French finance minister.[8]

1,617

Incidents of violence and abuse against UK retail staff a day, September 2024 to August 2025.[11]

£18m or 5%

Maximum Martyn's Law penalty for enhanced duty premises: £18m or 5% of worldwide revenue.[13]

TIMELINE

From one Easter weekend to peak 2026

Key dates. Company dates are as disclosed; incident dates as reported.

25 April 2025 — **M&S pauses online orders**
After contactless and click and collect problems over Easter. The pause lasts 46 days.[2]

1 May 2025 — **NCSC steps in**
The NCSC confirms it is working with UK retailers affected by cyber incidents.[17]

16 July 2025 — **Co-op data confirmed**
The Co-op says data on all 6.5 million members was taken.[5]

24 February 2026 — **BRC Crime Report**
Violence and abuse against retail staff falls to 1,617 incidents a day.[11]

29 April 2026 — **Crime and Policing Act**
Royal Assent for the Act containing a new retail worker assault offence.[18]

6 October 2026 — **ASOS app alert**
App users receive an unauthorised push notification claiming a hack.[7,19]

11 to 12 October — **Two retail shocks**
Ahold Delhaize takes systems offline; CERT-FR warns of compromised fridge controllers.[16,20]

2 November 2026 — **Second fridge wave**
Stores in Ireland, Belgium and Sweden, and UK food suppliers, are hit.[9,10,21]

4 to 5 November — **Costs and warnings**
Ahold Delhaize cuts guidance; US agencies warn about refrigeration controllers.[6,22]

PART 01

The outage.

Four incidents, four ways a retailer's systems can stop it trading normally.

01 2025: the spring that emptied shelves

02 2026: the back office and the app

03 Four incidents compared

THE OUTAGE

2025: the spring that emptied the shelves

> **Every shutdown decision has a store and supply chain consequence that must be planned for in advance.**

M&S first disclosed a cyber incident on 22 April 2025, after problems with contactless payments and click and collect over the Easter weekend. On 25 April it stopped taking online orders for clothing and home, and did not restart them for 46 days. It said attackers had got in by tricking staff at a third-party contractor.[2]

The company's own account shows how a cyber response becomes an operational one. Containing the attack meant disconnecting warehouse management systems, which paused online orders, click and collect and in-store ordering. Manual processes were introduced to keep forecasting, ordering and replenishment going, and customers could shop in stores throughout.[14]

The cost was large but smaller than first feared. In May 2025 M&S estimated a hit to operating profit of around £300m before mitigation.[1] A year later it reported £131.3m of incident costs within adjusting items and £100m of insurance proceeds, describing 2025/26 as a year of two halves.[3] Its online offer was restored in August 2025.[14]

The Co-op took a different path to the same place. It shut down systems to contain its attack and kept stores trading, but faced payment problems and stock shortages.[4] It estimated lost sales of at least £206m and an £80m profit hit in the six months to 5 July 2025, with around £120m expected for the full year.[4] It later confirmed that names, addresses and contact details of all 6.5 million members had been taken, with no financial data involved.[5]

In July 2025 the National Crime Agency arrested four people in connection with attacks on M&S, the Co-op and Harrods.[5] The NCSC called the incidents a wake-up call for all organisations.[17]

The lesson for retailers is not that systems should never be switched off. It is that every shutdown decision has a store and supply chain consequence that must be planned for in advance.

THE OUTAGE

2026: the back office and the customer's phone

> **The first public sign of an attack may be a message your customers see before your own teams do.**

On 11 October 2026 Ahold Delhaize took some systems offline after identifying a security issue in its network. It said stores remained open and that it had no evidence that customer or associate data had been stolen.[15,20]

The effects were felt most online and in logistics. Albert Heijn's online ordering reopened on 23 October, with delivery fleets initially running at about a third of normal capacity. In stores, some electronic shelf labels showed outdated promotional prices and digital loyalty card scanners temporarily failed.[15]

On 4 November the group set out the bill. It expects the incident to cut fourth-quarter net sales by €200m to €250m and operating income by €75m to €100m, mostly through disruption to online capabilities in the Benelux and the US and to Benelux supply chain operations. Its chief executive said most of the disruption was contained within two weeks.[6]

ASOS faced a different kind of incident. On 6 October 2026 app users received a push notification claiming the retailer had been hacked and urging staff to make contact.[7] ASOS said an attacker had obtained an employee's login credentials by impersonating a trusted contact, then used them to access information on certain third-party platforms and send the notification. It said names and contact details may have been accessed, but not payment card details or passwords.[7]

The market reacted before the facts were known: ASOS shares fell as much as 15% in London that day.[19] The attacker's claim of a wider data compromise had not been confirmed when this report was written.

Two lessons stand out. Customer channels such as push notifications are now part of the incident surface. And the first public sign of an attack may be a message your customers see before your own teams do.

FOUR INCIDENTS

What was hit, what kept working, what it cost

Disclosed figures only. Company estimates may be revised.

RETAILER	WHAT WAS HIT	WHAT KEPT WORKING	DISCLOSED IMPACT
M&S, 2025	Online orders paused 46 days; warehouse systems disconnected.[2,14]	Stores traded throughout, with manual processes.[14]	£131.3m incident costs; £100m insurance.[3]
Co-op, 2025	Systems shut down; payment problems and stock shortages.[4]	Stores kept trading.[4]	At least £206m lost sales in H1; 6.5m members' data taken.[4,5]
Ahold Delhaize, 2026	Online in the Benelux and US; Benelux supply chain.[6]	Stores stayed open; online reopened after about two weeks.[15,20]	Q4 sales down €200m to €250m (estimate).[6]
ASOS, 2026	Push notification channel; data on third-party platforms.[7]	Shopping continued; no card data or passwords taken, it says.[7]	Names and contact details may be exposed; shares fell up to 15% on the day.[7,19]

PART 02

The store itself.

When the threat is a warm freezer or an aggressive customer, the incident starts and ends with the people on shift.

01 The fridge attacks

02 How a controller becomes a weapon

03 Violence, abuse and the law

THE FRIDGE ATTACKS

When the freezer is switched off from the internet

> **A store that cannot prove its cold chain held has to assume it did not.**

On 12 October 2026 France's CERT-FR warned that it knew of numerous compromises of remote controllers for refrigeration installations: Danfoss AK-SC and AK-SM series and Copeland and Dixell XWEB systems. It said exposing a management interface on the internet runs against good practice, and that attack campaigns were probably still under way.[16]

The French finance minister told lawmakers that about 700 supermarkets were affected. Retailers including Carrefour, Coopérative U, E.Leclerc, Intermarché and Monoprix confirmed impact, and two supermarkets in Alsace reported combined losses of €270,000. Danfoss said most affected units were end-of-life models no longer receiving patches.[8]

A second wave on 2 November reached other countries. Le Monde Informatique reported around 40 Delhaize stores in Belgium, ICA stores in Sweden and at least 13 SuperValu stores in Ireland, with attackers again triggering defrost cycles.[9] SuperValu's owner took chilled and frozen products off sale as a precaution and said all stores were trading normally by that evening.[21]

The UK was not untouched. Members of the Association of Independent Meat Suppliers and a London fruit and vegetable wholesaler had equipment switched to defrost, but no stock was lost.[10,23] The NCSC said it was working with affected organisations and that the impact so far was minimal; no UK supermarket chain had been confirmed as directly affected.[10,23]

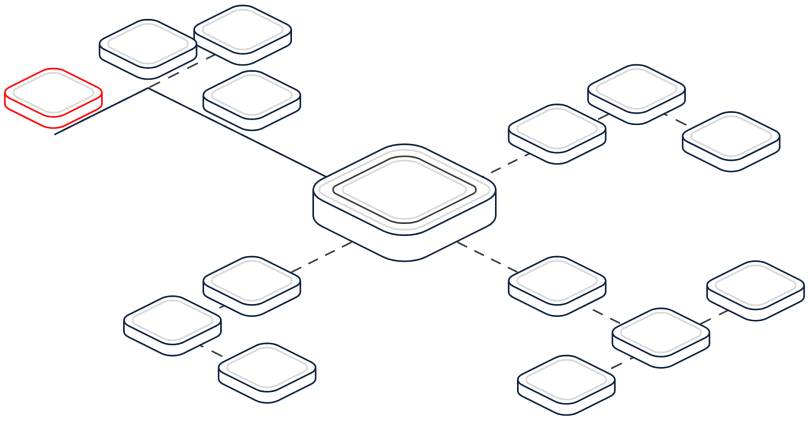
On 5 November US agencies including CISA and the FBI warned of ongoing attacks on refrigeration and cold chain monitoring systems, citing inventory loss, fire hazards and unsafe storage conditions.[22]

For food retailers this is a food safety issue as much as a cyber one. In England, Wales and Northern Ireland chilled food must legally be kept at 8°C or below.[24] A store that cannot prove its cold chain held has to assume it did not.

HOW IT WORKS

Four steps from exposed panel to empty shelf

As described by CERT-FR, vendors and US agencies.



01 **Find the panel**

Controller web interfaces reachable from the internet, often on end-of-life kit.[8,16]

02 **Get in**

Authentication flaws and weak or default passwords, some long since patched.[8,10,22]

03 **Change the settings**

Defrost triggered or stretched, or units pushed into heating.[9,22]

04 **Leave the store to cope**

Stock is discarded and staff must check, quarantine and restock.[8,21]

VIOLENCE AND THE LAW

Violence, abuse and the laws catching up

> **A specific offence of assaulting a retail worker is now law, but is not yet in force.**

The BRC Crime Report 2026 estimates more than 1,600 incidents of violence and abuse against retail staff a day, about 590,000 in the year to August 2025. That is down from over 2,000 a day the year before, but far above the 455 a day recorded in 2019 to 2020.[11] Around 118 incidents a day involved physical violence, and incidents involving a weapon fell from 68 to 36 a day.[11]

Reporting remains patchy. Only 15% of all incidents of abuse, threats and violence were reported to the police, although retailers reported 55% of physically violent incidents.[11] Usdaw's own survey of 9,481 retail staff found 77% had been verbally abused in the previous year, 53% threatened and 10% assaulted.[25]

The law is changing. The Crime and Policing Act 2026 received Royal Assent on 29 April 2026.[18]

Section 45 makes it an offence to assault a retail worker at work, covering anyone working on or about retail premises for the owner or occupier, including unpaid work, and is triable summarily with up to six months in prison, a fine or both.[12] The legislation.gov.uk text still marks the section as prospective: it is not yet in force, and no commencement date has been published.[12,18]

Section 46 adds a duty on courts to make a criminal behaviour order for the offence, subject to conditions in the Act, and section 47 makes theft from a shop triable either way whatever the value of the goods, ending the £200 threshold.[11,26]

Martyn's Law adds a different duty. The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 applies to premises wholly or mainly used for listed purposes, including shops, where 200 or more people can reasonably be expected at the same time.[13] Standard tier premises will need evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication procedures, so far as is reasonably practicable, and must notify the SIA.[13] The implementation period is at least 24 months from Royal Assent on 3 April 2025.[13]

THE LAW

What the new rules say, and when they bite

Status as at 9 November 2026. Check legislation.gov.uk and GOV.UK for commencement.

MEASURE	WHAT IT DOES	STATUS
Crime and Policing Act 2026, s.45	Offence of assaulting a retail worker at work; up to six months, a fine or both.[12]	Enacted 29 April 2026; not yet in force.[12,18]
Crime and Policing Act 2026, s.46 and s.47	Duty on courts to make a criminal behaviour order, subject to conditions; shop theft triable either way whatever the value.[26]	Enacted; check commencement before relying on them.
Martyn's Law, standard tier	200 to 799 people: notify the SIA; evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication procedures.[13]	Not yet in force; at least 24 months from 3 April 2025.[13]
Martyn's Law, enhanced tier	800 or more people: public protection measures and wider duties; penalties up to £18m or 5% of worldwide revenue.[13]	Not yet in force; standard tier penalties up to £10,000.[13]
UK food hygiene law	Chilled food kept at 8°C or below in England, Wales and Northern Ireland.[24]	In force now.

PART 03

What to do now.

What the evidence means for UK organisations in retail, and the steps that close the gap before and during peak.

01 What it means for UK retail

02 Where retailers get it wrong

03 Recommendations and board questions

UK RELEVANCE

What it means for UK organisations in Retail

> **A cyber incident in retail becomes a store, supplier, customer and food safety event within hours.**

The NCSC's Annual Review records 80 nationally significant incidents in the year to August 2026, out of 337 that needed its support.[27] Retailers were among the most visible of those affected in 2025, and the refrigeration attacks show the threat now reaches equipment that most IT teams have never inventoried.[10,17]

The BRC's own members ranked cyber crime as their second biggest financial concern related to crime, after customer theft.[11] The evidence above shows why. A cyber incident in retail is rarely just an IT event: it becomes a store event, a supplier event, a customer event and often a food safety event within hours.

The common thread is coordination. In each case, the hardest work was keeping stores trading safely while head office contained the problem: telling managers what to do, telling customers what still worked and making sure nobody was left guessing. That work depends on fast, two-way communication with every store and a clear record of who has been told what.

Colleague safety sits alongside this. Violence and abuse is a daily reality, peak trading raises the pressure, and two new legal frameworks are on the way. Retailers that improve reporting now will be ready to use the new offence when it commences, and those that write and rehearse their four Martyn's Law procedures now will not be scrambling when the duties begin.

For UK retail leaders, the test before Black Friday is practical. Could every store receive and acknowledge one clear instruction within ten minutes? Could you list every fridge controller and building system that faces the internet? And would a colleague who was assaulted on the busiest Saturday of the year be looked after, and the incident reported?

COMMON GAPS

Where retailers get it wrong

The gap is rarely technology. It is ownership, communication and rehearsal.

AREA	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Store communication	Head office decides; stores hear about it from customers or social media.	Every decision has a store message, sent at once and acknowledged by every manager.
Shutdown decisions	Systems are switched off with no view of what stores lose.	A pre-agreed map of each system's store and supply chain dependencies.
Operational technology	Fridge and building controllers left on the internet, run by contractors.	Controllers inventoried, off the internet and reached only through secure access.
Third parties	Contractor and help desk access assumed to be safe.	Supplier access reviewed, limited and verified, with tested reset procedures.
Colleague safety	Abuse treated as part of the job and rarely reported.	Every incident logged and reported, with aftercare and store risk reviews.
Peak readiness	Plans written for a quiet Tuesday.	Rehearsed for a Saturday in December, with peak on-call rotas.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Seven steps before peak

In priority order.

01 Give stores and head office one severity scale

Shared triggers, owners and update rhythm for stores and the crisis team.

02 Make every shutdown decision store-aware

Map what stores, online and supply chain lose with each system, and pre-write the store instruction.[14,15]

03 Get operational technology off the internet

Inventory fridge controllers and building systems, remove internet exposure and replace end-of-life kit.[16,22]

04 Harden people-based access

Train help desks and staff against impersonation and tighten contractor access.[2,7]

05 Pre-approve messages for every audience

Stores, colleagues, customers, suppliers and media, each with the next update time.

06 Report and support every assault

Make reporting easy, follow up every incident, prepare for the new offence.[11,12]

07 Rehearse before Black Friday

Exercise a payment outage, a cold-chain incident and a lockdown; draft Martyn's Law procedures.[13]

FOR THE BOARD

Questions boards should ask this quarter

Answers should be specific, dated and owned.

TRADING

- ? If we had to take core systems offline tomorrow, which stores, channels and suppliers would stop, and how would we tell them?
- ? How many of our refrigeration controllers and building systems are reachable from the internet?
- ? How quickly can every store acknowledge a single instruction?

PEOPLE AND LAW

- ? How many assaults on colleagues were reported last quarter, and what support followed?
- ? Which of our stores are likely to be in scope of Martyn's Law, and in which tier?
- ? When did we last rehearse an incident with store and head office together?

GLOSSARY

Terms used in this report

Push notification
A message sent by an app straight to a customer's phone screen.

Social engineering
Tricking a person into giving access, for example by impersonating a colleague or supplier.

Refrigeration controller
A device that runs fridges and freezers, often reachable remotely by engineers.

Defrost cycle
A scheduled warm-up that clears ice. Stretched or repeated, it spoils stock.

End of life
When a manufacturer stops issuing security fixes for a product.

Operational technology
Systems that control physical equipment, such as refrigeration, lighting or access.

Adjusting items
Costs a company reports separately from underlying profit, such as one-off incident costs.

Prospective
A provision that is law but has not yet been brought into force.

Invacuation
Moving people to a safer place inside a building, away from danger outside.

SIA
The Security Industry Authority, which will regulate Martyn's Law.

Standard and enhanced tier
Martyn's Law categories for premises expecting 200 to 799 people, and 800 or more.

Cold chain
Keeping chilled and frozen food at safe temperatures from supplier to shelf.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When card payments fail on Black Friday, a message to stores is minute one. Trading through it depends on which stores acknowledged, who switched to the fallback, what customers were told, and an accurate picture for head office.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your retail organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Every store manager and on-call colleague reached in minutes, on more than one channel.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Store-by-store acknowledgement, with escalation when a store stays silent.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation from store to region to head office runs by rule.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by IT, store operations, loss prevention and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Fallback, lockdown and cold-chain procedures run as owned tasks in every store.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Head office sees which stores are trading, closed or at risk, live.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline for insurers, the ICO or a post-incident review, ready the next day.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Peak-trading scenarios rehearsed with stores, not only at head office.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own retail scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A card payment or till outage on your busiest trading day.

02 A violent incident or lockdown in a store, with colleagues to protect.

03 A refrigeration or cold-chain failure across several sites.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

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Keep every store trading, and every colleague safe.

Crises Control helps retailers alert every store in seconds, see who has acknowledged, coordinate head office and the shop floor from one place, and keep a full record for the review.

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**: alert, coordinate, execute, see and prove, in one place.

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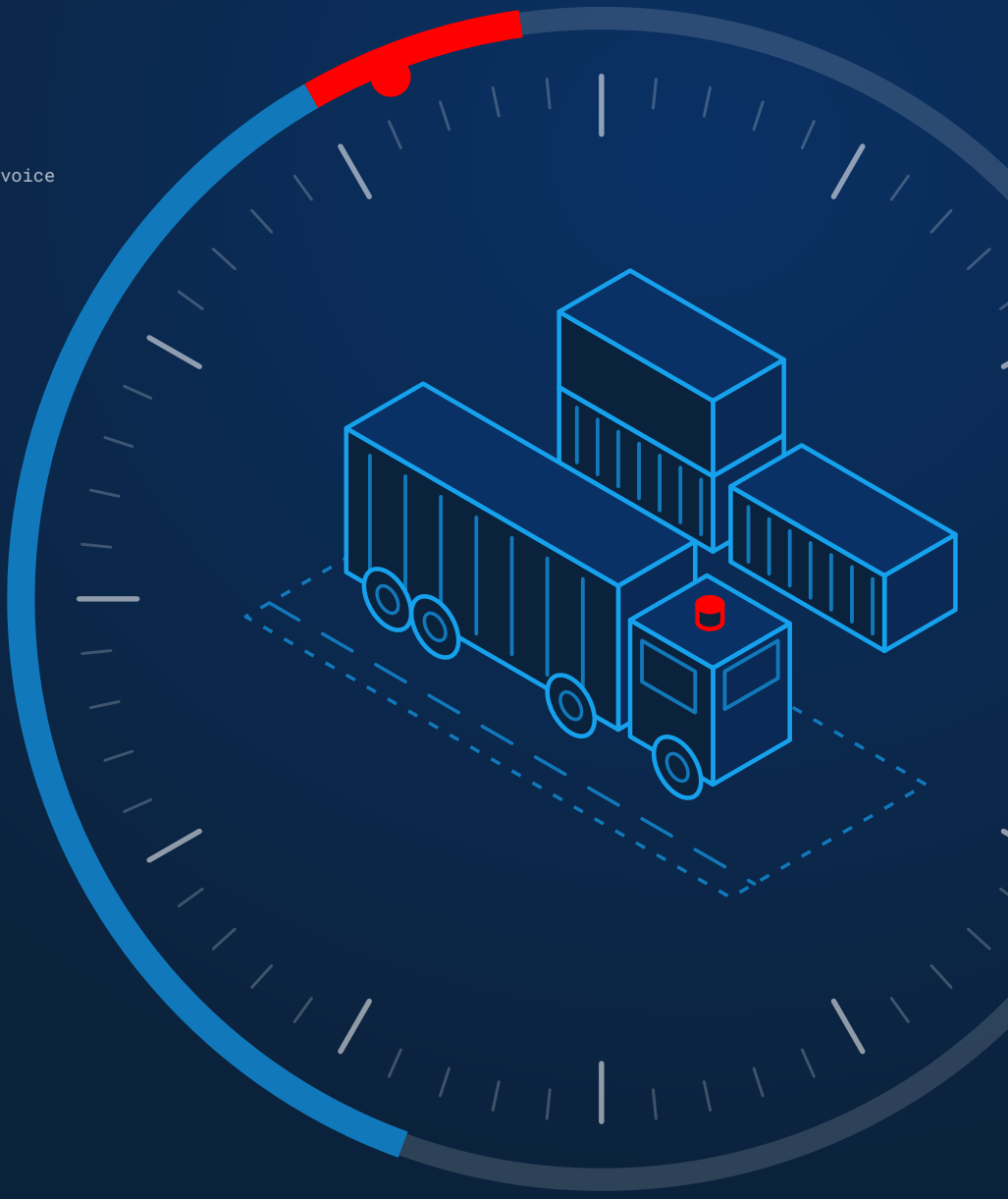
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CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 04

WEEK OF 30 NOVEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



TRANSPORT AND LOGISTICS

Keep it moving.

Hub and depot incidents, storms, IT and cyber outages, failed suppliers and drivers on their own at 3am. How to reroute, inform and protect people in the first hour, and what to fix before winter.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

Contents

A practical playbook for transport and logistics leaders: how to keep people, goods and passengers moving, and staff safe, when a hub goes dark, the weather turns, a system fails or a driver stops answering.

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FOREWORD

In transport, nobody fails alone. One fault becomes everyone's problem within the hour.

On 21 March 2025 Heathrow closed for most of a day after a fire at the North Hyde substation in west London. More than 270,000 passenger journeys were disrupted.[1] The official review found that losing one of the airport's three supply points cut power to some operationally critical systems, and that reconfiguring the airport's network to run on the other two would take an estimated 10 to 12 hours.[2]

Six months later a ransomware attack on a check-in system supplier forced staff at Heathrow, Brussels and Berlin back to handwritten boarding passes.[3] A cyber attack halted production at Jaguar Land Rover for five weeks and left its suppliers waiting for orders and payments.[4,5] And on 8 September 2026 a software defect in the UK's air traffic system delayed, cancelled or diverted more than 2,000 flights.[6]

This playbook is for the people who hold it together when that happens: operations, resilience, security, safety and communications leaders in airports, ports, rail, bus and coach, freight and logistics. It sets out how to grade an incident, what to do in the first hour, how to keep drivers and lone workers safe, how to reroute and keep customers and passengers informed, and how to bring contractors and partners into one response. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things keep a network moving on a bad day.

Transport and logistics run on tight timings, shared assets and many hands. When something breaks, the operators that recover fastest are not the ones with the thickest plans. They are the ones that know where the network is fragile, who must hear first and how to reach every person in it.

Know your single points of failure

One power intake, one planning system, one supplier or one control room can stop a whole network. Find them, test the fallback and know how long it lasts.

Reach everyone, by more than one route

Staff, drivers, contractors, partners, customers and passengers each need the right message, fast, with a record of who has acknowledged and who has not.

People before payload

Every decision starts with the safety of passengers, crews, drivers and lone workers. Freight can wait in a yard. A driver who has stopped answering cannot.

Disruption travels faster than freight.

A fault at one hub, airport or control room reaches drivers, partners and passengers within minutes. The first hour decides whether they hear it from you, with clear instructions, or work it out for themselves.

PART 01

Before it hits.

Find where your network is fragile, agree how to grade an incident and fix the gaps the recent reviews exposed.

01 Why transport incidents spread

02 Six disruptions, first moves

03 A transport severity ladder

04 Readiness in six steps

BEFORE IT HITS

Your network is only as strong as the parts you do not own

> **Incident management in this sector is mostly about the space between organisations.**

A transport or logistics operation is a chain of dependencies. Power comes from a network operator. Planning, booking and check-in run on systems built by suppliers. Track, airspace, roads and berths belong to someone else. Drivers, handlers and engineers are often contractors or agency staff. When one link fails, the effect lands somewhere else: at a gate, a loading bay, a platform or a lay-by.

The recent reviews make the point clearly. At Heathrow, the risk that one supply point might fail was understood at a technical level but less well known outside the technical team.[7] After the 2023 failure of the UK's flight planning system, several airlines and airports first heard about it from the media.[8] In September 2025, airports that had done nothing wrong lost their check-in desks because a supplier was attacked.[3]

So incident management in this sector is mostly about the space between organisations. Who tells the partner sites? Who tells the drivers already on the road? Who decides to divert, and who tells the customer whose delivery will now be late? Who checks that the contractor on the night shift is out of the building?

That means three things have to be settled before anything happens. A severity scale that every site and partner understands. A map of who must be told, in what order, by what route. And a clear way to account for people, from passengers in a terminal to a driver parked alone at a closed depot.

None of this is exotic. Much of it is in the recommendations of the reviews that followed Heathrow and the air traffic failures: a second way to reach key people, earlier warnings to partners and a standard set of information for passengers.[1,9] The work is in making it true across sites, shifts and suppliers before winter, not during the next incident.

SIX DISRUPTIONS

Six disruptions and the first moves that matter

What to do in the first fifteen minutes, before the cause is clear.

DISRUPTION	FIRST OPERATIONAL MOVE	FIRST PEOPLE AND COMMUNICATION MOVE
Hub, depot, port or airport incident	Make the site safe. Stop inbound movements. Decide hold, divert or close.	Account for staff, contractors and visiting drivers. Tell partner sites and drivers on the road.
Power loss	Confirm what is on backup and how long it will last. Ask the network operator for an estimate.[2]	Alert the incident team by two routes. Warn customers that services from the site may stop.
Severe weather	Act on Met Office warnings before they peak: pre-position, cancel early, protect exposed routes.[10]	Tell drivers and crews where to stop safely. Tell passengers and customers early, with what to do.
IT or cyber outage	Switch to manual or offline procedures. Isolate if attack is suspected. Keep evidence.	Tell sites what still works and what not to touch. Prepare a regulator notification.
Supplier or system failure	Ask the supplier for scope and a time. Move to the fallback you agreed in advance.[3]	Tell affected partners and customers once, plainly, with the next update time.
Driver or lone worker not responding	Follow the missed check-in procedure at once. Do not wait for the end of the shift.[11]	Call, then locate, then send help. Tell the family only through the agreed route.

SEVERITY

A transport severity ladder for every site and partner

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later.

SEV 1

Critical

TRIGGERS

A hub, port, terminal or depot closed. Power, IT or a critical supplier lost across the network. Confirmed cyber attack on operations. A fatality, serious injury or missing driver. A red weather warning on key routes.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Crisis team, all affected site leads, safety, security, IT, communications, legal and key partners.

`Voice · SMS · push · bridge in 15 min`

SEV 2

Major

TRIGGERS

One site partly down. An amber warning across a region. A planning, booking or check-in system failing. A road collision with injury. A credible threat to a crew or driver.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Incident manager, site and regional leads, IT or engineering on call, communications on standby.

`SMS · push · escalate after 10 min`

SEV 3

Moderate

TRIGGERS

A single depot or route affected. A breakdown in an unsafe place. A partner running late. A lone worker check-in missed by up to 30 minutes.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Site lead, transport planner or controller, service desk.

`Push · email`

SEV 4

Minor

TRIGGERS

Short delays, a single device fault, a near miss or an abusive passenger without injury.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Site lead, recorded for trend reporting and the weekly review.

`App · email`

READINESS

Readiness in six steps

Each step comes from a lesson in a recent official review. Finish them before the winter peak.

01 Map your single points of failure

Power intakes, control rooms, planning and check-in systems, fuel and key suppliers. At Heathrow, losing one of three supply points cut power to critical systems.[2]

02 Test backup for duration, not just start-up

Find out how long each backup source lasts. Heathrow's review found nearly all emergency power on the affected supply would have run out before main power returned.[7]

03 Give every key person a second route

The Heathrow review recommended a second means of contact for significant incidents, in addition to the existing alert calls.[1]

04 Check on-call staff can actually act

In 2023 an on-call engineer could not log in remotely and reached the control centre 3 hours 15 minutes after the failure began.[8]

05 Agree who tells partners, and how fast

After the 2023 air traffic failure, several airlines and airports first heard of it from the media.[8]

06 Set weather triggers in advance

Decide which warnings cancel which services. In a red warning, police advise people to avoid travel in the affected area.[10]

PART 02

When it hits.

The first hour at a hub that has gone dark, keeping drivers and lone workers safe, rerouting, informing passengers and bringing partners into one response.

01 The first hour

02 Driver and lone worker welfare checks

03 Rerouting and information

04 Messages ready to send

05 Contractors and partners

THE FIRST HOUR

Thursday, 23:40: a substation fire cuts power to your main hub

Illustrative. The cause is not yours. The response is.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Power lost at the hub** Lights, sortation and yard systems stop. Backup starts, but not everything is on it.	HUB DUTY MANAGER
T+00:05	**SEV 1 declared, log started** The team is alerted by call and SMS. Anyone silent after five minutes is called again.	INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:10	**Account for everyone on site** Roll call of staff, agency workers, contractors and visiting drivers.	SITE SAFETY LEAD
T+00:15	**Stop inbound vehicles** Drivers heading in stop at a safe place and acknowledge. Nobody arrives at a dark yard.	TRANSPORT PLANNER
T+00:30	**Decide where the freight goes** No restoration time yet. Divert trunks to hubs with confirmed capacity.	OPERATIONS DIRECTOR
T+00:45	**Tell customers before they ask** Key customers hear what is affected and when the next update is.	CUSTOMER SERVICE · COMMS
T+01:00	**First crisis team review** People, freight, drivers' hours and the morning plan.	INCIDENT MANAGER

WELFARE CHECKS

When a driver or lone worker stops answering

HSE guidance says employers must monitor lone workers and keep in touch with them, using pre-agreed intervals of regular contact, and test their emergency procedures regularly.[11]

Agree the rhythm before the shift

Planned route, check-in times and a safe word or status code. Higher risk work, such as night parking or remote sites, gets shorter intervals.

Spot the missed check-in at once

A missed check-in raises an alert to the controller automatically. Nobody should be relying on memory at 3am.

Try to reach them, then escalate

Call, then message, then call the vehicle or site. If there is no answer within the agreed window, escalate to SEV 2 and the duty manager.

Locate and send help

Use the last known location and telematics. Call 999 if there is any sign of danger. Send a colleague only if it is safe to do so.

Close the loop and learn

Record the outcome, check on the person the next day and review the route, the timing and the kit.

Transport and storage recorded 15 worker deaths in 2025/26 in HSE's provisional figures, which do not include deaths in road traffic accidents.[12]

REROUTING AND INFORMATION

Rerouting and keeping people informed

The 2023 air traffic review asked airlines and airports to develop a standardised suite of passenger information during major incidents.[9] The same discipline works for freight customers.

Decide the route, then say it once

Agree the diversion or alternative with the receiving site before announcing it. One instruction, one owner, one time stamp, sent to every site and driver affected.

Tell people what to do

Lead with the action: do not travel, rebook, collect from another depot, expect delivery tomorrow. Then explain the cause, if you know it.

Set the next update and keep it

Give a time for the next update, even if there will be nothing new. Silence is when rumours start and phone lines jam.

Reach people without data

Not everyone has the app. Use SMS, station and terminal staff, partner desks and recorded phone lines alongside the website.

MESSAGES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and honest. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause and always give the time of the next update.

SMS · DRIVERS ON THE ROAD

141 chars

> SEV1: [Hub] has no power. Do not travel to site. Stop at [safe location] and reply 1 when parked. Next update 00:30. Call [number] if unsafe.

Ask for a reply so you know who has stopped.

PUSH · HUB STAFF AND CONTRACTORS

> Power loss at [Hub]. Stop work safely and go to [assembly point] for a roll call. Do not restart equipment. Supervisors will brief you there.

WEB BANNER · PASSENGERS

> Services from [terminal or station] are disrupted because of [a power failure]. Please do not travel to [location] today unless told your journey is running. Next update [10:00].

Lead with what to do. Add rebooking and refund links.

EMAIL · CUSTOMERS AND PARTNERS

> We are managing an incident at [site] affecting [services]. Freight is being diverted to [site]. Expect delays of [x hours]. We will update you at [time]. Contact [desk].

Partners should hear before the media does.

EMAIL · REGULATOR

> Initial notification: [Organisation] is managing an incident affecting [service] since [time]. Impact: [summary]. Cause: under investigation. Contact: [name, number]. Full report to follow.

NIS operators must notify within 72 hours; a Bill now before Parliament proposes 24 hours.[13,14]

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of disruption affecting [services] and are working to restore them as quickly as possible. The safety of our passengers and colleagues comes first. We will share more information as soon as we can.

01

Bring contractors and partners into one response

Most transport incidents involve people you do not employ: network operators, system suppliers, hauliers, handlers, security and cleaning contractors, neighbouring sites. They need to hear early and act on the same facts.

KNOW WHO THEY ARE

Every partner that can stop your operation, or be stopped by it, with a 24-hour contact and a named owner.

TELL THEM FIRST

Partners should hear from you, not the news. Agree in contracts how fast you tell each other.

SHARE ONE CLOCK

Key partners join the incident log or call, with the same severity scale and update times.

PLAN FOR THEIR FAILURE

JLR set up early payment financing for suppliers critical to its restart.[5] Ask what yours would need.

OWNER

Head of operations, with procurement

Bring this to the monthly review, with a date for each action.

PART 03

Recover and rehearse.

Three scenarios to test your plan, a dated plan with owners, and the questions to put to your leadership team.

01 Three scenarios

02 This week, this month, this quarter

03 Questions and checklist

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse this winter

REGIONAL BUS AND COACH OPERATOR

A red wind warning on a weekday morning

THE TRIGGER

Warnings move from amber to red overnight. Drivers start at 05:00 on exposed routes.

WHAT HURTS

Deciding route by route at the depot, while passengers wait at stops.

WHAT HELPS

Pre-agreed triggers, early cancellation and a driver check-in every hour.

REHEARSE

Walk through the 04:30 decision call with depot leads.

PARCEL AND FREIGHT NETWORK

The planning system supplier is hit by ransomware

THE TRIGGER

Route planning and labels fail at 22:00. The supplier says it is investigating.

WHAT HURTS

Waiting for the supplier before telling sites and customers anything.

WHAT HELPS

A paper or offline route pack and a list of priority customers.

REHEARSE

Run one hub for two hours without the planning system.

AIRPORT GROUND HANDLER

Check-in and bag drop go down at 06:00

THE TRIGGER

Desk systems fail across the terminal. Queues build within minutes.

WHAT HURTS

Each airline saying something different at its own desks.

WHAT HELPS

Manual check-in kits, extra staff called in and one passenger message.

REHEARSE

A 30-minute manual check-in drill with airline partners.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Publish the severity ladder and the six message templates to every site. Confirm a second contact route for every key person.	Head of resilience
This week	Check lone worker and driver check-in procedures are live on every night shift, with escalation tested.	Head of health and safety
This month	Map single points of failure: power, control rooms, systems and suppliers. Test how long each backup lasts.	Engineering and IT leads
This month	Agree partner notification routes and 24-hour contacts with your top 20 suppliers and partners.	Head of operations, with procurement
This quarter	Run a joint exercise with partners: a hub power loss at night, then a supplier cyber attack.	Operations director
This quarter	Check regulator reporting duties and timings. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Chief operating officer, with legal

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

RESILIENCE

- ? If our main hub or terminal lost power tonight, how long would backup last, and what would stop first?
- ? Which single supplier or system could stop our whole operation, and what is the fallback?
- ? How quickly would every partner site and driver have one clear instruction?

PEOPLE

- ? How do we know, minute by minute, that every lone worker and driver is safe?
- ? Could every key decision maker be reached at 1am if their phone was on silent?
- ? Do passengers and customers hear from us before they hear from the media?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready to keep it moving?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **One severity ladder used by every site and key partner**
  With named owners and alert routes for each level.

- [ ] **Single points of failure mapped and backup duration known**
  Power, control rooms, systems and suppliers.

- [ ] **Two routes to every key decision maker**
  Tested out of hours, not only in office time.

- [ ] **Lone worker and driver check-ins live on every shift**
  With automatic alerts for missed check-ins.

- [ ] **Message templates approved and loaded**
  Drivers, staff, passengers, customers, regulators and media.

- [ ] **Partner contacts current and notification agreed**
  Including 24-hour numbers for critical suppliers.

- [ ] **Manual or offline procedures tested this quarter**
  Planning, check-in, dispatch and gate control.

- [ ] **Regulator reporting duties understood**
  Who reports what, to whom, and by when.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Severity level
A shared grade (SEV 1 to SEV 4) that sets who is alerted, how fast and how often.

Single point of failure
One component, site, system or supplier whose loss stops the whole operation.

Supply point
A connection to the electricity network. Large sites may have several, each feeding different systems.

Backup duration
How long a generator, battery or other fallback can run before it is exhausted.

Lone worker
Anyone who works without close or direct supervision, such as a driver or night security officer.

Welfare check
A planned contact to confirm a lone worker or driver is safe.

Trunking
Moving freight in bulk between hubs, usually overnight.

Diversion
Sending vehicles, freight or passengers through another site or route.

Manual fallback
A paper or offline way of doing a task when the system is down.

NIS Regulations
The Network and Information Systems Regulations 2018, which set security and incident reporting duties for essential services, including transport.

Competent authority
The regulator for an essential service under the NIS Regulations.

Holding line
A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

Acknowledgement
A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Incident manager
The person who runs the response, keeps the log and sets the rhythm of updates.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When a substation fire cuts power to a hub at 23:40, the alert is minute one. Keeping goods and people moving depends on which drivers are safe, which partners know, what passengers or customers were told, and a clear record of who decided what.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits in a transport incident

How the steps in this playbook map to Crises Control modules.

Alert drivers, crews and partner sites in seconds, see who has acknowledged and escalate automatically to anyone who has not.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Run the incident from one workspace with one log, shared by sites, contractors and partners.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
Turn the hub power loss, manual check-in and diversion procedures into tasks with owners and deadlines.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
See which sites are affected, which drivers have stopped safely and where escalations are waiting.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Give drivers and lone workers a one-touch way to raise an alarm with their location.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Keep a timestamped record of every message and decision for the regulator, the insurer and the review.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your transport and logistics organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Drivers, depot staff, partners and contractors reached on several channels, at any hour.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement and welfare checks for lone and remote workers, with escalation on silence.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation to duty managers and partner organisations runs by rule.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by operations, partners and customer communications.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Rerouting and recovery steps run as owned tasks across sites.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of sites, people, vehicles and outstanding actions.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that supports regulators, insurers and the post-incident review.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Multi-partner exercises that include a second means of contact for key people.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

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02 A cyber or supplier outage that stops dispatch or check-in.

03 A driver or lone worker who stops responding.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

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10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

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Keep every driver, site and passenger in the loop.

Crises Control helps transport and logistics operators alert every site, crew and driver in seconds, see who has acknowledged, coordinate partners from one place and keep lone workers safe.

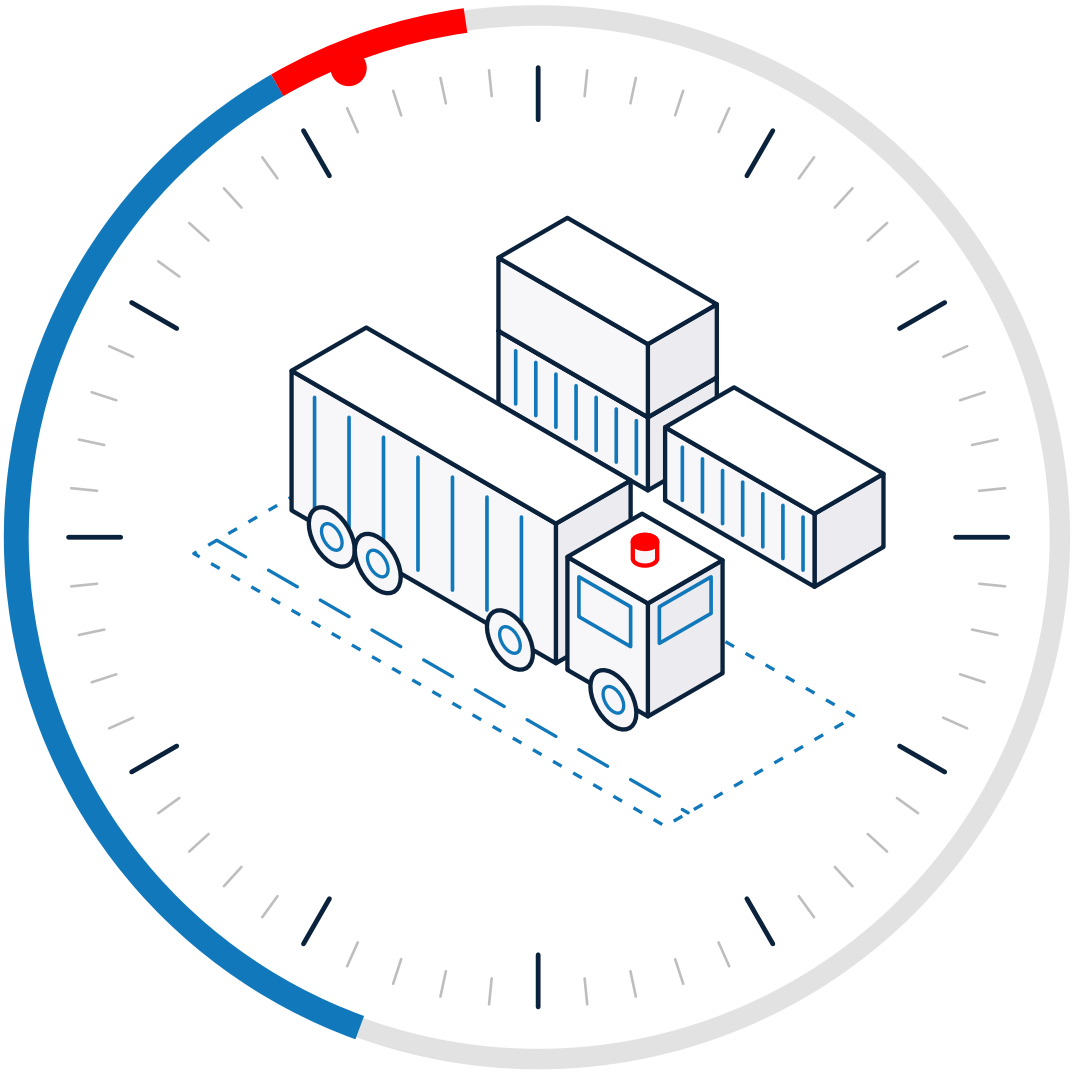
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READ THE COMPANION REPORT

Intelligence report No. 04 · The Heathrow lesson



TRANSPORT AND LOGISTICS · INTELLIGENCE REPORT

The Heathrow lesson.

What the official reviews of the North Hyde fire, the NATS failures, the airport check-in attack and the JLR shutdown tell transport and logistics leaders about power, partners, people and the first hour.

INSIDE

Contents

An evidence-based look at the disruptions that have tested UK transport and logistics since 2023: the North Hyde fire that closed Heathrow, two failures of the UK's air traffic system, a ransomware attack on airport check-in and the cyber attack that stopped Jaguar Land Rover and its supply chain.

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Coordination, self-assessment and your demo 20

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The weak points in UK transport were known. What failed was the link between knowing and acting.

Late on 20 March 2025 a fire at the North Hyde substation cut power to part of Heathrow. The airport closed for most of 21 March and more than 270,000 passenger journeys were disrupted.[1,2] NESO's review found that losing one of Heathrow's three supply points cut power to some operationally critical systems, and that a high moisture reading taken at the substation in 2018 had not been acted on.[1]

Heathrow's own review, led by Ruth Kelly, found the decision to close was correct, but that nearly all emergency power on the affected supply would have run out before main power returned, and that a key alert went unheard overnight.[2,3] The CAA's review of the August 2023 air traffic failure had already found partners hearing late and an on-call engineer who could not log in remotely.[4,5] On 8 September 2026 a different software defect at NATS delayed, cancelled or diverted more than 2,000 flights.[6,7]

Cyber attacks on suppliers added a second pattern. A ransomware attack on a check-in system supplier hit Heathrow, Brussels and Berlin in September 2025, and an attack on Jaguar Land Rover stopped production for five weeks, with a modelled UK cost of £1.9bn across more than 5,000 organisations.[8,9,10]

This report sets out what the reviews found, separates findings from commentary, and ends with practical steps for UK transport and logistics leaders.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Treat power, systems, suppliers and people as one resilience problem: know your single points of failure and how long each fallback lasts, reach every key person and partner by more than one route, and rehearse the first hour with the organisations you depend on.

KEY FINDINGS

Seven things the evidence tells us

01 The weak point was a single connection, and it was known.

Heathrow's network meant losing one of three supply points cut power to critical systems. The vulnerability was understood at a technical level but less well known outside the technical team.[1,3]

02 Backup that starts is not backup that lasts.

The Kelly Review found nearly all emergency power sources on the North Hyde supply would have been depleted before main power was restored.[3]

03 Alerts depend on the phone that receives them.

A senior leader's phone had switched to silent overnight. The review recommended a second means of contact for significant incidents.[2]

04 Partners often heard last.

After the 2023 air traffic failure, several airlines and airports first learned of it from media coverage, and the review called for earlier notification.[4,5]

05 A supplier's incident becomes the operator's crisis.

Airports that were not themselves attacked fell back to manual check-in when their supplier's system was hit by ransomware.[8,9]

06 One attack can stop a whole supply chain.

The Cyber Monitoring Centre called the JLR attack a Category 3 systemic event affecting more than 5,000 UK organisations.[10]

07 Fixing one failure does not prevent the next.

NATS says the September 2026 defect was unrelated to 2023. The new CAA review will examine how earlier recommendations were implemented.[6,7]

AT A GLANCE

Disruption, in six figures

Each figure is sourced. Estimates are labelled as such.

270,000+

Passenger journeys disrupted by the closure of Heathrow on 21 March 2025.[2]

10 to 12 hrs

NESO's estimate of the time to reconfigure Heathrow's network onto its two remaining supply points.[1]

700,000+

Passengers affected by the NATS flight planning failure of 28 August 2023.[4]

3 h 15 min

Time before the on-call engineer reached the control centre in 2023, after remote login failed.[5]

£1.9bn

Cyber Monitoring Centre's central estimate of the UK cost of the JLR attack, within a modelled £1.6bn to £2.1bn.[10]

2,000+

Flights delayed, cancelled or diverted after the NATS software defect of 8 September 2026.[7]

TIMELINE

From a bank holiday failure to a second one

Key dates. Times are as given in the official reviews and company statements.

28 Aug 2023 — **Flight planning failure**
Automatic flight plan processing fails at 08:32 on a bank holiday. Restrictions run until 18:03.[5]

14 Nov 2024 — **CAA review published**
The independent panel makes 34 recommendations for NATS, airlines, airports, the CAA and government.[4]

20 to 21 Mar 2025 — **North Hyde fire**
The substation loses all supplies late on 20 March. Heathrow closes for most of 21 March.[1]

28 May 2025 — **Kelly Review**
Heathrow publishes its independent review. The decision to close is found to be correct.[11]

1 to 2 Jul 2025 — **NESO report, Ofgem acts**
NESO publishes its final report with 12 recommendations. Ofgem opens an enforcement investigation.[1,12]

19 to 22 Sep 2025 — **Check-in attack**
Ransomware at a supplier disrupts check-in at Heathrow, Brussels and Berlin.[8,9]

28 Sep to 8 Oct 2025 — **JLR support and restart**
A £1.5bn loan guarantee is announced. JLR begins a phased restart.[13,14]

6 Aug 2026 — **Manchester signalling**
A brief power loss at a rail operating centre halts trains across the North West.[15]

8 Sep 2026 — **NATS fails again**
A software defect forces UK-wide restrictions. The CAA sets up a new review.[6,7]

PART 01

The Heathrow lesson.

What two official reviews found about the fire that closed Europe's busiest airport, and why it matters well beyond aviation.

01 One night in March

02 Four links that broke

03 What the reviews found

THE HEATHROW LESSON

One night in March

> **An alert is only as good as the device that receives it.**

Late on 20 March 2025, North Hyde, a 275kV substation in west London, lost all supplies after a fire. NESO found the fire was caused by a catastrophic failure of a high voltage bushing on a transformer, most likely because moisture had got in. An elevated moisture reading in oil samples taken in July 2018 had not been followed by actions appropriate to its severity.[1]

The government's response to NESO adds that the protocols for logging and scheduling routine maintenance had not flagged that essential work was outstanding, and that the fire risk assessment did not include a site-level view of nearby oil-filled equipment.[16] Ofgem opened an enforcement investigation into the transmission owner on 2 July 2025, stressing that this did not mean it had found any breach.[12]

The fire did not only hit Heathrow. NESO says 66,919 customers supplied directly from the local distribution network were affected, alongside road and rail services, Hillingdon Hospital and homes near the site, some of which were evacuated.[1] Three data centres lost mains power but kept running on generators.[1]

At Heathrow, the loss of one of three supply points cut power to some operationally critical systems.[1] Reporting on the Kelly Review says the first automated alert to senior leaders went out at 00:21, that the decision to suspend operations was taken at 01:15, and that limited arrivals resumed at 16:00, with full operations on 22 March.[2]

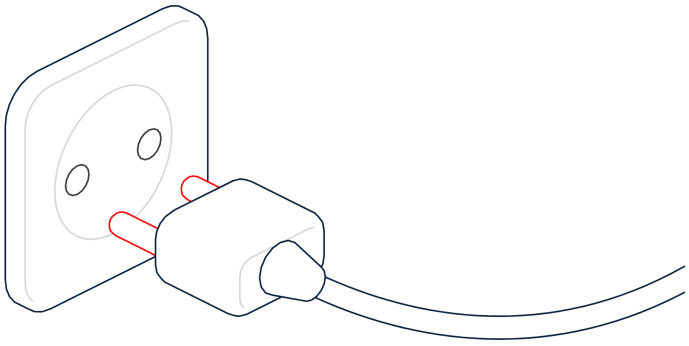
The review found the decision was correct and that alternative choices would not have materially changed the outcome.[11] It also found that overnight alerts had not reached one senior leader because the phone had switched to silent without their knowledge, and recommended a second means of contact for significant incidents.[2] The lesson applies to every organisation, not one person: an alert is only as good as the device that receives it.

Most transport and logistics businesses do not run an airport. But almost all of them depend on a small number of power connections, control rooms and systems, and assume that backup will cover the gap. North Hyde tested that assumption in public.

FOUR LINKS THAT BROKE

Four links in the chain, and what each one teaches

Each was survivable alone. Together they closed an airport.



01 The asset

A 2018 moisture warning was not acted on as it should have been.[1] A known defect with no owner is a future incident.

02 The protection

The fire risk assessment had no site-level view.[16] Assess the whole site, not each part alone.

03 The design

Switching away from one supply point would take 10 to 12 hours.[1] Know what each connection powers.

04 The alert

A key alert went unheard on a silent phone.[2] Reach key people by more than one route.

WHAT THE REVIEWS FOUND

Five official reviews, one set of lessons

Summaries of published findings and terms of reference. Read the originals before relying on any one point.

REVIEW	WHAT IT FOUND OR EXAMINES	LESSON FOR OPERATORS
NESO final report, July 2025	Root cause, maintenance, fire risk and Heathrow's supply design. 12 recommendations, including on the energy resilience of critical national infrastructure.[1]	Map what each power connection feeds and how long a switch-over takes.
Kelly Review, May 2025	Right decision to close; backup power would have run out; vulnerability not widely known outside the technical team.[3,11]	Test backup for duration and share risk knowledge beyond engineers.
DESNZ response, Nov 2025	No cross-sector requirement on CNI operators to ensure continuity during power disruption. Action plan for all 12 NESO recommendations.[16]	Do not wait for a duty. Plan for a long power loss now.
CAA review of NATS, Nov 2024	34 recommendations, including earlier notification to airlines and airports and standard passenger information.[4]	Agree how partners and passengers will hear, and how fast.
CAA review of NATS, from Sep 2026	Causes, consumer impact, system renewal, how past recommendations were implemented and CAA oversight. Final report due by 8 March 2027.[7]	Check that last year's actions are actually closed.

PART 02

The pattern.

Heathrow was not a one-off. Air traffic, airport check-in, rail signalling and a car maker's supply chain show the same shape of failure.

01 When the system is someone else's

02 One attack, a whole supply chain

03 What good looks like

THE PATTERN

When the failure is in someone else's system

> **The operator facing passengers was rarely the one whose system failed.**

On the August 2023 bank holiday, the UK's automatic flight plan processing failed at 08:32 after receiving a plan with duplicate waypoint names. Restrictions ran until 18:03, with knock-on disruption for days.[5]

The independent review found that the on-call engineer's login could not readily be verified remotely, so the engineer travelled in and arrived 3 hours 15 minutes after the failure began. The manufacturer was not contacted for more than four hours, then found a fix within 30 minutes.[5] More than 700,000 passengers were affected, and the panel made 34 recommendations.[4]

On 8 September 2026 a different defect stopped the same national system. NATS says a paused request to allocate an aircraft code did not resume correctly and corrupted later flight data, within a millisecond. Restrictions had to be applied across the UK so the system could be restarted.[6] More than 2,000 flights were delayed, cancelled or diverted, and the CAA has opened a wider review.[7]

Airports met a similar problem a year earlier from a supplier. From the evening of 19 September 2025, a cyber attack on the passenger processing software provided by Collins Aerospace hit check-in and bag drop at Heathrow, Brussels and Berlin. Staff used handwritten boarding passes, and Brussels asked airlines to cancel about half of one day's departures.[8] ENISA confirmed it was ransomware, and the NCA arrested a man in West Sussex on 23 September.[9,17]

Rail has seen the same pattern with power. On 6 August 2026 a power loss of about 90 seconds at the Manchester Rail Operating Centre took down signalling when backup did not start in time, halting trains across the North West into a second day.[15] On 30 December 2025 a power problem in the Channel Tunnel suspended Eurostar services between London, Paris, Brussels and Amsterdam.[18]

In each case the operator facing passengers was not the one whose system failed. That is the pattern: transport depends on shared systems, and the first hour depends on how fast the people who rely on them are told.

SUPPLY CHAINS

One attack, a whole supply chain

> **A customer's shutdown stops your work and your cash flow without warning.**

Jaguar Land Rover shut down production in early September 2025 after a cyber incident. It began a phased restart on 8 October, starting with engine and battery assembly in the West Midlands, then stamping and vehicle lines in Solihull and Nitra.[13] Production returned to normal levels only by mid-November, and vehicles then took extra time to reach markets.[19]

The effects ran well beyond JLR. On 28 September the government announced a loan guarantee backing up to £1.5bn of lending, provided through a commercial bank and backed by UK Export Finance, to help JLR support its suppliers.[14] JLR introduced financing to pay qualifying suppliers early, speeding payment by up to 120 days, starting with those critical to the restart.[13]

The Cyber Monitoring Centre estimated the UK cost at £1.9bn, within a modelled range of £1.6bn to £2.1bn, and said more than 5,000 UK organisations were affected. It described how disruption spread from suppliers to transport and retail, with a little over half of the modelled cost falling on JLR and the rest on its supply chain.[10]

JLR's own accounts show the direct cost. It recorded £196m of cyber incident costs in the quarter to September 2025 and a further £64m in the quarter to December.[19,20]

For logistics firms, the lesson is two-sided. A customer's shutdown stops your work and your cash flow without warning. Your own outage can do the same to every haulier, warehouse and supplier that depends on you. Both need a plan: who you call, what you can keep doing, and how long your partners can survive a stop.

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

Where the gaps were, and what good looks like

Drawn from the published reviews. The gaps are common across the sector, not unique to the organisations named.

AREA	WHAT THE REVIEWS FOUND	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Single points of failure	One supply point fed critical systems. Switching would take 10 to 12 hours.[1]	Each critical system mapped to its power, IT and supplier dependencies, with a tested fallback.
Backup	Emergency power would have run out before mains returned.[3]	Backup tested for how long it lasts, not just whether it starts.
Alerting key people	An overnight alert went unheard on a silent phone.[2]	Two independent routes to every key decision maker, with escalation on no response.
On-call response	Remote login failed; the engineer arrived after 3 hours 15 minutes.[5]	On-call access tested regularly, with supplier escalation in the first hour.
Partners	Some airlines and airports learned of the 2023 failure from the media.[5]	Partners told directly within minutes, by an agreed route, with update times.
Suppliers	A supplier attack stopped check-in at several airports.[8]	Manual fallbacks rehearsed, and supplier incident terms agreed in advance.

PART 03

What to do now.

What the evidence means for UK transport and logistics organisations, and the steps that close the gap.

01 What it means for the UK

02 Recommendations

03 Questions for the board

UK RELEVANCE

What it means for UK organisations in Transport and Logistics

> **Plan on the basis that a long power loss is yours to manage.**

Operators of essential transport services already have a duty under the NIS Regulations 2018 to notify their regulator of any incident with a significant impact on the continuity of the service, without undue delay and no later than 72 hours after becoming aware of it.[21] The Cyber Security and Resilience Bill, still before Parliament at the time of writing, would add a light-touch initial notification within 24 hours, followed by a full report.[22]

On power, there is no general safety net. NESO found that critical national infrastructure has no priority within the electricity legal or regulatory framework, and the government accepted there is currently no cross-sector requirement on CNI operators to ensure continuity during power disruption.[1,16] Its action plan includes business continuity guidelines for CNI and a review of how CNI customers are treated in restoration, but operators should plan on the basis that a long power loss is theirs to manage.[16]

Weather adds to the load every winter. When Storm Éowyn brought a red wind warning to central Scotland on 24 January 2025, officials warned of lengthy delays, bridge closures and cancelled rail, ferry and air services, and police advised people to avoid travel in the red warning area.[23]

People remain the first priority. HSE says employers must monitor lone workers and keep in touch with them, test emergency procedures regularly and use devices for raising the alarm where needed.[24] Transport and storage recorded 15 worker deaths in 2025/26 in HSE's provisional figures, which do not include deaths in road traffic accidents.[25]

The practical test is simple. Could you name every single point of failure in your operation, say how long each backup lasts, reach every key person and partner within ten minutes at night, and show a regulator a timed record of what you did? If not, that is the first job.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Seven steps for UK transport and logistics leaders

In priority order. The first four can start this week.

01 Map single points of failure

Power, control rooms, systems and suppliers, and what each one feeds.[1]

02 Test backup for duration

Run fallbacks for as long as a real outage might last.[3]

03 Give every key person two routes

App, call and SMS, with escalation on no response.[2]

04 Tell partners first

Agree routes and timings with suppliers and partners.[4,5]

05 Rehearse supplier failure

Run manual procedures for a shift; agree incident terms.[8,13]

06 Protect lone workers and drivers

Live check-ins, with alerts for missed contact.[24]

07 Know your reporting duties

72 hours today; 24 hours proposed under the Bill.[21,22]

FOR THE BOARD

Questions boards should ask this quarter

Answers should be specific, dated and owned.

EXPOSURE

? Which single power connection, system or supplier could stop our whole operation, and for how long?

? How long does each backup actually last, and when did we last test it for that long?

? Which partners would we stop if we went down, and how fast would they hear?

RESPONSE

? Could we reach every key decision maker within ten minutes at 1am tonight?

? Are the actions from our last incident review closed, and who checked?

? Could we show a regulator a timed record of every alert and decision?

GLOSSARY

Terms used in this report

NESO
The National Energy System Operator, which reviewed the North Hyde outage for government.

NATS
The UK's main air navigation service provider, which runs en route air traffic control.

CAA
The Civil Aviation Authority, the UK aviation regulator.

Supply point
A connection to the electricity network. Heathrow has three.

Bushing
An insulated part that carries a high voltage conductor through a transformer casing.

CNI
Critical national infrastructure: assets whose loss would have a major impact on essential services.

Flight plan processing
The system that checks flight plans and passes them to air traffic controllers.

Ransomware
Malware that locks or steals data and demands payment.

Category 3 event
The Cyber Monitoring Centre's rating for a systemic event, on its five-point scale.

NIS Regulations
The Network and Information Systems Regulations 2018, covering essential services including transport.

Lone worker
Anyone who works without close or direct supervision.

Second means of contact
A separate route to reach a key person if the first alert is missed.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When a substation fire cuts power to a hub at 23:40, the alert is minute one. Keeping goods and people moving depends on which drivers are safe, which partners know, what passengers or customers were told, and a clear record of who decided what.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your transport and logistics organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Drivers, depot staff, partners and contractors reached on several channels, at any hour.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement and welfare checks for lone and remote workers, with escalation on silence.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation to duty managers and partner organisations runs by rule.	0 1 2 3
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Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own transport and logistics scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A power loss or fire at a hub, depot, port or airport.

02 A cyber or supplier outage that stops dispatch or check-in.

03 A driver or lone worker who stops responding.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

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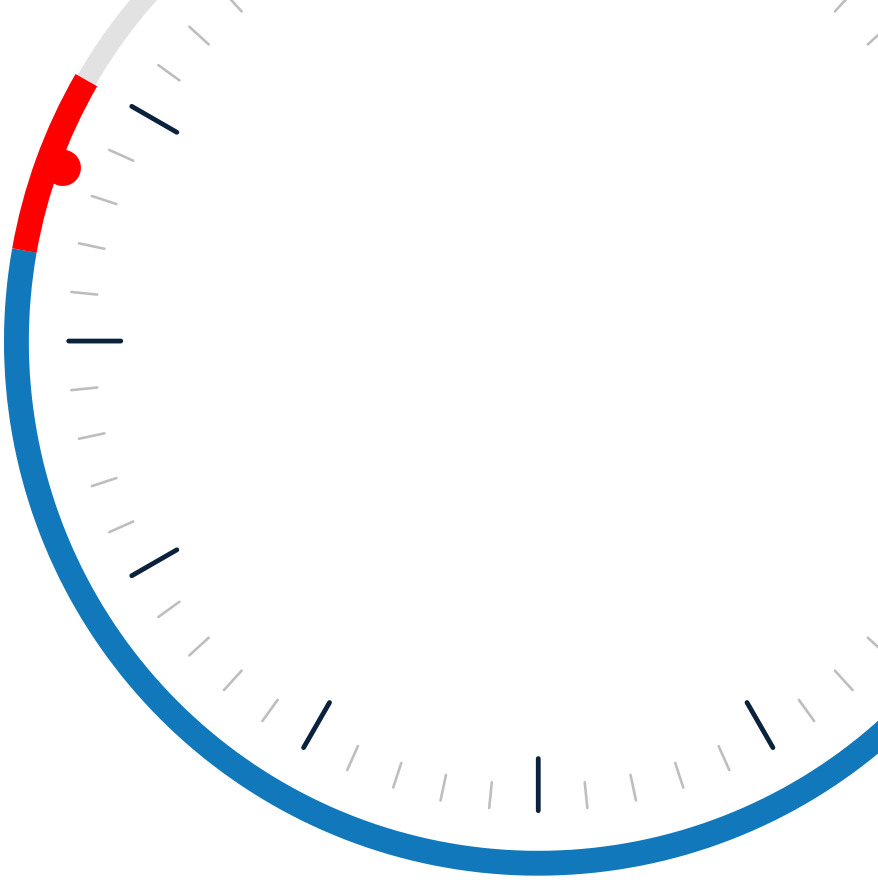
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Keep every site, partner and driver in the loop.

Crises Control helps transport and logistics operators alert every key person by more than one route, see who has acknowledged, coordinate partners from one place and keep a timed record for the regulator and the review.

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CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 05

WEEK OF 7 DECEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



HOSPITALITY

Ready for Martyn's Law.

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down and tell everyone on site, fast. A practical playbook for hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues, written for the busiest weeks of the year.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

Contents

A practical playbook for hotels, pubs, bars, restaurants and venues: what Martyn's Law will require, how every shift protects guests and staff on the worst night, and how to be ready before the festive season peaks.

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FOREWORD

In a busy bar or hotel, the first minutes belong to the people on shift.

On the night of the London Bridge and Borough Market attack in June 2017, the attackers moved through a restaurant courtyard, bars and a restaurant on Stoney Street. The Chief Coroner found that all eight people who died did so within 15 minutes of the attack beginning.[1] In the City Room at Manchester Arena a few weeks earlier, a concern raised by a member of the public did not reach anyone who could act on it, partly because a radio channel was busy.[2]

Martyn's Law, the Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, is named after Martyn Hett, one of the 22 people killed at Manchester Arena.[2,3] It received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025, and the Security Industry Authority expects it to come into force in spring 2027.[3,4] Pubs, bars, restaurants, cafés, hotels and nightclubs where 200 or more people can be expected at the same time will need procedures to evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate with everyone on site.[4,5,6]

This playbook is for the people who will make that work on a Saturday night in December: owners, general managers, duty managers, security leads and operations teams. It covers the law as enacted, the roles each shift needs, how to reach guests and staff in minutes, the other emergencies that are far more likely, and a dated plan. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things protect people on the worst night.

Hospitality venues are busy, noisy, open late and staffed by people on different shifts, many of them new. The venues that cope best are not the ones with the thickest plan. They are the ones where every shift knows who decides, what to do and how to tell everyone fast.

One person decides

Every shift has a named duty manager who can declare an evacuation, invacuation or lockdown without waiting for permission, and everyone knows who that is tonight.

Everyone hears it at once

A code phrase, a radio call and an alert to every phone, so the kitchen, the bedrooms and the smoking area hear the same instruction within a minute.

Plans people actually know

Short procedures, briefed at induction and walked through on the late shift, not a binder in the office that nobody has opened.

A plan nobody on shift knows is not a plan.

The Manchester Arena Inquiry found that on the night, plans "were not known by everyone who should have known about them".[7] Martyn's Law asks hospitality to close that gap before the law starts, not after.

PART 01

Know the duty.

What the Act requires of hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues, the four procedures, and a severity scale every shift can use.

01 What the law says, exactly

02 Four procedures for every venue

03 A hospitality severity ladder

KNOW THE DUTY

What Martyn's Law asks of hospitality

> **Count the busiest realistic night, not a quiet Tuesday.**

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025. The Home Office expects an implementation period of at least 24 months, and there is no legal requirement to comply until the duties come into force.[4] The SIA, which will regulate the Act, says it expects the Act to come into force in spring 2027 and will confirm the exact date ahead of time.[3]

The Act covers premises wholly or mainly used for purposes listed in Schedule 1. Statutory guidance says the "food and drink" use "includes bars, pubs, restaurants, cafés and food halls"; "hotels etc" also covers hostels and holiday parks; and nightclubs fall under entertainment and leisure.[6]

Premises are in the standard tier where 200 to 799 people, including staff, can reasonably be expected to be present at the same time from time to time, and in the enhanced tier at 800 or more.[4] Count the busiest realistic night, not a quiet Tuesday: a Christmas party, a New Year's Eve ticketed event or a wedding in the function suite.

Standard tier premises must notify the SIA and have, so far as is reasonably practicable, appropriate public protection procedures for evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.[4,5] The Home Office says these are simple, low-cost steps that do not require physical alterations or new equipment.[4]

Enhanced tier premises must also have public protection measures covering monitoring, movement, physical safety and security, and the security of information; document compliance and give it to the SIA; and, where the responsible person is an organisation, designate a senior individual.[8]

Penalties reach £10,000 for standard duty premises, and £18m or 5% of worldwide revenue for enhanced duty premises.[9] Existing premises will have three months from commencement to notify the SIA, and changes must be notified within 28 days.[10]

FOUR PROCEDURES

Evacuate, invacuate, lock down, communicate

The Act's four public protection procedures, as the Home Office defines them, and what each means in a hotel, bar or restaurant.[5]

Evacuation

"Getting people away from danger by moving them out of the premises." Know every exit, including through the kitchen, and where guests go once they are out.[5]

Invacuation

"Moving people away from danger to a place within the premises." A function room, back corridor or cellar away from glass and the main doors.[5]

Lockdown

"Securing the premises to prevent individuals entering or leaving." Who locks which door, who drops the shutters, how fast, and on every shift.[5]

Communication

"Ensuring information is provided to individuals at the premises." Staff, guests, bedrooms, terraces, toilets, contractors and the next shift.[5]

The Home Office's own example is a 400-seat restaurant: two evacuation routes, nominated staff who lock doors and close shutters on the shift manager's instruction, and a short briefing for every new starter at induction.[5]

SEVERITY

A hospitality severity ladder for every shift

Grade early and regrade often. If in doubt, go one level higher and step down later. The duty manager can declare any level.

SEV 1

Critical

TRIGGERS

An attack or credible threat at or next to the venue. A fire with people unaccounted for. A crowd crush or several casualties.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Everyone on site, the on-call general manager, the head office crisis team and security leads. 999 first.

Code phrase · radio · PA · SMS · voice

SEV 2

Major

TRIGGERS

A full evacuation on a busy night. A suspicious item. A serious assault or suspected spiking needing hospital. Power lost in service. Booking or payment systems down across sites.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, general manager, area or operations manager, IT or facilities on call.

Radio · SMS · push · escalate after 10 min

SEV 3

Moderate

TRIGGERS

One site's tills or booking system failing. A guest collapse. An aggressive group removed. People trapped in a lift.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, general manager, service desk or facilities helpdesk.

Radio · push · email

SEV 4

Minor

TRIGGERS

Suspicious behaviour reported and resolved. A near miss. A single device fault. Verbal abuse logged.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager, recorded for the weekly review and trend reporting.

App · email

PART 02

On the night.

The first hour of the worst night, the roles every shift needs, how to reach everyone, and the emergencies that are far more likely.

01 The first hour

02 Roles on every shift

03 Reaching guests and staff fast

04 Other emergencies

05 Messages ready to send

THE FIRST HOUR

Saturday, 22:15: an attack outside

Illustrative: a city-centre hotel with a bar and restaurant, around 550 people on site. Police instructions always come first.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Door team sees people running from the street** Shouts of a knife attack nearby. The door supervisor radios the code phrase to the duty manager.	DOOR SUPERVISOR
T+00:01	**Lockdown and invacuation declared** Doors locked, shutters down, music off. Guests moved away from glass to the function room.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:02	**999 called, log started** What, where, which direction, how many on site. Every decision from now is logged with a time.	RECEPTION
T+00:03	**Every member of staff alerted** Code phrase on the PA, radio and an alert to every phone. Staff reply when their area is safe.	DUTY MANAGER
T+00:06	**Guests in bedrooms told to stay put** Room phones and text: stay in your room, lock the door, keep away from windows.	NIGHT MANAGER
T+00:12	**Everyone accounted for, escalated** Chase staff who have not replied, including smokers and anyone outside. On-call general manager and head office alerted.	SHIFT MANAGERS
T+01:00	**Police briefed, people cared for** Floor plans and numbers to police. Guests and staff stay inside until police advise otherwise.	GENERAL MANAGER

ROLES

Who does what, on every shift

Name the people at the start of each shift. There is no statutory training requirement, but staff with a role in the procedures must know them and what they have to do.[5]

01 Duty manager: decides and declares

Has authority to call evacuation, invacuation or lockdown at once, and to call 999. Does not wait for head office.

02 Door and security team: first eyes

Spot and report early, lock doors, stop people entering, and give police clear information on arrival.

03 Bar and floor staff: move the room

Each person owns a section: move guests from glass and doors, sweep toilets and terraces, and report when clear.

04 Reception or night manager: the hotel

Calls 999, reaches guests in bedrooms and holds the guest list and today's function bookings.

05 Kitchen and back of house: the rear

Secure the back doors and delivery yard, cut gas if instructed, and know which rooms can be used as safe areas.

06 Communicator: who has heard

Sends the alert, tracks who has replied and chases the rest, and logs who was told what and when.

COMMUNICATION

Reaching guests and staff in minutes

Noise, music, bedrooms, outdoor areas and staff on breaks make hospitality hard to reach. Use more than one route, and confirm who has heard.

A code phrase everyone knows

A neutral phrase on the PA or radio that tells staff what is happening without alarming guests. Change it if it leaks.

Stop the music, light the room

Music off and house lights up so announcements can be heard, unless lockdown means lights off on police advice.

An alert to every phone

One message to staff on duty by SMS, push and voice, with a reply to confirm. Chase anyone who does not answer.

Guests you cannot see

Bedrooms, toilets, terraces, smoking areas and private dining rooms each need a named person or route.

People off site

The next shift, off-duty staff and families. Tell them not to come in, and keep updates on a schedule. Counter Terrorism Policing's public advice is RUN, HIDE, TELL.[11]

At Manchester Arena, a steward without a radio passed on a concern; a colleague with one tried to report it but someone else was talking, and it went no further.[2] Never rely on a single channel.

OTHER EMERGENCIES

The emergencies that are far more likely

Terrorism is rare. Fire, medical emergencies, spiking, power and system failures are not. The same roles and alerts handle them all.

EMERGENCY	FIRST ACTION ON SITE	FIRST ACTION FOR MANAGERS
Fire alarm in a full venue	Evacuate by the plan. Sweep sections and bedrooms. Do not let guests collect coats or go back in.	Account for staff and guests from the booking and room lists. Meet the fire service with the plan.
Medical emergency	Call 999, send for the defibrillator and a first aider, clear space and send someone to guide the ambulance.	Look after witnesses and staff, record what happened and check first aid cover for the rest of the night.
Suspected spiking	Stay with the person, get help and call police or an ambulance if needed. Keep the drink if you can.	Report it, keep CCTV and brief door staff. Police received 6,732 reports in a year to April 2023.[12]
Power failure	Emergency lighting check, stop cooking, keep exits clear, and decide quickly whether to evacuate.	Call the supplier or facilities, plan for lifts, fridges, tills and door locks, and tell arriving guests.
Booking or payment systems down	Switch to the paper booking list and offline or cash procedure. Do not keep restarting terminals.	Find out whether it is an outage or an attack, and tell sites what still works. A 2022 cyber incident disrupted IHG's booking channels.[13]
Violence or disorder	Make safe, call 999 if anyone is in danger, and do not detain. Staff safety first.	Support the staff involved, keep CCTV and review staffing for the next nights.

MESSAGES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and calm. Fill the brackets, never guess the cause, and always say when the next update will come.

SMS · STAFF ON DUTY

139 chars

> LOCKDOWN at [venue]. Move guests away from doors and glass to [area]. Doors stay locked. Do not go outside. Reply 1 when your area is safe.

Under 160 characters, so it arrives as one message.

SMS · HOTEL GUESTS

144 chars

> [Hotel]: police are dealing with an incident nearby. Please stay in your room, lock the door and keep away from windows. Next update by [22:45].

Only to guests who have given a mobile number.

SMS · OFF-DUTY AND NEXT SHIFT

131 chars

> [Venue] is closed tonight due to an incident nearby. Do not travel in. Everyone on site is being looked after. Next update [08:00].

EMAIL · GUESTS WITH BOOKINGS

> Because of an incident near [venue], we are closed this evening. Please do not travel to us. Your booking will be [moved or refunded] and we will contact you by [time].

Send from the booking system so it reaches tonight's and tomorrow's bookings.

EMAIL · SUPPLIERS AND BOOKING PLATFORMS

> Our booking and payment systems are offline while we investigate. Deliveries continue as booked. Do not act on any request to change bank details; call [known number].

Attackers often follow an outage with fake payment requests.

HOLDING LINE · MEDIA

> We are aware of an incident near [venue] this evening. Our priority is the safety of our guests and team, and we are following police advice. We will share more when we can.

PART 03

Ready for December.

What to do before the first Christmas party, three scenarios to rehearse, a dated plan, and the questions to ask.

01 Festive season readiness

02 Three scenarios

03 Week, month, quarter

04 Questions and checklist

FESTIVE READINESS

Six steps before the first Christmas party

The weeks to New Year bring the biggest crowds, the most new staff and the longest nights. Finish these now.

01 Count your peak nights

Work out how many people, including staff, can reasonably be expected on your busiest nights, function rooms and terraces included. It decides your tier.[4,6]

02 Name the duty manager for every night

Publish who decides on each shift until 2 January, with an on-call general manager behind them.

03 Brief every seasonal starter

A short induction on the four procedures and their role, as in the Home Office restaurant example.[5]

04 Walk through a lockdown

Ten minutes with the late shift: which doors lock, where guests go, who checks the toilets and terrace.

05 Load every contact, including agency staff

Mobile numbers for everyone on the rota, tested with a short alert that asks for a reply.

06 Plan for the outage

Paper booking lists, an offline payment or cash procedure and a known number for every supplier.

SCENARIOS

Three illustrative scenarios to rehearse

CITY-CENTRE BAR AND NIGHTCLUB, 900 CAPACITY

A fight spills inside, then reports of a weapon outside

THE TRIGGER

Door staff see a crowd running towards the entrance at 01:00.

WHAT HURTS

Music still playing and nobody sure who decides.

WHAT HELPS

A code phrase, doors that lock in seconds and staff who own sections.

REHEARSE

A five-minute lockdown drill before opening.

HOTEL, 140 BEDROOMS AND A FUNCTION SUITE

A fire alarm during a 300-guest Christmas party

THE TRIGGER

Smoke in the kitchen at 21:30 with the suite full and bedrooms occupied.

WHAT HURTS

Party guests returning for coats and drivers blocking the fire lane.

WHAT HELPS

Section sweeps, a guest list by room and a clear assembly point.

REHEARSE

A walk-through with the events team and night porter.

RESTAURANT GROUP, 12 SITES

Booking and payment systems fail on the last Saturday before Christmas

THE TRIGGER

Card terminals and the booking platform fail at 18:00 across all sites.

WHAT HURTS

Each manager calling IT separately and guests turned away at the door.

WHAT HELPS

Printed booking lists, a cash procedure and one acknowledged instruction to every site.

REHEARSE

One site running on paper for an hour.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure, and date every action.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Name a duty manager for every night to New Year. Brief the four procedures and the code phrase at every shift start.	General manager
This week	Load every staff mobile, including agency and seasonal staff, and test an alert that asks for a reply.	Operations manager
This month	Count peak numbers for every site and room. Decide your likely tier and who the responsible person is.	Head of security, with legal
This month	Write one page per site: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication. Walk through lockdown on a late shift.	General manager
This quarter	Prepare for SIA notification within three months of commencement. Enhanced tier: designate a senior individual and start the compliance document.	Chief operating officer
This quarter	Run a joint exercise with head office on an attack nearby and a system outage. Report gaps and dated fixes to the board.	Head of security

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your leadership team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

THE DUTY

- ? Which of our sites are likely to be standard tier, which enhanced, and who is the responsible person for each?
- ? Could every site evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate tonight, and when was it last practised?
- ? Who on tonight's rota can declare a lockdown without asking anyone?

THE PEOPLE

- ? How long would it take to reach every member of staff on duty, and to know who had not replied?
- ? How would we reach guests in bedrooms, on terraces and in private dining rooms?
- ? Are our seasonal and agency staff briefed to the same standard as the regulars?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready for Martyn's Law?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Peak numbers counted for every site**
  Including staff, function rooms and outside areas.

- [ ] **Four procedures written for every site**
  Evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.

- [ ] **A named duty manager on every shift**
  With authority to act at once.

- [ ] **Every staff member briefed on their role**
  Including seasonal, agency and night staff.

- [ ] **One alert reaches everyone on duty**
  With replies tracked and non-responders chased.

- [ ] **A way to reach guests in bedrooms**
  And in toilets, terraces and private rooms.

- [ ] **Outage procedures for bookings and payments**
  Tested on a real shift.

- [ ] **Ready to notify the SIA**
  And, for enhanced tier, a senior individual named.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Martyn's Law
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, named after Martyn Hett, who was killed at Manchester Arena.

Responsible person
The person or organisation in control of qualifying premises for the use that brings them into scope.

Standard tier
Premises where 200 to 799 people, including staff, can reasonably be expected at the same time.

Enhanced tier
Premises where 800 or more people can reasonably be expected at the same time.

Public protection procedures
Actions staff can take if they suspect an attack: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.

Public protection measures
Wider enhanced tier measures on monitoring, movement, physical security and information security.

Invacuation
Moving people away from danger to a safer place inside the premises.

Lockdown
Securing the premises to stop people entering or leaving.

Reasonably practicable
Proportionate: weighing what a step achieves against its cost, time and difficulty.

Immediate vicinity
The area close to the premises. There is no fixed distance.

SIA
The Security Industry Authority, the regulator for Martyn's Law.

Senior individual
The person an organisation must designate for enhanced tier premises.

Acknowledgement
A recipient's confirmation that an alert has been read and acted on.

Holding line
A short, accurate statement used while facts are still being established.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When an attack happens outside a busy venue at 22:15, the alert is minute one. Protecting guests depends on every member of staff knowing their role, lockdown or invacuation starting at once, guests being told clearly, and a record of the first fifteen minutes.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits on the night

How the steps in this playbook map to Crises Control modules.

Send one lockdown or evacuation alert to every member of staff on duty by SMS, push and voice, and see who has replied.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Give door staff and duty managers a one-touch way to raise the alarm, with their location.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Turn the four procedures and each shift role into tasks with owners, so nothing depends on memory.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
Run the incident from one workspace with one log, shared by the site, the on-call manager and head office.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
See which sites are affected, who has acknowledged and where escalations are waiting.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Keep a timestamped record of every alert and decision for the review, the insurer and the regulator.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your hospitality organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Every member of staff on shift reached in seconds, including agency and new starters.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement from each area of the venue, with escalation when one stays silent.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One duty manager can start evacuation, invacuation or lockdown for the whole site.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by the duty manager, security, head office and emergency services liaison.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Public protection procedures under Martyn's Law run as owned tasks.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of staff, areas secured and guests accounted for.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that shows what the venue did and when, for the regulator or an inquiry.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Shift-level drills, including the festive season and the busiest nights.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own hospitality scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A lockdown or invacuation on your busiest night.

02 A fire, medical emergency or spiking incident with guests to protect.

03 A booking or payment system outage during the festive season.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

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contactus@crises-control.com

www.crises-control.com

Request a demo

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Every guest safe.
Every shift ready.

Crises Control helps hotels, bars, restaurants and venues alert every member of staff in seconds, see who has replied, run the incident from one place and keep a full record for the regulator.

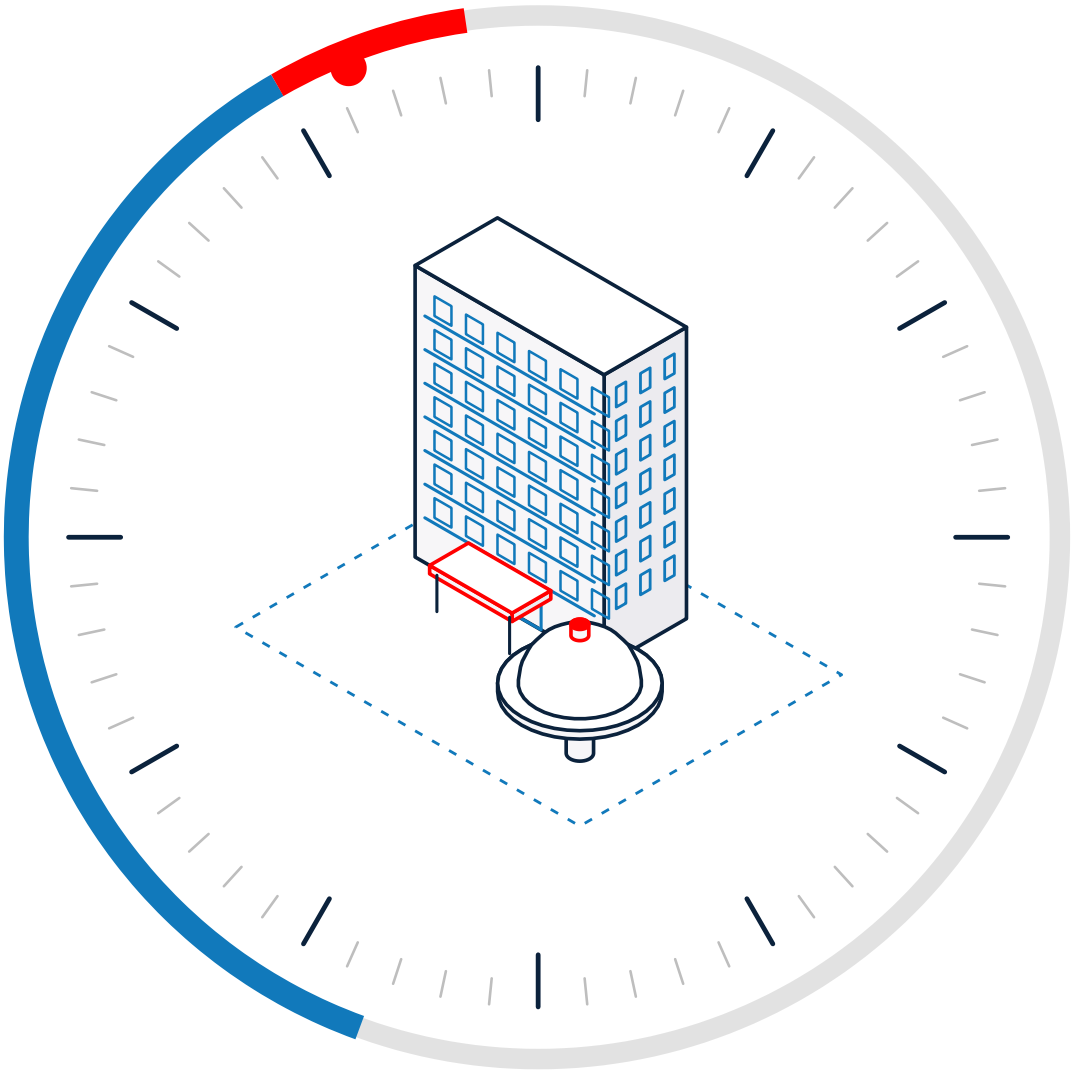
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READ THE COMPANION REPORT

Intelligence report No. 05 · The protect duty



HOSPITALITY · INTELLIGENCE REPORT

The protect duty.

Martyn's Law, the Manchester Arena Inquiry and the first minutes of an attack. What the evidence shows for UK hotels, bars, pubs, restaurants and venues, and what to do before the duties begin.

INSIDE

Contents

An evidence-based look at Martyn's Law and what it means for hotels, pubs, bars, restaurants and venues: what the Act requires and when, what the Manchester Arena Inquiry and the London Bridge inquests found about the first minutes, and what hospitality leaders should do now.

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Coordination, self-assessment and your demo 20

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Martyn's Law is mostly about people and procedures, and hospitality is at the heart of it.

The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 received Royal Assent on 3 April 2025.[1] It will require the people in control of qualifying premises, including bars, pubs, restaurants, cafés, hotels and nightclubs, to take steps to protect the public from terrorism.[1,2] Premises where 200 to 799 people can reasonably be expected at the same time fall into the standard tier, and those with 800 or more into the enhanced tier.[3] The Security Industry Authority (SIA) will regulate, and expects the Act to come into force in spring 2027; no date has yet been set.[4,5]

When the Bill was assessed in 2024, the Home Office estimated around 154,600 standard tier and 24,300 enhanced tier premises, and the Regulatory Policy Committee noted that the large majority are in the retail and hospitality sectors.[6]

The evidence behind the law points to communication and preparation as much as physical security. The Manchester Arena Inquiry found that a concern about the attacker did not reach anyone who could act on it, and that on the night the emergency plans "were not known by everyone who should have known about them".[7,8] At London Bridge and Borough Market, where attackers entered bars and restaurants, all eight people who died did so within 15 minutes of the attack beginning.[9]

This report sets out what the Act requires and when, what the inquiries found, and the practical steps for UK hospitality leaders before the duties begin.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Do not wait for commencement. Count your peak numbers, write the four procedures, name a decision maker on every shift and make sure one alert reaches every member of staff, then rehearse it before the festive peak.

KEY FINDINGS

Seven things the evidence tells us

01 The law is enacted, but not yet in force.

Royal Assent was on 3 April 2025, with an implementation period of at least 24 months. The SIA expects commencement in spring 2027 and will confirm the date ahead of time.[1,3,4]

02 Hospitality is at the centre of the duty.

Statutory guidance names bars, pubs, restaurants, cafés, hotels and nightclubs among the uses in scope, and most estimated premises are in retail and hospitality.[2,6]

03 For most venues, it is about procedures, not kit.

Standard tier premises need evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication procedures so far as is reasonably practicable; the Act does not require physical alterations or equipment.[10]

04 Plans fail when the people on shift do not know them.

The Manchester Arena Inquiry found that plans were not known, not always clear, not always understood and not always put into practice.[8]

05 Communication breaks at single points.

A concern passed between stewards stalled on a busy radio channel, and a police declaration of Operation Plato was not passed to the other emergency services.[7,8]

06 The first minutes are decided on site.

At London Bridge and Borough Market the attack lasted about ten minutes, and all eight victims died within 15 minutes of it beginning.[9]

07 The same capability covers likelier emergencies.

Police received 6,732 spiking reports in a year, 80% in night-time economy venues; cyber incidents can take booking channels offline.[11,12]

AT A GLANCE

Martyn's Law and hospitality, in six figures

Each figure is sourced. The premises estimates are from the 2024 impact assessment and may change.

3 April 2025

Royal Assent for the Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025.[1]

200 and 800

People who can reasonably be expected at once, including staff, that mark the standard and enhanced tiers.[3]

154,600

Estimated standard tier premises, alongside 24,300 enhanced tier, mostly retail and hospitality.[6]

£18m or 5%

Maximum penalty for enhanced duty premises, of worldwide revenue. Standard duty: up to £10,000.[13]

149

Recommendations in Volume 2 of the Manchester Arena Inquiry, on the emergency response.[8]

6,732

Spiking reports to police from May 2022 to April 2023, 80% of them in night-time economy venues.[11]

TIMELINE

From Manchester to commencement

Key dates. The commencement date has not yet been set.

22 May 2017 — **Manchester Arena attack**
22 people are killed at the end of a concert.[4]

3 June 2017 — **London Bridge and Borough Market**
Attackers move through a restaurant courtyard, bars and a restaurant; eight people are killed.[9]

17 June 2021 — **Inquiry Volume 1**
Security arrangements at the Arena; the chair sets out key elements of a Protect Duty.[7]

6 September 2022 — **IHG booking systems disrupted**
The hotel group discloses unauthorised activity that significantly disrupted booking channels and apps.[12]

3 November 2022 — **Inquiry Volume 2**
The emergency response, with 149 recommendations.[8]

3 April 2025 — **Royal Assent**
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 becomes law.[1]

15 April 2026 — **Statutory guidance**
Home Office guidance is laid; the SIA consults on its own guidance until 12 June.[2,4,14]

14 July 2026 — **Notification rules**
Guidance sets three months from commencement for premises to notify the SIA.[15]

Spring 2027 — **Expected commencement**
The SIA's expectation. The date will be set by statutory instrument.[4,5]

PART 01

The law.

What the Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025 requires of hospitality, exactly, and what it does not.

01 What the Act requires

02 Two tiers compared

03 What the duty is, and is not

THE LAW

What the Act requires, and of whom

> **For most hospitality venues, the duty is a set of procedures that every shift can follow.**

The Act's long title describes its purpose: to require persons with control of certain premises or events to take steps to reduce the vulnerability of the premises or event to, and the risk of physical harm to individuals arising from, acts of terrorism, and to confer related functions on the SIA.[1]

It applies to premises wholly or mainly used for purposes in Schedule 1. Statutory guidance says the food and drink use "includes bars, pubs, restaurants, cafés and food halls", the hotels use includes hostels and holiday parks, and nightclubs sit under entertainment and leisure.[2] The Home Office's own examples include a pub with a beer garden and a hotel with grounds used for dining and events.[3]

Tier depends on numbers. Premises are in the standard tier where 200 or more people, including staff, can reasonably be expected to be present at the same time from time to time, and in the enhanced tier at 800 or more.[3] Qualifying events have an 800-person threshold and further conditions.[3]

Standard tier premises must notify the SIA and have, so far as is reasonably practicable, appropriate public protection procedures: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.[10] The Home Office describes these as simple, low-cost steps.[3] There is no statutory training requirement, but staff with responsibilities must know the procedures and their roles.[10]

Enhanced tier premises must also have public protection measures relating to monitoring, movement, physical safety and security, and security of information; document compliance and give the document to the SIA; and, where the responsible person is an organisation, designate a senior individual.[16]

The SIA will assess compliance through desk-based assessments and inspections, usually with at least 72 hours' notice.[4] Penalties reach £10,000 for standard duty premises and £18m or 5% of worldwide revenue for enhanced duty premises, with daily penalties for continued failure.[13]

TWO TIERS

Standard and enhanced tier, side by side

As stated in Home Office factsheets and guidance. Status as at 9 November 2026.

	STANDARD TIER	ENHANCED TIER
Threshold	200 to 799 people reasonably expected at once, including staff.[3]	800 or more people reasonably expected at once.[3]
Core duty	Public protection procedures: evacuation, invacuation, lockdown, communication.[10]	Procedures plus public protection measures on monitoring, movement, physical security and information.[16]
Paperwork	Notify the SIA within three months of commencement; changes within 28 days.[15]	Notify the SIA; document compliance and send it to the SIA; name a senior individual.[15,16]
Penalties	Up to £10,000; up to £500 a day for continued failure.[13]	£18m or 5% of worldwide revenue; up to £50,000 a day; restriction notices.[13]
Status	Not yet in force. Expected spring 2027.[4]	Not yet in force. Expected spring 2027.[4]

COMMON MISREADINGS

What the duty is, and what it is not

Several claims about Martyn's Law circulate in the trade. This is what the official sources say.

CLAIM	WHAT IS OFTEN ASSUMED	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY
Timing	The law is already in force, or starts on a fixed date in April 2027.	It is not yet in force. The SIA expects spring 2027; the date will be set by statutory instrument.[4,5]
Equipment	Every venue must buy barriers, scanners or new locks.	Standard tier premises are not required to make physical alterations or buy equipment.[3,10]
Training	Staff must complete a specific accredited course.	There is no statutory training requirement, but staff must know the procedures and their role.[10]
Who counts	Only seated customers count towards the threshold.	The numbers include staff, and are those reasonably expected at the same time from time to time.[3]
Who is responsible	The security contractor carries the duty.	The responsible person is whoever controls the premises for the use that brings them into scope.[2]
Guidance	There is nothing to read until the law starts.	Statutory guidance has been in force since 10 April 2026, with factsheets and notification guidance published.[2,14,15]

PART 02

The lessons.

What the Manchester Arena Inquiry and the London Bridge inquests found about the minutes that matter most.

01 Manchester Arena: plans and messages

02 Four ways communication failed

03 Bars, restaurants and the first 15 minutes

MANCHESTER ARENA

Manchester Arena: when the plan and the message do not reach people

> **The concern was raised in time. It did not reach anyone who could act on it.**

On 22 May 2017, 22 people were killed in the attack at the end of a concert at Manchester Arena.[4] The public inquiry reported in three volumes. Volume 1, published on 17 June 2021, found that the security arrangements should have prevented or minimised the devastating impact of the attack, and failed to do so.[7]

One finding is directly relevant to every venue. A member of the public raised a concern about the attacker with a steward around 15 minutes before the concert ended. The steward had no radio. A colleague with a radio tried to report it, but someone else was talking on the channel, and the concern went no further. The inquiry found the efforts made were inadequate, and that there had been enough time to investigate and act.[7]

Volume 2, published on 3 November 2022, examined the emergency response and made 149 recommendations.[8] It found that significant aspects of the response went wrong. The police declaration of Operation Plato, the response to a suspected marauding terrorist attack, was not communicated to the other emergency services as the police plan required, and the fire service did not arrive until over two hours after the attack.[8]

Its conclusion on planning applies far beyond the emergency services: plans "were not known by everyone who should have known about them", were not always clear, not always understood and not always put into practice.[8] It also found single points of failure, and called for checks to make sure that what needed to be done had been done.[8]

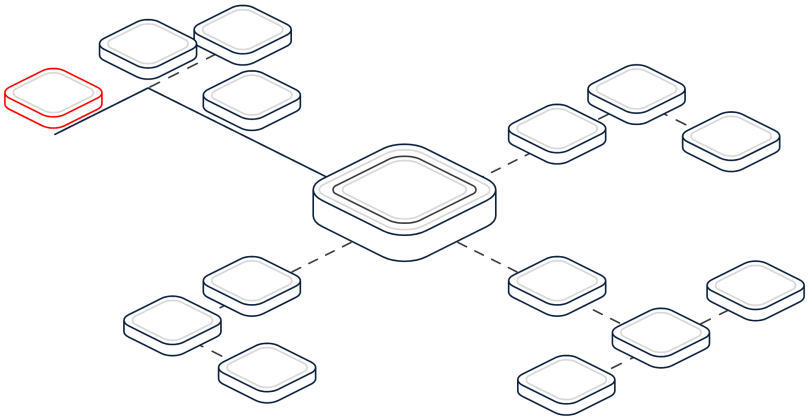
The inquiry recorded that venue staff acted quickly: the head of security instructed staff to divert people away from the scene, and a radio message asked staff with first aid skills to go there.[8] It also called for more members of the public to have first responder skills.[8]

Volume 1 explicitly anticipated a Protect Duty, an obligation for those responsible for publicly accessible locations to consider and implement security measures.[7] Martyn's Law is that duty.

HOW IT FAILS

Four ways communication fails on the night

Drawn from the Manchester Arena Inquiry. Each has a direct equivalent in a busy bar, hotel or restaurant.



01 **No device, no route**

A steward without a radio had to find someone who had one.[7]

02 **A busy channel**

A radio report could not get through because someone else was talking, and was not escalated another way.[7]

03 **A declaration not shared**

A critical declaration was not passed to partners who needed it, as the plan required.[8]

04 **Plans not known**

Responders on the night had little or no knowledge of the plans that applied to them.[8]

BARS AND RESTAURANTS

Bars, restaurants and the first 15 minutes

> **Before police arrive, what happens inside depends on the staff on shift.**

On the evening of 3 June 2017 three attackers drove a van into pedestrians on London Bridge, crashed outside a pub and then attacked people at street level, in a restaurant courtyard and in bars and a restaurant on Stoney Street. Armed officers stopped them about ten minutes after the attack began.[9]

The Chief Coroner found that the emergency operation was generally well managed, and that all eight people who died had suffered injuries that could not have been treated at the scene and died within 15 minutes of the attack beginning.[9] He also recorded police evidence that a clear legal duty on private site owners would help, contrasting the extensive health and safety duties to visitors with the lack of any comparable duty to protect from terrorism.[9]

For hospitality, the lesson is about time. Before police arrive, what happens inside a bar or restaurant depends on staff: whether they recognise what is happening, lock the doors, move guests away from the entrance and tell everyone on site.

Terrorism is, thankfully, rare. Other emergencies are not. The Home Office reported 6,732 police reports of spiking between May 2022 and April 2023, 80% of them in night-time economy venues and almost half in bars.[11] The Crime and Policing Act 2026 includes a new offence of administering a harmful substance, including by spiking; it is not yet in force.[17,18]

Technology failures reach the front desk too. In September 2022 IHG told the stock exchange that unauthorised activity had significantly disrupted its booking channels and apps.[12] A booking or payment outage on a December Saturday is a crisis of a different kind, but it needs the same things: one decision maker, one instruction to every site and confirmation that it has been read.

PART 03

What to do now.

What the evidence means for UK organisations in hospitality, and the steps that close the gap before the duties begin.

01 What it means for UK hospitality

02 Seven recommendations

03 Questions for the board

UK RELEVANCE

What it means for UK organisations in Hospitality

> **A plan that works on a quiet weekday may not work on the last Saturday before Christmas.**

Most hospitality businesses with a busy bar, restaurant, hotel or function room will be in scope of Martyn's Law, and most will be in the standard tier. The duties are not yet in force, but the guidance is published, the notification rules are set and the SIA expects commencement in spring 2027.[2,4,15]

The standard tier is deliberately modest: procedures, not equipment.[3,10] That makes it achievable, and it also puts the weight on the hardest thing in hospitality: getting a varied, often temporary workforce to know what to do on a noisy, crowded night. The Home Office's restaurant example relies on a shift manager who enacts the procedures and an induction briefing for every new starter.[10]

The inquiries show where that breaks. Concerns that do not reach a decision maker. Channels that are busy at the moment they are needed. Plans that exist but are not known.[7,8] Each of these has a practical fix: a named decision maker on every shift, more than one way to raise and send an alert, and a way to confirm who has received it.

The festive season is the sharpest test. Venues are fuller, shifts are longer, many staff are new or temporary, and guests are spread across function rooms, terraces and bedrooms. A plan that works on a quiet weekday may not work on the last Saturday before Christmas.

The same capability serves every emergency. A venue that can lock down and tell every member of staff within a minute can also run a fire evacuation, respond to a spiking report or move to a paper booking list when systems fail. Building it now is good practice whatever the commencement date.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Seven steps before the duties begin

In priority order. Most cost time, not money.

01 Count peak numbers for every site

Include staff and outside areas, and record the method.[3,15]

02 Name the responsible person

And a senior individual for enhanced tier premises.[2,16]

03 Write the four procedures, one page per site

Each with routes, safe areas and named roles.[10]

04 Give every shift a decision maker

A duty manager who can declare a lockdown at once, known to all staff.

05 Make one alert reach everyone, and confirm it

More than one channel, with replies tracked and non-responders chased.[7]

06 Brief every starter, including seasonal staff

A short induction on the procedures and their own role.[10]

07 Rehearse before the festive peak

A lockdown walk-through on a late shift, and a head office exercise.

FOR THE BOARD

Questions boards should ask this quarter

Answers should be specific, dated and owned.

THE DUTY

- ? Which of our sites are likely to be standard tier and which enhanced, and how did we count?
- ? Who is the responsible person for each site, and who is our senior individual?
- ? Are we ready to notify the SIA within three months of commencement?

THE NIGHT

- ? Could every site evacuate, invacuate, lock down and communicate tonight, and when was it last practised?
- ? How long would it take to reach every member of staff on duty, and to know who had not replied?
- ? Are seasonal and agency staff briefed to the same standard as permanent staff?

GLOSSARY

Terms used in this report

Martyn's Law
The Terrorism (Protection of Premises) Act 2025, named after Martyn Hett, who was killed at Manchester Arena.

Protect Duty
The proposal, discussed in the Manchester Arena Inquiry, that became Martyn's Law.

Responsible person
Whoever controls qualifying premises for the use that brings them into scope.

Standard and enhanced tier
Premises where 200 to 799, or 800 or more, people can reasonably be expected at once.

Public protection procedures
Evacuation, invacuation, lockdown and communication.

Public protection measures
Enhanced tier measures on monitoring, movement, physical security and information.

Invacuation
Moving people away from danger to a safer place inside the premises.

Reasonably practicable
Proportionate: weighing what a step achieves against its cost, time and difficulty.

SIA
The Security Industry Authority, regulator for Martyn's Law.

Commencement
The date a provision of an Act comes into force, set by statutory instrument.

Prospective
A provision that is law but not yet in force.

Operation Plato
In 2017, the emergency services' designation for the response to a marauding terrorist firearms attack.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When an attack happens outside a busy venue at 22:15, the alert is minute one. Protecting guests depends on every member of staff knowing their role, lockdown or invacuation starting at once, guests being told clearly, and a record of the first fifteen minutes.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your hospitality organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Every member of staff on shift reached in seconds, including agency and new starters.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement from each area of the venue, with escalation when one stays silent.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One duty manager can start evacuation, invacuation or lockdown for the whole site.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by the duty manager, security, head office and emergency services liaison.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Public protection procedures under Martyn's Law run as owned tasks.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of staff, areas secured and guests accounted for.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that shows what the venue did and when, for the regulator or an inquiry.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Shift-level drills, including the festive season and the busiest nights.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

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Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

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03 A booking or payment system outage during the festive season.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

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10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

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CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 06

WEEK OF 14 DECEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



HEALTHCARE

Major incident, minute one.

Ransomware on the pathology system, a chiller failure in a heatwave, a surge in winter. How to declare, call staff in, switch to paper and keep patients safe when the systems go down.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

Contents

A practical playbook for NHS trusts and independent healthcare providers: how to declare, mobilise staff, run downtime procedures and keep patients safe in the first hour of a business continuity, critical or major incident, including a cyber attack on clinical systems.

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FOREWORD

In healthcare, an IT incident becomes a patient safety incident within the hour.

On 3 June 2024 a ransomware attack on Synnovis, the pathology provider for major hospitals in south east London, stopped normal blood testing. Guy's and St Thomas' and King's College Hospital declared a critical incident the next morning.[1] NHS England later reported that 10,152 acute outpatient appointments and 1,710 elective procedures had been postponed at the two trusts.[2] Because blood could not be matched in the usual way, NHS Blood and Transplant asked O type donors to book urgently.[3]

In June 2025 King's College Hospital confirmed that a long wait for a blood test result, caused by the attack, was one of the factors that contributed to a patient's death.[4] In April 2026, almost two years on, one mental health trust in the area was still working in business continuity for pathology.[5] And in the summer of 2026 trusts declared critical incidents when chillers failed in a heatwave and when IT systems went down.[6,7]

This playbook is for the people who carry the bleep when that happens: accountable emergency officers, EPRR and business continuity leads, on-call managers and directors, digital, nursing and communications teams, in NHS trusts and in independent providers that deliver NHS-funded care. It covers the first hour, the downtime that follows and the plan to be ready before the next one. The companion intelligence report sets out the evidence in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three things decide how the first hour goes.

Every trust has an incident response plan and a business continuity plan. The ones that cope best on the day have rehearsed three simple things until they are habits.

Declare early, in the right words

Use the NHS England definitions for business continuity, critical and major incidents, and the standard message formats, so partners know exactly what you mean.[8]

Know who is coming in

Reach on-call staff, ward leaders and off-duty teams in minutes, and know who has acknowledged, who is on the way and who has not answered.

Make downtime safe

Paper requests, manual result reporting, safe blood and clear handovers, practised before the systems fail, so patient care does not depend on the network.

The network can go down. Patient care cannot.

A cyber attack, a power cut or a failed cooling plant all end in the same place: clinicians working without the systems they rely on, and patients who need to be told what is happening.

PART 01

Declare and decide.

Agree the words, the thresholds and who can say them, before the day you need them.

01 Three declarations, exact words

02 Why declaring early matters

03 A healthcare severity ladder

DEFINITIONS

Three declarations, in NHS England's words

From the NHS EPRR Framework, version 3, July 2022. Use them exactly, and always say who declared it.[8]

DECLARATION	DEFINITION	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE
Business continuity incident	"an event or occurrence that disrupts, or might disrupt, an organisation's normal service delivery, to below acceptable pre-defined levels. This would require special arrangements to be put in place until services can return to an acceptable level."	Your business continuity plan is running. Examples in the framework include a surge in demand, a utilities breakdown and significant equipment failure.
Critical incident	"any localised incident where the level of disruption results in an organisation temporarily or permanently losing its ability to deliver critical services; or where patients and staff may be at risk of harm."	Principally an internal escalation. You need support from partners across the system to restore normal operating functions.
Major incident	Defined by the Cabinet Office and JESIP as "an event or situation with a range of serious consequences that require special arrangements to be implemented by one or more emergency responder agency."	Usually multi-agency. There are no universal triggers; the decision is made in a local, operational context.
Format	"Critical Incident declared by (organisation)". For major incidents: standby, declared, cancelled or stand down.	Tell your ICB, which reports to NHS England through regional on-call.[8]

DECLARE AND DECIDE

Why the first decision is the hardest, and the most important

> **Declaring is how you get the right people moving. Waiting for certainty puts you two hours behind the wards.**

Nobody wants to declare too soon. A critical incident is a public signal, it pulls in partners and it can feel like an admission. So the first hour often goes on fixing the problem quietly, while wards improvise and the on-call director hears about it second hand.

The NHS framework is clear that a critical incident is principally an internal escalation response to increased system pressures or disruption to services that will affect the ability to deliver safe patient care.[8] It exists to bring in help. When East Kent Hospitals declared one over IT problems in July 2026, it said the declaration let it keep patients safe by drawing on support from colleagues across the health system.[7]

Declaring is also how you get the right people moving. An on-call manager who declares a business continuity incident at 08:15 can start the downtime procedures, call in the pathology and digital leads and warn the emergency department. One who waits for certainty at 10:00 is two hours behind the wards.

So set the triggers in advance. Loss of a clinical system that supports results, prescribing or patient flow for more than a set time. Any suspected cyber attack on a clinical system. Loss of power, water, cooling or medical gases to a clinical area. A surge that takes the organisation to its highest operational pressure level under the OPEL framework.[9] Write them down, give named roles the authority to declare and tell them they will never be criticised for declaring early and standing down.

Use the agreed words. NHS England asks for the format “Critical Incident declared by (organisation)”, and the four standard major incident messages: standby, declared, cancelled and stand down.[8] Share facts with partners in METHANE or SBAR form, which the framework sets out, including an example for a cyber incident.[8]

Then tell your own staff, in the same words, at the same time. A declaration that reaches the ICB before it reaches the wards has gone the wrong way round.

SEVERITY

A healthcare severity ladder for the first hour

An internal scale for alerting and staffing. It sits alongside the formal EPRR declarations, not instead of them. If in doubt, grade up and step down later.

SEV 1

Major or critical, trust wide

TRIGGERS

Loss of pathology, EPR or prescribing across sites; suspected ransomware; mass casualty major incident declared by your trust or the ambulance service; loss of power or water to clinical areas.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Executive on call, AEO, incident team, all clinical leads, digital, comms; ICB on call informed at once.

`Push, SMS and voice · ack in 5 min`

SEV 2

Critical in one service or site

TRIGGERS

One site's emergency department, theatres or diagnostics unable to work safely; critical system down beyond the agreed time; OPEL 4 with patient safety risk.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Director and manager on call, service and site leads, digital, comms.

`Push and SMS · ack in 10 min`

SEV 3

Business continuity incident

TRIGGERS

Planned downtime overrunning; single system or equipment failure with a working fallback; staffing gap in one area; supplier outage.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Manager on call, service leads, EPRR lead.

`Push and email · ack in 30 min`

SEV 4

Watch and prepare

TRIGGERS

Supplier warning, heat or cold alert, cyber advisory affecting your systems, rising pressure.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

EPRR lead, digital, site team.

`Email and app · no ack needed`

PART 02

Mobilise.

Reach the right people, know who is coming, and say the same thing to everyone.

01 The first hour, minute by minute

02 Call-in and acknowledgement

03 Messages ready to send

04 Three scenarios

THE FIRST HOUR

Monday, 08:10: the lab goes dark

An illustrative acute trust. Treat it as a cyber attack until proved otherwise.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Laboratory staff report the system is down** Lab manager calls the site manager and digital service desk. No results are going out.	LAB MANAGER
T+00:05	**On-call manager grades it SEV 1** Business continuity incident declared. Executive on call and AEO alerted. Digital isolates systems.	MANAGER ON CALL
T+00:10	**Call-in alert sent** Incident team, pathology, transfusion, ED, theatres, critical care, comms. Reply with arrival time.	SITE MANAGER
T+00:15	**Downtime procedures start** Paper requests and phoned urgent results; transfusion to its downtime plan. Clinical leads review today's planned care.	PATHOLOGY LEAD
T+00:20	**Cyber reporting route** Digital lead calls the NHS England cyber security operations centre, which is monitored 24/7.[10] NIS operators prepare a DSPT report within 72 hours.[11]	CHIEF DIGITAL OFFICER
T+00:30	**Critical incident declared** “Critical Incident declared by (trust)”. ICB on call told; testing mutual aid requested.	EXECUTIVE ON CALL
T+01:00	**Messages out, first meeting held** Holding lines to staff, today's patients and ED. Facts in METHANE form; decisions logged.	INCIDENT DIRECTOR

CALL-IN

Five rules for calling staff in

Most trusts have a cascade. Few know, in real time, who has answered.

01 Alert by role, not by name

Lists are built around roles and rotas: the on-call transfusion scientist, the theatre coordinator, the matron on duty. People change; roles do not.

02 Ask for an answer, not a read receipt

Every call-in asks a question: available now, available later, not available. Silence after the set time escalates to a deputy automatically.

03 Use more than one channel

Push, SMS and voice. If the incident is a cyber attack, assume trust email and Teams may be down or untrusted.

04 Protect people off duty

Ask for what you need and no more. Track hours so the people who come in at 08:30 are not still there at midnight. Plan the second shift in the first hour.

05 Stand down in the same way

Release staff with a message as clear as the one that called them in, and tell them when the hot debrief will be.

REMEMBER

If you cannot see who has acknowledged within ten minutes, you do not yet know whether you have a response team.

MESSAGES

Six messages ready to send

Short, specific and honest. Fill the brackets, do not speculate on cause, and always give the time of the next update.

SMS · ON-CALL STAFF 134 chars

> [Trust] critical incident: lab systems down. Incident team to [room] now. Reply 1 coming, 2 later, 3 not available. Next update 09:00.

Send by role. Escalate no reply after 10 minutes.

PUSH · ALL CLINICAL STAFF

> Pathology systems unavailable. Use paper request forms and phone urgent results via [extension]. Transfusion is on downtime procedures. Do not use [system] until told. Update at 09:30.

Pin it in the app; repeat at each handover.

SMS · PATIENTS BOOKED TODAY 133 chars

> [Trust]: we have an IT problem affecting blood tests. Please attend as planned unless we contact you. Info: [web page]. Do not reply.

Approved by clinical leads first.

WEB AND PHONE · PUBLIC HOLDING LINE

> We have declared a critical incident because of an IT problem affecting pathology. Emergency care is open. Please use NHS 111, your GP or a pharmacy for non-urgent needs. We will update this page at [time].

Same words on the switchboard message.

EMAIL · ICB AND PARTNERS

> Critical Incident declared by [trust] at [time]. METHANE summary attached. Requests: urgent testing mutual aid, ambulance awareness. Next sitrep [time].

From the incident log, not from memory.

SMS · COMMUNITY AND LONE STAFF 118 chars

> [Trust]: IT incident. Visits go ahead. Use paper notes, call [number] for results. Check in at 12:00 and on finishing.

Ask for a reply to confirm they are safe.

IN PRACTICE

Three providers, three first hours

ACUTE TRUST, THREE SITES

Ransomware at a pathology partner

THE GAP

The lab is run by a partner; nobody at the trust was on its incident call list.

THE CHECK

A joint exercise with the partner, timed from first report to first paper result.

THE FIX

Joint call-in list and shared incident log with the partner; downtime forms printed on every ward.

WATCH OUT

Transfusion needs its own downtime plan; agree O type use with the blood bank.

COMMUNITY TRUST, 1,200 FIELD STAFF

EPR outage during a cold snap

THE GAP

Visit lists live only in the electronic record; staff were already on the road.

THE CHECK

Every lone worker confirmed safe by the end of the shift.

THE FIX

Daily offline visit lists, a check-in rule for lone workers and SMS updates that need no app login.

WATCH OUT

About one in seven NHS staff reported physical violence from patients or the public in the 2025 staff survey.[12]

INDEPENDENT PROVIDER, NHS CONTRACT

Cooling failure in a heatwave

THE GAP

Theatres and the server room relied on the same chiller plant.

THE CHECK

Temperature triggers written into the severity ladder.

THE FIX

A business continuity incident declared and the ICB told; lists moved to a partner site.

WATCH OUT

The NHS Standard Contract requires providers of NHS-funded services to comply with EPRR guidance.[8]

PART 03

Keep patients safe.

Downtime, partners, patients and staff, from the first hour to the last debrief.

01 Downtime that works

02 Working with system partners

03 Winter, heat and long incidents

04 Your plan

KEEP PATIENTS SAFE

Downtime procedures: the plan you hope never to use

> **Can a ward request an urgent blood test, get the result and act on it safely with no computers at all?**

Most clinical areas have a downtime folder. The question is whether anyone has opened it this year. The test is simple: can a ward request an urgent blood test, receive the result and act on it safely with no computers at all? If the answer depends on one person who knows how, it is not a procedure.

Synnovis showed how long downtime can last. NHS England reported that services in south east London were largely restored by the end of 2024, but in early 2026 one trust estimated that entering 161,560 pathology reports into patient records had been delayed, and it had recorded 122 patient safety incidents involving incorrect, unavailable or delayed results.[5] Recovery has its own risks: results back-entered weeks later, duplicate records and patients lost to follow-up.

Blood is the sharpest edge. When hospitals cannot match blood in the usual way they rely on O type blood, which is safe for all patients. That is why NHS Blood and Transplant appealed for O negative and O positive donors within a week of the attack.[3] Every transfusion laboratory needs a downtime plan agreed with clinicians, including who authorises O type use.

Good downtime procedures are short, printed and practised. They name the forms, the phone numbers, the runners and the order of priority: emergency department, critical care, maternity, theatres, then the rest. They say how results will be checked and entered when systems return. And they are tested in exercises with the people who will use them, not just the people who wrote them.

Treat the cyber attack as different from the power cut in one way: you may not be able to trust the systems even when they come back. Keep digital and clinical leads in the same incident meeting. The 2017 WannaCry review found that local staff shared information by personal mobile phones and WhatsApp when email was lost.[13] Decide your out-of-band channel now, before staff choose one for you.

SYSTEM PARTNERS

Who needs to hear from you, and when

A declared incident is rarely yours alone. Agree these routes in advance and test them in exercises.

ICB and NHS England

Tell your ICB on call when you declare. The ICB reports to NHS England through regional on-call, and coordinates mutual aid.[8]

Ambulance service

If you need diverts or redirection, say so early. The framework lists ambulance redirection as a reason to notify.[8]

Suppliers and partners

Pathology, imaging, EPR and facilities partners belong on your call-in lists, and you on theirs.

GPs, social care, the public

Primary care, care homes and patients need to know what still works and where to go instead.

Report cyber incidents to the NHS England cyber security operations centre straight away.[10] Operators of essential services report network and information system incidents through the DSPT within 72 hours.[11]

LONG INCIDENTS

Winter, heat and the incident that does not end

Many healthcare incidents are rising tides, not explosions. They need a different rhythm.

PRESSURE	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Winter surge	Escalation drifts from OPEL 3 to 4 without a declared incident or extra staff.	Triggers that link OPEL levels to your severity ladder and call-in lists.[9]
Heat	Chillers and server rooms fail together; theatres and scanners stop.	Temperature triggers, cooling checks and a plan for diagnostics, as trusts learned in June 2026.[6]
Long cyber recovery	Staff run on paper for weeks with no rota change or welfare plan.	A recovery cell, shift patterns, welfare checks and a plan for back-entering results.
Lone and community staff	Visits continue with no way to raise an alarm if systems are down.	Check-in times, one-touch alarms and visit lists that work offline.
Communication fatigue	Updates stop once the crisis feels normal.	Fixed update times for staff and patients until stand down.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Write declaration triggers and who can declare. Check call-in lists by role, with tested numbers for every on-call rota.	Accountable emergency officer
This week	Confirm the out-of-band channel if email and Teams are lost. Print downtime forms for every clinical area.	Chief digital officer
This month	Agree downtime plans with pathology, transfusion, imaging and pharmacy partners, including results back-entry.	Chief medical officer
This month	Load the six message templates. Set a lone worker check-in rule for community teams.	Head of comms; chief nurse
This month	Swap incident contacts with every clinical supplier. Agree how they will alert you and how you will alert them.	Chief operating officer
This quarter	Link OPEL levels, heat and cold alerts to the severity ladder before winter peaks.	EPRR lead
This quarter	Run a no-notice call-in test and a cyber downtime exercise with a key supplier. Time first paper result.	EPRR lead
This quarter	Report results, gaps and dated actions to the board alongside the annual EPRR core standards return.	Accountable emergency officer

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your executive team

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

READINESS

- ? Who can declare a critical incident tonight, and do they know the triggers?
- ? How long would it take to know who is coming in after a call-in?
- ? Could each ward get an urgent blood result with no computers?

PARTNERS AND PEOPLE

- ? Are our pathology, imaging and EPR suppliers on our incident call lists, and are we on theirs?
- ? How would we reach community staff if the record system and email were both down?
- ? Who looks after the people who worked the first twelve hours?

CHECKLIST

Ready for minute one?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Declaration triggers written and owned**
  Using the EPRR definitions and standard formats.

- [ ] **Call-in lists by role, with acknowledgement**
  Tested out of hours in the last quarter.

- [ ] **Downtime procedures printed and practised**
  Including transfusion and results back-entry.

- [ ] **Out-of-band channel agreed**
  For use when email and Teams cannot be trusted.

- [ ] **Suppliers on your incident lists**
  And your team on theirs.

- [ ] **Message templates approved**
  Staff, patients, partners, public and lone workers.

- [ ] **Lone worker check-in rule**
  Works with no access to the record system.

- [ ] **Hot debrief within 48 hours of stand down**
  As the EPRR framework expects, with welfare support.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

EPRR
Emergency preparedness, resilience and response: the NHS England programme and framework for incidents and emergencies.

Accountable emergency officer
The board-level executive responsible for EPRR in an NHS-funded organisation.

Business continuity incident
Disruption below acceptable levels that needs special arrangements until services recover.

Critical incident
Localised loss of ability to deliver critical services, or risk of harm to patients and staff.

Major incident
An event with serious consequences needing special arrangements by one or more responder agencies.

OPEL
Operational pressures escalation levels, from 1 to 4, used to describe pressure on services.

METHANE
A JESIP format for sharing incident information: major incident, exact location, type, hazards, access, number of casualties, emergency services.

SBAR
Situation, background, assessment, recommendation: a structured way to escalate.

Downtime procedure
How a service works safely when a clinical system is unavailable.

Mutual aid
Help from other organisations, such as testing capacity or staff, during an incident.

Hot debrief
A short review straight after an incident, within 48 hours of stand down.

DSPT
The Data Security and Protection Toolkit, used by health bodies to report security incidents.

ICB
Integrated care board: plans and coordinates NHS services across a local area, with 24/7 on-call.

Out-of-band channel
A way to communicate that does not depend on the systems that may be compromised.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When pathology goes down at 08:10, the alert is minute one. Keeping patients safe depends on who declared what, which staff came in, which downtime procedures started, what partners and patients were told, and a record for the after-action review.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits in a healthcare incident

How the steps in this playbook map to Crises Control modules.

Call in on-call staff and clinical leads by role, see who has acknowledged and escalate non-responders to deputies automatically.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Run the incident from one workspace with one log, shared by the incident team, digital, partners and the ICB liaison.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
Turn downtime procedures, transfusion steps and results back-entry into tasks with owners and deadlines.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
See which sites and services are affected, what has been done and where escalations are waiting.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Give community and lone staff a one-touch alarm with their location.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Keep a timestamped record of every message and decision for the hot debrief and the post-incident report.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your healthcare organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Clinical, on-call and support staff reached on several channels, at any hour.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Call-in responses tracked, with escalation when key roles stay silent.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Declaration and escalation follow the EPRR framework by role.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by the incident team, clinical leads, partners and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Downtime procedures run as owned tasks in every affected department.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of staff mobilised, services affected and actions outstanding.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that supports EPRR assurance, the ICO and the after-action review.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Exercises that include a cyber attack on clinical systems, not just a major incident.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own healthcare scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A cyber attack that takes a clinical system or pathology offline.

02 A major incident that needs staff called in out of hours.

03 A winter pressure or heatwave critical incident across several sites.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

+44 (0) 20 8584 1385

contactus@crises-control.com

www.crises-control.com

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Every clinician reached, every patient safe.

Crises Control helps NHS trusts and independent providers call staff in by role, see who has acknowledged, run downtime procedures as tasks and keep a full record for the debrief.

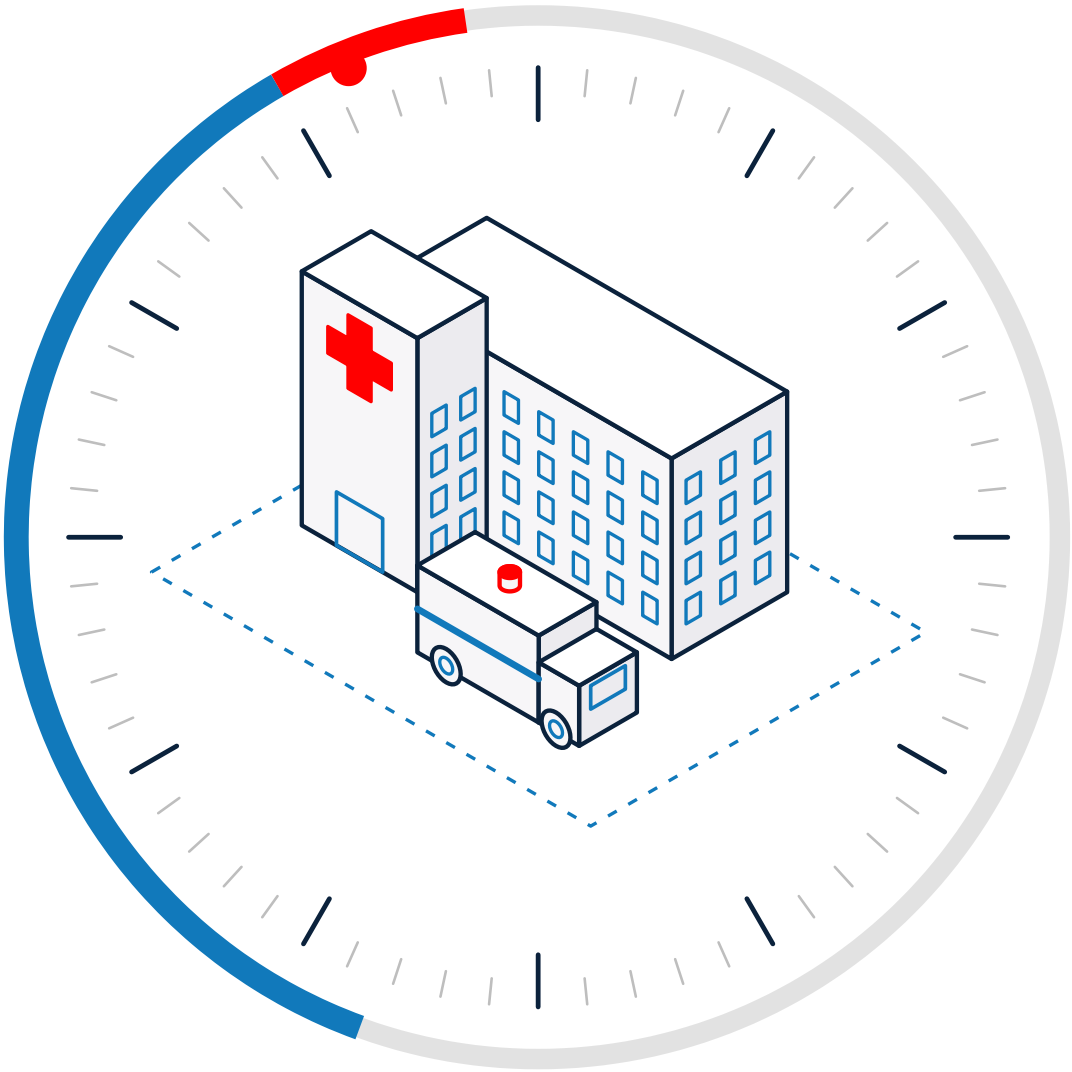
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READ THE COMPANION REPORT

Intelligence report No. 06 · When the lab went dark



HEALTHCARE · INTELLIGENCE REPORT

When the lab went dark.

The Synnovis attack, two years on. What happens to patients, blood stocks and staff when a clinical system fails, and what the evidence says about getting the first hour right.

INSIDE

Contents

An evidence-based look at the 2024 Synnovis ransomware attack and its long tail, what WannaCry taught the NHS, how the EPRR framework expects trusts to respond, and what UK healthcare providers should do before the next incident.

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Coordination, self-assessment and your demo 21

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

One laboratory outage. Two years of recovery.

On 3 June 2024 a ransomware attack on Synnovis, which provides pathology services to major hospitals in south east London, stopped normal blood testing. Guy's and St Thomas' and King's College Hospital declared a critical incident the next morning, with blood transfusions particularly affected.[1] NHS England later reported that 10,152 acute outpatient appointments and 1,710 elective procedures were postponed at the two trusts.[2]

The effects travelled far beyond the laboratory. NHS Blood and Transplant appealed for O type donors within a week and in July 2024 issued a national amber alert, saying the London hospitals had needed 94 per cent more O negative blood than a year earlier.[3,4] The alert was not stood down until July 2025.[5] In June 2025 King's College Hospital confirmed that a long wait for a blood test result caused by the attack was one of the factors that contributed to a patient's death.[6]

The recovery was long. In early 2026 one mental health trust estimated that entering 161,560 pathology reports into patient records had been delayed, and patient data stolen in the attack was still being confirmed to trusts in 2026.[7,8] Meanwhile trusts declared critical incidents for IT failures and heat-related cooling failures in the summer of 2026.[9,10]

This report sets out the evidence, compares it with the lessons of WannaCry and the NHS EPRR framework, and ends with practical recommendations.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Assume that a clinical system will fail. Declare early in the agreed words, reach and confirm the right staff in minutes, run practised downtime procedures with your suppliers, and keep patients and partners informed until the last result is back in the record.

KEY FINDINGS

Seven things the evidence tells us

01 A supplier incident is a clinical incident.

Synnovis is a pathology partner, not a trust, but the disruption landed on wards, clinics, GP practices and the blood supply.[1,2,4]

02 The harm was real and is now documented.

Reporting in June 2025 linked 170 cases of patient harm, most of them low harm, to nearly 600 incidents, and a trust confirmed the attack contributed to a death.[6,11]

03 Blood is the sharpest edge.

Without normal matching, hospitals relied on O type blood, and national O negative stocks fell to 1.6 days.[3,4]

04 Recovery takes far longer than response.

Almost two years on, one trust was still in business continuity for pathology results.[7]

05 The communication lessons of 2017 still apply.

After WannaCry the NAO found the local response plan had not been tested and staff fell back on personal phones and WhatsApp.[12]

06 Not every critical incident is cyber.

In 2026 trusts declared critical incidents over IT failures and heat-related cooling failures that stopped theatres and scanners.[9,10,13]

07 The rules are tightening.

Proposed UK law would require an initial incident notice within 24 hours, against 72 hours under the current NIS regime for health.[14,15]

AT A GLANCE

The lab outage, in six figures

Each figure is sourced. Where sources measure different things, we say so in the analysis that follows.

10,152

Acute outpatient appointments postponed at the two most affected trusts, according to NHS England.[2]

1,710

Elective procedures postponed at the same two trusts.[2]

94%

Increase in O negative blood needed by the affected London hospitals, against the same period a year earlier.[4]

170

Cases of patient harm linked to the attack, as reported in June 2025; most were classed as low harm.[11]

161,560

Pathology reports one trust estimated were delayed being entered into patient records, as of early January 2026.[7]

81 of 236

NHS trusts in England affected by WannaCry in 2017, as a minimum, according to the NAO.[12]

TIMELINE

From WannaCry to a summer of critical incidents

Key dates. Later reporting on long incidents can revise earlier figures.

12 May 2017 — **WannaCry**
A worldwide ransomware outbreak disrupts at least 81 NHS trusts in England.[12]

July 2022 — **EPRR framework, version 3**
NHS England sets out business continuity, critical and major incident definitions.[16]

3 to 4 June 2024 — **Synnovis attack**
Critical incident declared at Guy's and St Thomas' and King's College Hospital.[1]

25 July 2024 — **National amber alert**
NHSBT asks hospitals to restrict O type blood to essential cases.[4]

26 November 2024 — **Wirral major incident**
A trust declares a major incident for cyber security reasons.[17]

June 2025 — **Harm confirmed**
A trust confirms the attack contributed to a patient's death.[6]

13 November 2025 — **Review complete**
Synnovis completes its investigation of the stolen data.[18]

June 2026 — **Data and heat**
A trust confirms data on 32,927 patients was stolen; heat forces critical incidents.[8,10]

29 July 2026 — **IT critical incident**
East Kent Hospitals declares a critical incident over IT problems.[9]

PART 01

The attack.

What happened when a pathology partner was hit, and how far the effects travelled.

01 From laboratory to ward

02 How a supplier outage spreads

03 Reading the numbers

THE ATTACK

From laboratory to ward in one morning

> **Pathology sits underneath almost everything a hospital does.**

Synnovis is a pathology partnership that runs laboratory services for hospitals and GP practices in south east London. On Monday 3 June 2024 a ransomware attack took its systems offline. By Tuesday morning Guy's and St Thomas' and King's College Hospital had declared a critical incident, and the chief executive of one trust told staff that blood transfusions were particularly affected.[1]

Pathology sits underneath almost everything a hospital does. Without results, surgeons cannot confirm a patient is fit for theatre, emergency teams wait longer to rule conditions in or out, and GPs cannot manage long-term conditions. NHS England's tally of 10,152 outpatient appointments and 1,710 elective procedures postponed at the two trusts captures only part of that.[2]

Blood was the most visible pressure. NHS Blood and Transplant said the affected hospitals could not match patients' blood at the usual frequency, so they relied on O type blood, which is safe for all patients.[3] On 25 July it issued a national amber alert: O negative stocks stood at 1.6 days and the London hospitals had needed an extra 1.7 days of O negative since June.[4] The alert was stood down from 21 July 2025, almost a year later.[5]

Harm followed. Reporting in June 2025 described nearly 600 incidents linked to the attack, 170 of them involving harm to patients, most of it low harm.[11] The same month King's College Hospital said a patient safety investigation had identified a long wait for a blood test result due to the attack as one of several contributing factors in a patient's death.[6]

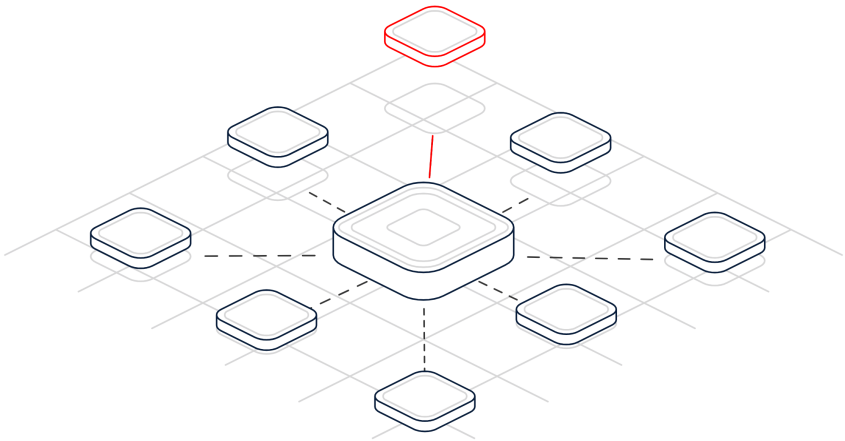
Then came the long tail. Synnovis said in November 2025 that its review of the stolen data was complete; it described the data as unstructured, incomplete and fragmented.[18] In June 2026 Bedfordshire Hospitals confirmed that data on 32,927 of its patients had been taken.[8] And in April 2026 one mental health trust in south London was still in business continuity, with 122 recorded patient safety incidents involving incorrect, unavailable or delayed results.[7]

None of this is a judgement on the people who responded. Clinicians, scientists and managers worked around the clock. It is a measure of how deeply one system runs through modern care.

HOW IT SPREADS

Four routes from one supplier to every patient

How the Synnovis disruption travelled, as described by NHS England, NHSBT and the trusts.



01 **Results stop**

Tests cannot be requested, processed or reported normally, so clinicians work blind or on paper.[1,3]

02 **Planned care slows**

Operations and clinics that depend on results are postponed and rebooked.[2]

03 **Blood stocks fall**

Hospitals use more universal O type blood, which puts pressure on the national supply.[3,4]

04 **Records lag behind**

Results reach patient records months later, and stolen data surfaces years later.[7,8]

READING THE NUMBERS

What each figure actually counts

Figures from long incidents change as reviews finish. None should be read as the full cost to patients.

FIGURE	SOURCE	WHAT IT MEASURES
10,152 and 1,710	NHS England[2]	Outpatient appointments and elective procedures postponed at the two most affected trusts. Excludes GP and other services.
94%	NHSBT, July 2024[4]	Extra O negative blood needed by the affected London hospitals since June, compared with the same period a year earlier.
170	HSJ via PA, June 2025[11]	Cases of harm among nearly 600 incidents linked to the attack. Severity counts differ between reports, so we give only the total.
161,560	Trust estimate via The Record[7]	Pathology reports whose entry into records at one trust had been delayed, as of early January 2026.
32,927	Bedfordshire Hospitals[8]	Patients whose data was stolen. Other trusts have published their own counts.
UK total	Synnovis[18]	Synnovis has not published how many people's data was affected.

PART 02

The pattern.

Synnovis was not the first major incident to start in IT, and it will not be the last.

01 What WannaCry taught the NHS

02 Incidents since 2024

03 What the framework expects

04 Where providers fall short

THE PATTERN

What WannaCry taught, and what it did not

> **The common thread is not the cause. It is the first hour.**

On Friday 12 May 2017 the WannaCry ransomware spread worldwide. The National Audit Office found that at least 81 of the 236 trusts in England were affected, along with 603 primary care and other NHS organisations, including 595 GP practices.[12] NHS England recorded 6,912 cancelled appointments and estimated that over 19,000 would have been cancelled in total. Five A&E departments diverted patients.[12]

The NAO's findings on the response read as a checklist for today. The Department had a plan with defined roles, but had not tested it at a local level. Many local organisations could not reach national NHS bodies by email, and locally staff shared information through personal mobile devices, including WhatsApp.[12]

The NAO also judged that the attack was relatively unsophisticated and could have been prevented by following basic IT security best practice.[12] Since then the government has set a goal for all health and social care organisations to achieve cyber resilience no later than 2030.[19]

Synnovis was different in one important way: the system that failed belonged to a partner. That pattern has repeated. An ICO penalty notice in March 2025 fined Advanced, a software supplier, about £3.07m after a 2022 ransomware attack that disrupted NHS 111 and exposed data, including details of how to gain entry to the homes of 890 people receiving care.[20] In February 2025 HCRG Care Group, a large independent provider of NHS community services, confirmed it was investigating an IT security incident while services continued.[21]

And not every critical incident is a cyber attack. In June 2026 a Portsmouth hospital declared a critical incident when chillers failed in a heatwave, affecting digital systems, theatres, cardiac catheter laboratories and scanning; another trust lost its MRI scanners to the heat.[10,13] In July 2026 East Kent Hospitals declared one over IT problems without, at first, knowing the cause.[9]

The common thread is not the cause. It is the first hour: who declares, who is called in, how staff and patients are told, and whether care can carry on without the system.

SINCE 2024

UK healthcare incidents that started in technology

A selection with public, sourced detail. Causes and impacts are as reported by the organisations or regulators.

INCIDENT	WHAT HAPPENED	WHAT IT SHOWS
WannaCry, May 2017	Ransomware across the NHS; at least 81 trusts affected.[12]	Plans must be tested locally, with a fallback channel.
Synnovis, June 2024	Ransomware at a pathology partner; critical incident at two trusts.[1]	Supplier failure becomes clinical risk and a national blood issue.
Wirral, November 2024	Major incident declared for cyber security reasons; outpatients cancelled.[17]	Trusts do declare major incidents for cyber attacks.
HCRG Care Group, February 2025	Independent provider investigating an IT security incident; services continued.[21]	Independent providers face the same threat.
Advanced, fined March 2025	ICO fine of about £3.07m for a 2022 attack that disrupted NHS 111.[20]	Regulators now act against suppliers.
Heatwave, June 2026	Chillers fail; theatres, cath labs and scanning affected.[10,13]	Estates and digital failures arrive together.
East Kent, July 2026	Critical incident over IT problems of unknown cause.[9]	Declare first; find the cause later.

THE FRAMEWORK

What the NHS framework expects

> **The tools exist. The question is whether they are practised.**

Every NHS-funded organisation works to the NHS Emergency Preparedness, Resilience and Response Framework. Version 3, published in July 2022, defines a business continuity incident, a critical incident and a major incident, and sets incident response levels from 1, managed within one organisation, to 4, led nationally by NHS England.[16]

A critical incident, in the framework's words, is any localised incident where the level of disruption results in an organisation temporarily or permanently losing its ability to deliver critical services, or where patients and staff may be at risk of harm. It is principally an internal escalation response, and the framework asks organisations to use the format “Critical Incident declared by (organisation)”.[16]

The framework also sets out standard major incident messages, the METHANE and SBAR formats for sharing information, a 24/7 on-call system with a director able to allocate resources, and notification to the ICB, which informs NHS England through regional on-call. It expects a hot debrief within 48 hours of stand down and a structured debrief within 28 days.[16]

Compliance is tested every year against the NHS Core Standards for EPRR. The NHS Standard Contract requires providers of NHS-funded services, including independent providers, to comply with EPRR guidance.[16] NHS England grades organisations from fully compliant, meeting 100 per cent of the relevant standards, through substantial and partial to non-compliant, and its 2026/27 process keeps the approach of previous years.[22] In the 2024 round, one acute trust reported assessing itself against 62 core standards, plus a deep dive of 11 standards on cyber security.[23]

Cyber incidents carry extra duties. NHS trusts, foundation trusts, ICBs and certain independent providers are operators of essential services under the NIS Regulations, and must report network and information system incidents through the DSPT no later than 72 hours after becoming aware.[14] The Cyber Security and Resilience Bill proposes an initial notice within 24 hours and a full report within 72 hours; those measures would follow Royal Assent and secondary legislation.[15]

Pressure from demand is measured separately, through the OPEL framework, which makes declaring an incident a decision for the provider under the EPRR framework.[24] The tools exist. The question is whether they are practised.

COMMON GAPS

Where providers fall short in the first hour

The gap is rarely the plan. It is practice, people and partners.

AREA	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Declaring	Teams fix quietly and declare late, waiting for certainty.	Written triggers, named roles with authority, the standard wording.
Calling staff in	Phone trees and email; nobody knows who is coming.	Role-based alerts on several channels, with acknowledgement and escalation.
Suppliers	The lab, EPR or estates partner is not on the call list.	Joint call lists, joint exercises and a shared incident log.
Downtime	Folders exist but have not been used this year.	Printed, practised procedures, including transfusion and results back-entry.
Communication	Staff rely on personal messaging when email fails.	An agreed out-of-band channel and fixed update times.
Recovery	The incident is closed while results are still missing.	A recovery cell and debriefs on the framework's timetable.
Staff welfare	The same people work the first twelve hours and the next day.	Rotas planned in the first hour, welfare checks and a clear stand down.

PART 03

What to do now.

What the evidence means for UK healthcare providers, and the steps that close the gap.

01 What it means for UK healthcare

02 Recommendations

03 Questions for the board

UK RELEVANCE

What it means for UK organisations in healthcare

> **If your laboratory system went dark at 08:10 tomorrow, who would declare?**

For NHS trusts, the lesson of Synnovis is that resilience now runs through partners. Pathology networks, imaging, electronic records, estates and community services are often delivered by other organisations. If they are not on your incident call lists, and you are not on theirs, the first hour will be spent finding phone numbers.[1,18]

For independent providers with NHS contracts, the expectations are the same. The NHS Standard Contract requires compliance with EPRR guidance, and certain independent providers are operators of essential services under the NIS Regulations.[14,16] The 2025 attack on HCRG Care Group showed that the threat does not distinguish between sectors.[21]

For boards, the question is not whether a plan exists. The NAO's finding after WannaCry was that the plan had not been tested locally.[12] Annual EPRR assurance asks the question every year; boards should ask it more often, and ask for evidence: time to declare, time to confirm staff, time to first paper result.[22]

For winter, the risks stack. An IT failure on a day at the highest OPEL level, with staff sickness and full emergency departments, leaves little slack. Linking OPEL levels to your incident triggers and call-in lists means the response grows with the pressure.[24]

For staff, long incidents are exhausting. Synnovis and its aftermath ran for months. Rotas, welfare checks and a clear stand down matter as much as the first alert.

The practical test is simple. If your laboratory system went dark at 08:10 tomorrow, who would declare, how quickly would you know who was coming in, and could every ward get an urgent result on paper?

RECOMMENDATIONS

Seven steps for healthcare providers

In priority order. The first three can start this week.

01 Write declaration triggers

Use the EPRR definitions and wording; name who can declare.[16]

02 Call staff in by role, and confirm

Alerts by role on several channels, with acknowledgement and escalation.

03 Agree an out-of-band channel

Decide how staff talk if email is down or untrusted.[12]

04 Put suppliers on your incident lists

Pathology, imaging, EPR and estates, with joint exercises.[2,8]

05 Practise downtime, including blood

Paper requests, phoned results, O type use and back-entry.[3,7]

06 Link pressure and incident triggers

Tie OPEL levels and heat or cold alerts to your severity ladder.[10,24]

07 Debrief and report on time

Hot debrief within 48 hours, structured within 28 days.[16]

FOR THE BOARD

Questions boards should ask this quarter

Answers should be specific, dated and owned.

READINESS

- ? Who can declare a critical incident tonight, and when did we last test that they would?
- ? How long does it take us to confirm who is coming in after a call-in?
- ? Could every ward get an urgent blood result with no computers?

PARTNERS AND RECOVERY

- ? Which suppliers could stop clinical care, and are they in our incident plans?
- ? Would we know within 72 hours if we had to report a cyber incident, and who would do it?
- ? How do we look after the staff who carry a long incident?

GLOSSARY

Terms used in this report

EPRR
Emergency preparedness, resilience and response: the NHS England framework for incidents and emergencies.

Business continuity incident
Disruption to normal service below acceptable levels that needs special arrangements.

Critical incident
Localised loss of ability to deliver critical services, or risk of harm to patients and staff.

Major incident
An event with serious consequences needing special arrangements by one or more responder agencies.

Core Standards
The minimum EPRR requirements NHS-funded organisations assess themselves against each year.

OPEL
Operational pressures escalation levels, from 1 to 4.

Pathology
Laboratory testing of blood, tissue and other samples.

O negative
The universal donor blood type, used when a patient's blood cannot be matched.

Ransomware
Malicious software that locks or steals data to extort payment.

NIS Regulations
The Network and Information Systems Regulations 2018, which set security and reporting duties for essential services.

DSPT
The Data Security and Protection Toolkit, used to report incidents in health and care.

ICB
Integrated care board, the NHS body that plans and coordinates services across a local area.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Alerting is minute one. Coordination is everything after.

When pathology goes down at 08:10, the alert is minute one. Keeping patients safe depends on who declared what, which staff came in, which downtime procedures started, what partners and patients were told, and a record for the after-action review.

01 · ALERT

Ping

Reach people on push, SMS, voice and email, and track who acknowledged.

02 · COORDINATE

Incident Manager

One workspace and log for the whole team.

03 · EXECUTE

Task Manager

Procedures become owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.

04 · SEE

Control Centre

A live picture of tasks, people, locations and blockers.

05 · PROVE

Audit Trail

A timestamped timeline, ready for the post-incident report.

A MASS NOTIFICATION TOOL	AN OPERATIONAL INCIDENT COORDINATION PLATFORM
Sends a message	Runs the response, from first alert to recovery
Knows the message was delivered	Knows who acknowledged, and escalates silence
Ends when the alert goes out	Follows the incident with tasks, owners and deadlines
Leaves the record in inboxes and chats	Keeps one timestamped timeline you can hand over
Gives leaders a list of recipients	Gives leaders a live picture of what is happening

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. Mass alerting is where it starts, not where it ends.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

How coordinated is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your healthcare organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Clinical, on-call and support staff reached on several channels, at any hour.	0 1 2 3
02 **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Call-in responses tracked, with escalation when key roles stay silent.	0 1 2 3
03 **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Declaration and escalation follow the EPRR framework by role.	0 1 2 3
04 **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by the incident team, clinical leads, partners and communications.	0 1 2 3
05 **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Downtime procedures run as owned tasks in every affected department.	0 1 2 3
06 **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of staff mobilised, services affected and actions outstanding.	0 1 2 3
07 **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that supports EPRR assurance, the ICO and the after-action review.	0 1 2 3
08 **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Exercises that include a cyber attack on clinical systems, not just a major incident.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

YOUR TAILORED DEMONSTRATION

Bring your worst day. We will run it with you.

A 30-minute session built around your own healthcare scenario, not a standard product tour. You leave with a clearer view of your gaps, whether or not you go on to use Crises Control.

BRING A SCENARIO LIKE

01 A cyber attack that takes a clinical system or pathology offline.

02 A major incident that needs staff called in out of hours.

03 A winter pressure or heatwave critical incident across several sites.

WHAT THE 30 MINUTES COVERS

05 min — We agree your scenario and the people involved.

10 min — We run your first hour live: alert, acknowledgement and escalation.

10 min — We turn your procedure into tasks and show the live picture leaders would see.

05 min — We produce the timeline and talk through what it means for your plans.

Request your tailored demo

+44 (0) 20 8584 1385

contactus@crises-control.com

www.crises-control.com

Request a demo

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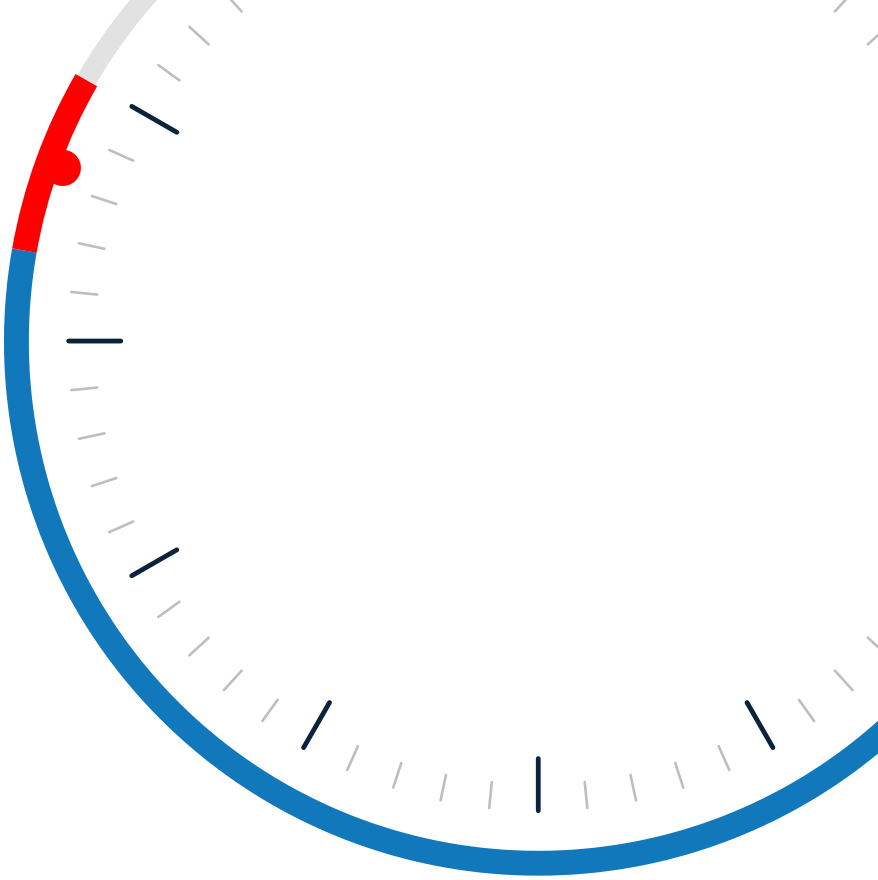
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Ready before the next outage?

Crises Control helps NHS trusts and independent providers call staff in by role, see who has acknowledged, run downtime procedures as tasks and keep a full record for the debrief.

Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**: alert, coordinate, execute, see and prove, in one place.

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PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Crisis playbook No. 06 · Major incident, minute one